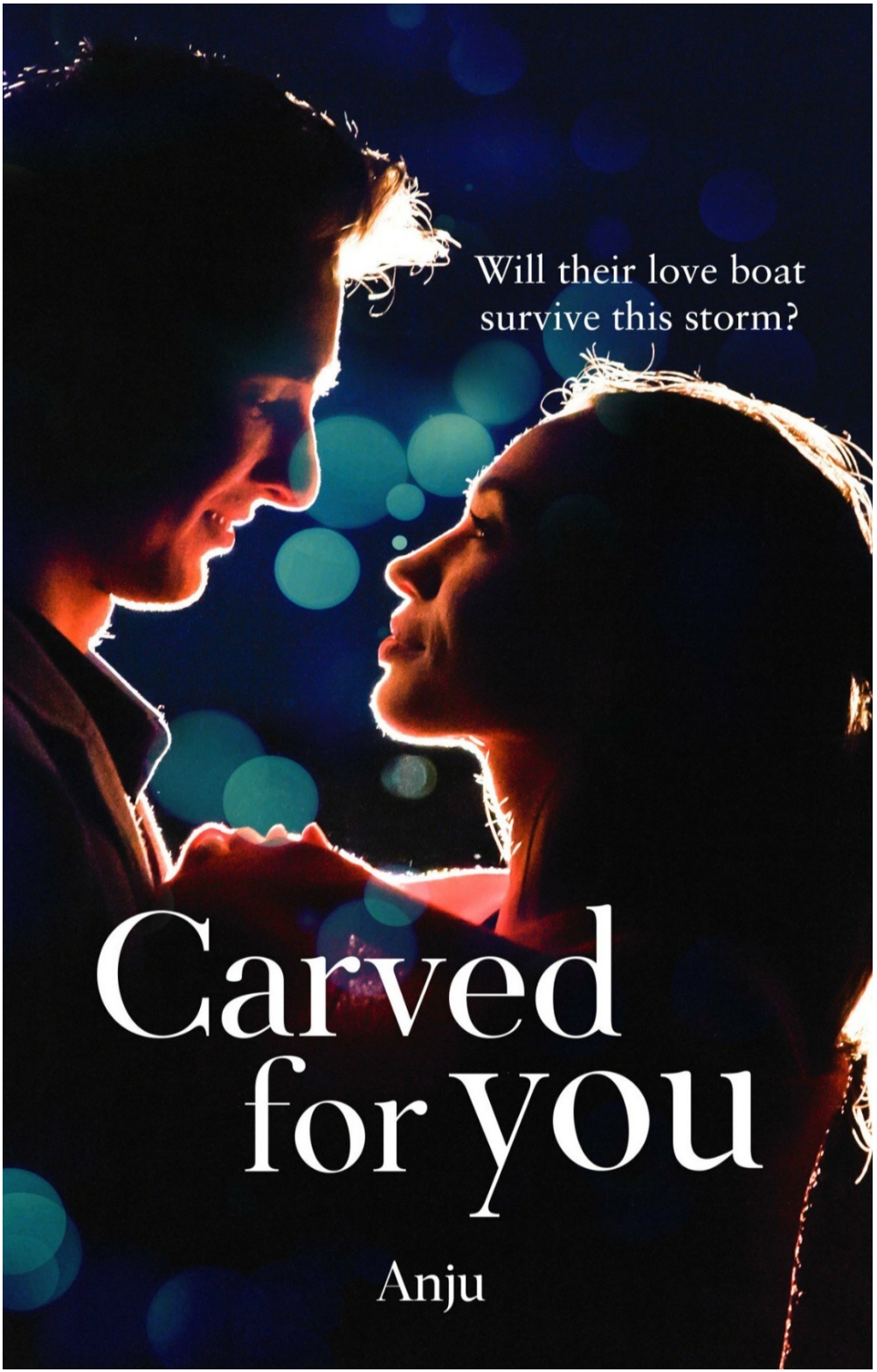
Will their love boat
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Contents

Chapter 1 1
Chapter 2 13
Chapter 3 23
Chapter 4 37
Chapter 5 51
Chapter 6 63
Chapter 7 75
Chapter 8 88
Chapter 9 102
Chapter 10 116
Chapter 11 131
Chapter 12 145
Chapter 13 157
Chapter 14 174
Chapter 15 187
Chapter 16 201
Chapter 17 216
Chapter 18 234

Chapter 1

After a long, troubled effort she was successful in applying kajal to her eyes. Kavya saw her reflection in the mirror; a usual thought occurred to her - `*I wish, I had known a bit about putting makeup and getting dressed. But it's okay...*' She lifted her shoulders smiling back at her reflection in the mirror, wearing a white kurti with peach Patiala and a shaded dupatta to match. She was very fond of wearing jewelry, but with a tight family budget, she could afford only a few. Today she wore her favorite silver earrings and bangles. Added to these were a moon-shaped bindi, half loosely-tied hair that fell in soft curls till her waist, a straight nose, and an oval-shaped face. Despite a perfect figure and fair complexion, Kavya never considered herself pretty. She always preferred 'smart' as a compliment over 'beautiful' in public because she never felt beautiful. She always saw herself as an average girl with average looks. But that was not her reality, she was beautiful within. Somewhere at the back of her mind she always wanted to dress up like other girls and look pretty, but she could never really afford it.

"Kavya, what time do you have the official meeting today?" Kavya usually had a very tight schedule. She had done her graduation in Commerce followed by an MBA in International Business through distance education. She was a topper in both graduation and post-graduation. Kavya could have actually got admission in any college to pursue an MBA, but she chose a

correspondence course as she had to work for a living. After all, who would pay her MBA fees? She had to earn it all by herself. She had quickly climbed the steps in the corporate sector with her soft, cooperative nature and an ultra-sharp mind.

Her mom called out from the kitchen again so Kavya replied, "It's at twelve pm; why, what happened?"

"I wanted you to hand over these gulab jamuns to my old friend."

"Which old friend mom?" Kavya moved toward the kitchen finishing her glass of milk, with her phone in her hand. She knew all her mom's friends because she was one of them.

"Rashmi is in town with Shiv and Aadi. Do you remember Aditya, her son? You two used to be best friends."

Of course, she remembered him. Her mom kept talking and Kavya was lost in her own thoughts. Even as a child, he was someone unforgettable for Kavya. It was almost impossible to separate them from each other when they were young. Aditya was a good person. She could speak her mind to him – unfiltered; but like her father, she lost him when she was in the first year of college. Aadi got a scholarship in the US for his MS. He was five years older to Kavya. Eventually, Aadi's father moved his business to Pune and they lost touch completely. Kavya's mom was in touch with Rashmi and Shiv. Kavya spoke to them once in a blue moon. She avoided them as much as she could. They both loved Kavya a lot. However, she was worried that they might offer her financial help. She avoided that situation as much as she could. When Aditya shifted to the US, she became aloof, she never made close friends later. It wasn't intentional, but it never really clicked. She had a lot of friends and was known as a chatterbox but none could ever reach her soul.

Something inside her lit up every time he saw her. She was too naive and young to understand that feeling. Nonetheless, destiny had its own way.

Her mother shook Kavya out of her reverie. "What happened? Where are you lost?"

"Nothing mom. You were saying something?"

"Yes, Rashmi is back in town for a short while and I am so excited to meet her soon. Please meet Aditya on the highway and hand over this *dabba* (box) to him. Here, take his number."

Her mother handed her a paper and Kavya realized what was happening. "Mom, I am really getting very late. Don't involve such coordination early in the morning, please. Why don't you meet them and give this yourself?"

Her mom laughed and said, "Shh Kavya, calm down. He is on his way, he might be reaching soon. He will meet you at the highway and then will drop you to your office. You won't be late, *beta*. I have already spoken to him."

Now Kavya was annoyed. She rolled her eyes and said, "Mom, how can you tell him without asking me? Why do I have to meet him all of a sudden?" She was thinking, why her mom didn't inform her earlier. '*At least I would have got ready properly. God! Why am I thinking so much? Probably he won't even remember me,*' she thought.

To her surprise, her mom laughed and said, "Come on Kavya, it's just a matter of half an hour's drive and some small talk. You can do it. Just listen to me and go."

'*Strange... very strange*, *it's so unlike mom*,' thought Kavya as she gave up. "Okay, okay, I am going."

She picked up the box of sweets and hugged her mom. Her mom kissed her cheeks, looked at her for a bit longer than she usually would, and smiled. Then, she bid her goodbye. It seemed she was up to something. "Mom, what happened? All okay?"

"Yaa, yaa, all good. Off you go now... you will be late otherwise."

"I am sorry, mom, I got irritated with you. You just took me by surprise." Her mom pulled her cheek saying, "Chill..." Kavya smiled back at her mom and hurried out of the house.

Suddenly, she came back to pick up her bag and walked out again. Her mom raised her eyebrows and wondered, '*It's very unlike Kavya to forget anything... she's way too particular*.'

Kavya walked a few blocks and realized that she had forgotten her phone in the kitchen. Now she was really embarrassed. She

went back and picked up her phone. Her mom held back her hand as she tried to walk out and asked, "What's wrong Kavya, are you okay?" Kavya took a long breath, and said, "Yes, mom. Just… don't know... I mean... meeting Aditya after ages, it's kind of a strange feeling." Her mom smiled back appreciating her honesty. Kavya never hid anything from her mom. She did not know about her feelings, but her mom knew them.

Her mom said, "At times you just need to go with the flow, Kavya. Learn to relax and enjoy the moment, and you never know, Aditya might be a handsome hunk!" Kavya turned red at her mom's comment and mocked her with anger. "Mom! I am not interested in complicating my life right now. We need to focus on making a decent living and I need to focus on my work." Her mom did not comment on this. She knew Kavya was right. After her father's death, both had done everything to make a decent living. However, both knew they were living way below a middle-class life. Month-ends were usually a hand to mouth existence. It was only recently when Kavya had got a good job that they were starting to get financially stable. The only thing that kept her going was Kavya's never-give-up attitude and her smile. Besides, both had Sandhya to look up to. She was in the 1st year of college and was living away from reality. After Kavya's father's death, both of them shared Sandhya's responsibility.

Kavya left home saying to herself, '*Okay darling... it's just a question of fifteen-twenty minutes. Okay, maybe half an hour. Don't overthink, go with the flow.*'

She walked faster than usual and her phone rang on the way. She checked her phone, it was an unknown number. She picked it up.

***

Aditya's dad and Kavya's dad were best friends, that's how Aditya and Kavya became friends. Kavya's father had his own business. An extremely brainy guy with a fun-loving attitude, he was a

go-getter in business. He was known for his far-sighted vision. He tasted success very early in his venture and made a wise decision of early diversification of his business. His only mistake throughout was - he never involved his family in business and always kept both, pressures and decisions, away from them. On one of his tours, Kavya lost him to cardiac arrest and no one knew about his investments and business. His partners raised their hands the moment they realized that the family was as naive as a child and Kavya's mother had zero income.

Nonetheless, the mother and daughter were born fighters. They did not give up and survived against all odds. Aditya's family was the first support Kavya's mother received during that phase. However, they moved on shortly. Hence, both mother and daughter became lonely. Nevertheless, it made them tough, tough enough to survive.

* * *

Kavya was lost in all the memories when her phone buzzed.

"Hello?" "Hey, Kavya! What's up? Aditya this side." It was Aditya. Her heart skipped a beat. "Hi, Aditya! I'm good, thank you. Sorry, I am late. I am on the way already. Will reach in about five minutes." "God, Kavya, calm down. You are talking so much." She felt a hint of a smile on Aditya's face. "Chill Manu. I am across the road, I can see you. Just across the road." Manu... Her childhood name. After her father, Aditya was the last guy to call her by that name. Lots of emotions started bursting inside her.

She didn't know what to say. She just remained quiet, looked around and saw him leaning against his car. Aditya was one fine sight with his six-two height, lean but toned body, deep honey-colored eyes with brown hair like his mother's. But the best part was his smile. He could move the world with that smile.

He made every girl's head turn at least once. If not for the family business and his God-gifted ability, he would have done

fantastic as a model. What more - he knew it! Nonetheless, he never carried an attitude or ego for his looks, which made him all the more smart and desirable. Kavya was observing him while crossing the road. He was wearing a simple black t-shirt with blue jeans. His soft hair rummaged in the wind. He disconnected the call and waved back at her with a smile. At that moment, her entire childhood ran through her mind. Memories of them being together, their happy times… Aditya shifting abroad for studies… Her missing him a lot… Kavya quietly crossed the road thinking in her mind, '*Don't cry... don't cry... don't cry*.'

"Hi! Manu..." The world froze at that moment. Both were speechless and engrossed looking at each other. Aditya came to his senses when he heard cars honking from behind. He realized his car was right in the middle of the road. Aditya quickly went to the other side of the car and opened it for her. He was a thorough gentleman.

When other cars started honking, both realized they were stuck in the middle of the road. Kavya turned crimson on realizing she was staring at him and started looking outside. She cleared her throat and responded.

"Hi, Aditya, I am doing well. How are you? In Mumbai for some work?"

"Naah… I came here to see you."

This made Kavya smile… She thought he was kidding and started making fun of him. "Yeah sure… *Aur kuch*? How is Pune?"

"Pune *main mann nahi lagta yaar*, you are not around." This time she could not hold herself back and landed in tears, but she quickly managed to turn her face to the other side and wiped them off. She hoped Aadi would not notice, but he did. He chose not to mention it to her and asked, "Hey, what happened?"

"Nothing, something went into my eyes."

She quickly composed herself and asked, "So how is Kalpana Industries doing?" Kalpana Industries was his father's venture

of a clothing brand which had made its mark in both national and international markets. Aditya had recently joined his father after completing his masters in IB.

"It's going fantastic. Do you know, we are also planning to launch a new range of winter collection soon? We have recently got an offer from a German brand to join hands."

"That's fantastic! I do follow companies' social media posts… I feel, in India, if you do more of realistic cuts and patterns, it will have a superb impact."

"Manu, our brand is used by a different league of people; they need offbeat stuff."

"I get it, create a separate brand for the masses. Or rather, buy out 'Yellow'. I read it in last week's newspaper, they are looking for equity investors. It's a pretty popular brand amongst the youngsters today. It's trendy and value for money," she casually said opening a box of sweets.

Aditya loved the idea and also realized her zeal and passion for work. She could do wonders in their company. Even without a B-school degree, she was way too bright for a mediocre job. He was hoping discussions would go smooth. She could be a part of Kalpana Industries soon!

"Hello! Where are you lost?" Kavya asked Aadi. He ran his fingers through his hair messing them up and smiled, "Nothing, just… gone with the wind!" It was his habit to mess up his hair since childhood and Kavya always brought them back in shape. With a natural instinct, she raised her hand to shape his hair but stopped. '*We are not kids anymore*,' she thought and pulled her hand back offering the box of sweets instead, to Aadi.

Aditya noticed her hesitation and said, "Manu, I am still your childhood friend and you can still put my hair back." She just smiled and said, "I know. Here… eat this."

Gulab Jamuns were Aditya's weakness, especially those made by Kavita Aunty - Kavya's mother.

"I don't want to mess my hands, please feed me."

Kavya lifted one Gulab Jamun and put it in his mouth.

"Ummm…. Heaven!"

To this, Kavya smiled and said, "Can you drop me to my office, please? It's not very far. If you are getting late, I can go, no problem."

"Can't you skip the office today? Let's just roam around the city. Mumbai has changed a lot in these years. You can take me to some new food joints around."

"I would love to… but I have a critical meeting to handle; can't skip it."

"Umm… How about the evening? I can come and pick you up and then we can go out."

"Not too sure, honestly…. But I will call you if I get free early. Okay?" She tried being as sweet and normal as possible. She was getting attracted to him, but for some strange reason, it was pushing her all the more away from him. Right now, she could not afford any kind of distraction.

Aditya knew her too well to let it go unnoticed. He just shrugged his shoulders and said, "Okay. We are about to reach your office. You want to eat anything before you go?"

"No, I actually need to go and prepare for the meeting."

"Hmmm… someone is working really hard it seems." He laughed sideways, which featured the dimple on his cheek.

However, Kavya was too occupied to notice it, she was engrossed in her own thoughts. "Yeah, some people actually need to work for a living." This got Aadi's attention. "Chill babe, it's just a phase and it will end very soon."

Kavya smiled on his optimism. "Turn right from this signal."

"Okies. So, you will be home, late, is it?"

"Haha… You are asking as if you will be waiting for me back home." She gave him a soft push on the shoulder, the effect of which he extrapolated and exaggerated by pretending to fall over the other side. "Ouch! What are you doing girl?" And now Kavya laughed openly showing her perfect, white teeth. Her head tilted back a bit and her hair flowed like a river with the wind. It was just the perfect sight.

Aadi could watch her for the rest of his life like this. '*A few more hours to go*,' he thought.

Kavya reached her office, took a deep breath, and looked at Aadi. She was too emotional to say anything so she just waved at him and moved her lips enacting to say 'bye' without actually saying it. Aadi smiled and said, "Bye, Manu." At that very moment, she realized her feelings for Aditya. It was not just friendship, it was more… much more… She loved him. She opened her mouth to say something, but let it go and moved out of the car. She kept telling herself, 'don't turn back Kavya, you will cry…' She kept saying this to herself and almost rushed into her office building.

Kavya went directly to the washroom and washed her face multiple times. Her heart was thumping loudly. It was a very strong wave of emotion that had hit her. Something she had avoided to confess to herself for many years… today, watching him again made her remember every emotion she had felt when Aadi left for the US. Now she understood why it hurt her so much. This was because it was not friendship, it was love that she missed. Nonetheless, she gathered herself up and immediately came back to the work zone as if nothing had happened. She had done this multiple times before - whenever there was a financial crisis, when she was emotionally drained of all the pressure and hectic schedule, and so many times when she really missed Aadi. Today was a bit different. She met him; she accepted her own emotions, and this pang of emotions was making her restless. '*But no time for all this, Kavya. You need to keep your focus on work*,' she told herself firmly.

She quickly went back to her desk as if everything was cool. She switched on her laptop and opened the inbox sipping a cup of hot black coffee. She inhaled the aroma of the coffee beans and smiled with closed eyes. '*Just perfect. It's going to be a perfect day*.'

Kavya went through her presentation one last time and made a few notes before instructing the IT team to set the presentation. She went to the ladies' room to touch up and directly headed to the conference room for the presentation. Kavya was absolutely a go-getter in client meetings and her

seniors were always amazed by her confidence with which she negotiated deals. Even though not from an IT background, her way of presenting made everyone feel she knew her stuff very well.

She waited in the conference room with poise, detailing everything for the meeting beforehand. She asked for a specific brand of tea, which she had tasted at the client's office, and changed the decor flowers to blue orchids as she had noticed the client usually wore blue. Prakash, Kavya's boss noticed her work from a distance and smiled. He trusted her completely.

Rajeev Malhotra was a tough nut to crack. He was well over six feet and very broad. His jet black eyes were like a scanner as if he could read through people's mind. Rajeev spoke very less and hardly trusted people. To top it all, he was well-known for taking decisions in one shot, which meant - Kavya had only one chance to convince him.

Rajeev came along with his team and Kavya welcomed them with a firm handshake and a warm smile. Rajeev returned an equally firm handshake, observing the blue orchids. "Nice selection of flowers, Ms. Kavya," he said smiling leaving Prakash surprised. Kavya just smiled back and thanked him for the compliment.

She offered them tea and coffee; to which Rajeev opted for tea. She had already instructed the admin team about tea. They brought it right on time. Kavya made Mr. Rajeev's tea herself with two drops of sugar-free sweetener. Rajeev's eyebrows raised on this. "How do you know I have the sugar-free sweetener and not sugar?"

"Well, I observe, sir. After all, we must know our clients to serve them better."

Rajeev was impressed but decided to keep it to himself. He took a sip and tasted the same brand he usually had in his office. Now he could not hold back the smile. He raised the cup a bit towards Kavya, in appreciation, before keeping it down.

She felt satisfied. The meeting started on a good note. She swiftly brought the discussion to the topic and started the

presentation. She started with full confidence as if she herself was the developer of the solution, reinforcing every detail which was customized for the client. Her detailing never ceased to amaze her clients.

The meeting lasted for exactly two hours as planned when she kept her pointer down and looked at the audience.

"Any questions?" she asked. Rajeev could not ask a single question. She had detailed and clarified everything brilliantly and ensured that every point Rajeev had raised in the previous meeting was addressed in her presentation. Rajeev replied, "No, that will be all for today. My team will get in touch with you all about the payment terms and implementation plan."

Kavya smiled at his words warmly. "Sure! That would be great. Shall I offer you something to eat? Sandwiches?"

"No. I would like to have a word with you in private."

Before she could blink her eyes, Rajeev's team moved out of the conference room. Taking that as a cue, Kavya's team moved out of the conference room quietly too. Kavya sat across the table, calm and composed. "Yes, Mr. Rajeev?"

"Ms. Kavya, I am impressed with your eye for detailing. It's a rare art. Would you like to join my company and look into the implementation of this software?"

This was no surprise to Kavya. 7 on 10 clients ended up offering a job. She was used to it by now, but loyalty meant a lot to her. She said, "Thank you so much for the offer, Mr. Rajeev; it means a lot. However, this company stood by me when I needed a job the most. Now I wish to stand by them when I am tasting success. I hope you understand."

"This makes me respect you more, Ms. Kavya. SV Tech is lucky to have a resource like you." He got up and offered his hand for a handshake. Kavya got up along and made a firm handshake thanking him again for his gesture.

In the next five minutes, Rajeev and his team left and Kavya took a long breath with a smile. She had a smile like an excited teenager on her face as if she had won a race. Everyone came to congratulate her.

She looked at her boss with a puppy face. "I know this look, Kavya. I'm just ordering your double cheeseburger." On this, she giggled like a kid. When she was about to give her 1st presentation, Prakash and Kavya had a bet. If she wins the client's consent, Prakash would treat the whole office with a double cheeseburger party, but if she lost the client, she would cook a cake at home for everyone and bring it the next day. Kavya was an excellent cook and the team used to look forward to her special delicacies. She often used to bake cakes for her teammates' birthdays. However, since her 1st presentation, she had lost only 2 clients. Rest of the time, it became a ritual for Prakash to throw a small party to everyone on success. His team worked hard and he knew it.

Chapter 2

After dropping Kavya, Aadi could not come out of her thoughts. He was now waiting for the evening. However, he had work to do so he drove back home. Aadi was usually full of energy and somewhat restless. He had a habit of ringing the doorbell multiple times until someone opened it, and whistling songs as he roamed around the house. Today he did not do all this and his parents understood it was the effect of meeting Kavya. They hammered him with questions - "How's she?" "Been ages we saw her!" "Does she still giggle like the old days?"

"Mom, Dad… Chill! Let me at least change and come back."

"No, tell us now. We are so happy and excited about your decision. We can't wait to go and meet Kavita and ask for her daughter's hand for you."

"Well, what can I say? She is beautiful… much more than what I thought she would be. I could not tell her anything. We just generally spoke and I came back."

His parents laughed. "We knew this is what will happen. Good. We will get a chance to officially talk to her."

"But mom, I am worried. She seems too focused on her work. What if she says no?"

Aadi's mom held his face in her hand and said, "We know why she is saying no for the marriage. Your dad is going to talk to her. Don't worry, everything will be fine. I have seen her

face when you moved from India. I know deep down she loves you too."

Aadi just nodded and said, "I will be back." He kept coffee for brewing and went to the balcony. He was gazing at the view of the city but was lost in his own world. He could clearly remember their childhood. That naughty, carefree Kavya who feared nothing and no one except her father. She was always an apple of everyone's eyes. Kavya's dad and Aditya's dad were best buddies and used to meet almost every day, which in turn made both Aadi and Kavya spend almost all evenings together.

She was a mess as a child and always used to tumble… and Aadi used to help her put everything together again. Kavya had her favorite doll; she named it 'Lola'. She never liked skinny dolls. Lola was like her - Chubby and Cute. Aadi used to tease her saying, "A fat doll for fat Kavya," and she used to go running behind him to beat him. Aadi loved teasing Kavya and she was easy to irritate. Eventually, she would end up crying and everyone came to her rescue. When Aadi used to get a good scolding for this, she would still take his side! Aadi smiled even now, remembering her cry. Then she would wipe her tears by the back of her hand while holding the other hand of Aadi and go back to play. He unknowingly raised his hand to hold her hand but realized it was just a memory trail.

He smiled a bit more, which highlighted the perfect dimple on his right cheek. His hair blew smoothly with the wind and covered his eyes. He ran his hand through his hair and went inside.

'*Come on, Aditya. It's gonna be a long day. Let's finish work before you get lost in her thoughts once again.*'

He quickly went to his room and opened his laptop. '*23 unread emails! I am gonna need another cup of coffee.*' He connected his Bluetooth headphone and called his assistant Esha.

"Morning Esha, what's the schedule for today?"

Esha read out the schedule from the other side of the call to which Aadi replied, "No, keep the contract on hold with

Mr. Parker; I need to know their consent to our revised terms first. Ask Jatin to follow up on this case. What's the status of the report I asked you to consolidate?"

He nodded as she updated him.

"Fantastic. I would like to review it once I am back to Pune."

He paused as Esha confirmed his dates.

"No, I am going to take longer here."

She asked if he needed the minutes of the meeting. He replied, "Yes, send me those, I'll go through the points."

His call went on for almost an hour when he tried to catch up with work as fast as he could. He brewed fresh coffee while talking to her and went back to his study table.

"Ask Jatin to call me, I have a new venture in mind. I want him to study that and remind me about this once I am back to the office. Also, if we get the consent of Mr. Parker, set up a meeting with their team to take this forward. That will be all for now. Call me once you catch up with this work."

He was curt when it came to business. Howsoever soft he was at heart, he never allowed it to come in between his work. When Aadi joined his father's business and started taking over the responsibilities, people showered love and blessings on him the way they loved his father as both of them had strikingly similar nature – Like father, like son. However, they had seen Aadi coming to office with his dad as a kid and thus, many times ended up taking him for granted, unknowingly. Aadi never took their comments in the wrong way and never left any opportunity to thank his father for the inheritance he got from him. He was a gentleman inside out and a very down to earth person. Nevertheless, to justify his designation of MD, it was important that people took him seriously and he had no option but to stay strong and less emotional in front of his employees.

And it did wonders. People actually started seeing Aadi for the knowledge he brought on the table. In less than 2 years, Aadi took over a majority of his father's work and his dad started reducing his trips to the office. By now, his dad came to office only once or twice a week to meet and greet people. Shiv,

Aadi's father had built this empire with a lot of love. He was known for his empathy and love for his employees. He never treated them as his employees. For him, it was one big family. People loved him and they continued to shower the same love on Aadi.

Aadi got lost in reading emails and reviewing documents. He looked at his watch, it was a quarter to two and he was hungry. His mom knew by now not to disturb him while he was working and that's why she did not call him to have lunch with them. He went to the kitchen. "Mom, I am hungry." They were not in their Pune house and thus, there was only one maid at home. It was a novelty for Aadi as he was used to watching multiple helpers around. Aadi and his family had come here after many years and were not used to the simple lifestyle now. Time had passed quickly and with the business gearing up, their standard of living changed drastically. However, Aadi enjoyed both lives - The simple one, as well as lavish.

Rashmi, Aadi's mother looked at him fondly and said, "Sit, I will serve food to my son today. Their maid came running saying, "Bhabi, I will do it." Rashmi said no and insisted to serve him today. Aadi smiled and sat at the dining table. Rashmi had made his favorite tawa-fry okra vegetable with roti and served him with Gulab Jamun. Aadi looked at the dessert and remembered Kavya again. Meanwhile, Rashmi noticed her son and laughed. "A few more hours my son, and you will meet her again." Aadi smiled and looked away, "Mommmm, please…"

Rashmi laughed harder and turned to the kitchen counter to make roti for him. Alongside she called Shiv, "Shiv, come and see your son turning into a tomato!" Shiv came from the bedroom and joined at the table. "Oh yes, Rashu, you are right! What's on your cheeks Aadi?" Now Aadi was smiling openly. "Stop it you two… oh my God, if this is the situation today, just imagine what will happen when the marriage is fixed." Now it was getting a bit too much for Aadi. He was very shy when it came to Kavya. She was the softest nerve of his body and he could never openly express his feelings about her to anyone. It

was his father who got Kavya's photos from his cupboard and cabin. He made Aadi sit and dragged a confession out of him that he loved her. Rashmi and Shiv were on seventh heaven when they got to know about his feelings. They loved Kavya and always missed not having a girl child when Aadi and Kavya were young. Now, Kavya would officially be their daughter.

Aadi tried getting up from the lunch table to hide his face, but his father held his hand and made him sit. Their lunchtime was usually this crazy since they got to know about Aadi's feelings. All three of them were secretly waiting for Kavya to complete the family.

When Shiv and Rashmi got to know about Aadi's feelings, Rashmi immediately called Kavita, Kavya's mother, and put the phone on loudspeaker. Kavita was in tears when she spoke to them. Kavita always used to be worried about Kavya's future. She was working way too hard and Kavita was feeling bad that she was not able to help her much. Sandhya, her younger daughter and Kavya's younger sister, was as bright as Kavya and thus, Kavya was determined to let her study as much as she wanted to. Sandhya was now doing engineering and Kavya took it on her to pay all the fees and look after her. In the process of settling the house and taking care of her sister, Kavya had been working like a machine. It was scary, sad, and most importantly, full of guilt for Kavita. Kavita was not much educated, and so could not help Kavya much in earning.

After years, Kavita spoke her heart out with Shiv and Rashmi. She missed them; she missed their emotional support. Rashmi felt very bad. Rashmi and Kavita used to be very close friends and used to share everything. But Shiv's business picked up pace and Rashmi got occupied in supporting him and looking after Aadi. She forgot to look back and help Kavita in tough times.

Kavita told them that Kavya was not willing to get married right now because she and Sandhya were financially dependent on Kavya. Her family was her pride and she would never compromise it for anything on earth. Shiv heard it and smiled. Like father, like daughter; full of self-respect and zeal. He

asked Kavita not to worry at all. "We all will come to meet her. If she likes Aadi, leave it to me to convince her. Just don't tell her anything before I meet her."

Kavita said, "I know she misses Aadi for sure." Shiv raised his eyebrow, smiled, and asked, "How do you know it?"

"Her cupboard has Aadi's photos. I have seen her watching those photos multiple times when I am not around. I tried bringing it up, but she avoids the topic saying 'we are no match, mom. Look at him; look at me. Look at their financials and ours. I wish him all the best in life and hope he gets the best of all worlds'."

Rashmi hugged Shiv and tears of happiness started to fall. It was the happiest call of their life. They told all this to Aadi and in less than one week, they were in Mumbai to speak to Kavya.

Even after knowing everything, Aadi was restless. He knew he won't feel any better till he heard a 'yes' from Kavya. He decided to get back to work after lunch so that time would pass faster. However, it was an effort in vain. He plugged in his headphones and started listening to songs. "Everything I do…. I just do it for you…" - Apt song for the movement. He got lost in her thoughts once again. He was feeling very nervous, happy, and excited all at the same time. The emotion was too much to cope with. And finally, he went to his father, his rescuer, his best buddy in such situations.

"Dad…"

"Yes, champ? Why you look so glum?

"Dad, She will say yes, right?"

Shiv smiled. "Yes, son. It might not be easy though; so don't expect 'yes' in the first meeting. We will have to convince her to let us take care of Kavita and Sandhya. She is a girl with very high respect for herself as well as her family. We don't want to hurt her self-esteem, do we?"

"No, you are right… But she did not say anything to me in the morning like she missed me or anything. She was normal."

Shiv asked, "Did you tell her that you missed her?"

"No… I mean not in these many words."

"Then how can she tell you?"

This made Aadi think. "She cried when I was talking to her. Did I hurt her?"

Shiv raised his eyebrow and had a naughty smile on his face, "Aag dono taraf barabar lagi hai!"

Aadi smiled and said, "C'mon dad… I am serious."

"Beta, girls cry when they can't handle their emotions. That means either she really missed you a lot or she was way too happy to see you."

"Hmm… maybe you are right. I just hope everything goes well."

Aadi usually got ready quickly. He was very organized. He had already planned the clothes to wear - navy blue open collar blazer with a plain white shirt. Not very formal, not very casual. But even after spending almost half an hour in front of the mirror in an effort of trying to set his hair, he was not feeling convinced. His mom saw him from the door of the room and laughed before she went to their bedroom. Shiv was getting ready too. "How do I look, sweetheart?"

"Shhh…" she said, "come here quietly." Shiv got confused and followed her. They went towards Aadi's room and hid behind the door watching their son's hair drama.

As Aadi took the jar of hair gel in his hand, Shiv said, "Do one thing, dip your head in it instead of applying it so many times!" Shiv and Rashmi laughed as Aadi realized they had been watching him for quite some time and felt embarrassed.

"What yaar? Give me some privacy, go get ready…" he literally pushed them both out. Rashmi told him, "Don't be so conscious beta, you look as smart as always." On this, Shiv patted his shoulder and said, "Get ready fast and come to the living room, I need to talk to you."

"What happened, dad? All okay?"

"Yeah, all fine… just need to talk to you generally on today's meeting strategy," said Shiv as he winked. Aadi smiled showing off his perfect white teeth and nodded saying, "Yeah, dad. Give me ten minutes."

Aadi quickly went back to his room and looked into the mirror one last time to see if everything was perfect. '*Today is going to be the best day of your life*,' he said to himself as he picked up his jacket and came to the living room. Shiv and Rashmi were waiting for him to join. Shiv was twinning with his son in a blue shirt with a white jacket. Rashmi chose a very simple pearl colored Punjabi dress with pearl jewelry. Aadi sat with them and said, "Yes, dad. So, what's the plan?"

"We have already spoken to Kavita and everything is all set. We will be there before Kavya comes back from office. We will spend some quality time with them and then talk to her."

"But dad…"

"Listen, Aadi. This is a very sensitive situation. I understand your feelings, but it's going to be very intimidating for her. She is not expecting this at all. Besides, financial issues take you to a different level of insecurities in life. Kavya has been through a lot for her age. It's only now that they are managing to meet both ends. This is going to be a very difficult decision for her."

"Dad, I feel very sad that I was not there for her in this tough time."

"I understand, Aadi, but we were there. Trust me, she is a tough girl. Rashmi tried approaching Kavita multiple times to offer help. Both mother and daughter denied taking any help. It's really rare nowadays to see people with such strong ethics. I am proud of her. But now you need to understand that it makes people difficult. It's as if she is wearing a strong shield over her heart so that she cannot feel any emotions right now. We are going to take time to break through this. It's not going to happen in one go. We need to take it slow. Let us slowly make her open to the concept of getting married first, then we will cross the bridge when we reach there… okay?"

Aadi nodded in agreement and said, "Maybe you are right." There was a long silence in the room. Rashmi broke the silence and said, "C'mon, let's go. I am dying to meet my daughter." On this, both Shiv and Aadi smiled and got up.

Kavya had a long day at work, but it was nothing unusual for her. On average, she worked 12-14 hours a day. After the meeting, she reviewed the leads current status report and shortlisted clients to target in the near future. She needed at least 2 big clients in this quarter to achieve the incentive amount she was counting on. There was no time to rest for her. She quickly got back to work after the office burger party and started calling the prospective clients. Her peers used to tease her as desk-worm because she never spent time with anyone around. This was not the real her; she would have loved being light-hearted like others and enjoy her life, but she had to stay on her toes to ensure being the top performer who gets max incentives.

She made calls to multiple clients and scheduled meetings with them. She generated reports, reviewed her team's performance, and called meetings to motivate them on targets and to solve their issues and queries. It was well past seven when she realized that she was still on the burger she had earlier and had missed her lunch as usual. She had lost almost three pounds in the last two months due to skipping meals. Even her boss used to worry at times. Whenever he was around and free during lunchtime, he used to come and shut her laptop directly to make her go for lunch. She used to skip leaving her seat and had a quick bite at her desk so that she could resume work immediately.

Kavya sent her final report for the day, shut her laptop, and gave a good, long stretch to her arms. Her bones made some crackling sounds complaining her of her long sitting hours without any break. She winced with pain slightly and straightened up. She looked around and the office was empty. Only Prakash's cabin lights were on. She quickly bid him goodbye and left for home.

She remembered Aditya's offer to meet in the evening. '*No Kavya, of course not. He said it for the sake of it. Don't get any ideas*.' She quietly walked towards the bus stop while plugging in her headphones. Kenny G - Instrumental. '*Yes… this should do*.' She always heard instrumental music. It helped her sleep

and forget the world and all worries for that half an hour's journey.

She got on a bus. It was packed as usual, but she managed to board it. She greeted the conductor like every day and gave her pass for scanning. The conductor swiftly pointed his eyes towards a gentleman two seats behind. This meant he was going to get down sooner than any other passengers and she could grab a seat. Kavya moved her lips as if saying thank you and smiled. She went and stood next to his seat. As expected, he got down after two stops and Kavya sat there. She was his regular passenger. She was usually drained out after the day's work and so the conductor used to guide her to passengers who would get down sooner.

She was about to fall asleep thinking of Aadi when suddenly her phone vibrated on receipt of a message.

"Wassup girl?"

It was Aadi; her heart skipped a beat again. "Nothing much… just got free from work. Now on the way to home." She replied.

She got a reply from Aadi, "Okay…"

'*Strange*,' she thought. '*Okay? That means he generally messaged and did not want to meet me. Thank God I did not call him in the evening to meet*.'

Aditya was already at her house with his mom and dad. Kavya was not aware of this. It was already 7.15 pm and thus, Aadi texted her to check where she had reached

Chapter 3

Kavya got down from the bus and started walking towards home. It was a 15-minute walk from the bus stop to her home, but by the end of the day, it used to feel like a journey of miles. Once in a while, Kavya used to pamper herself by opting for a shared auto, which she could afford only once or twice a month.

She was too tempted to take it today but decided to walk. '*The entire month is yet to go. Save it for later Kavya*,' she convinced herself to not give in to the temptation.

She reached near her house and heard loud, laughing voices. '*Guests? At our house?*' She was surprised. Rarely anyone visited them.

Kavya went inside the house and saw Rashmi, Shiv, and Aadi sitting relaxed. Aadi, sitting at the dining table, was cracking some jokes and making Kavita laugh her heart out. Seeing Kavya enter the house, both Rashmi and Shiv got up to greet her. She walked towards them and Rashmi gave her a long, warm hug running her hand through her hair. Kavya felt a strong emotional wave running through her chest. She had really missed them for so long. Shiv also gave her a warm hug. "How are you, Manu? We missed you." She was almost in tears when Shiv released her. "I am good, uncle. It's so good to see you all," she said trying to control her eyes from watering, in vain. "Been a very long time we all met..."

Shiv held her ear and said, "It's because you keep refusing to come to Pune for vacations. It's hardly three hours distance."

"Can't help uncle, work comes first and who would know it better than you?" Shiv smiled and nodded in agreement.

"Leave all this, what can I get you to eat?" she asked everyone.

"We all are fine, beta. It's been quite a while we all met. We will all go out for dinner after some time. It's my treat for Aadi joining the company," Shiv said.

"Uncle, you should throw a party when he runs it successfully, not for joining," Kavya said teasing Aadi and everyone started laughing. "Oh! Is it so, Kavya?" Aadi came towards her running to hit her and she ran like old days. Everyone started to laugh even more as they both were running around the house. Finally, he got her and twisted her arm. She winced softly, "Aadi, leave me..."

"No, I won't... First, say Aadi is smart," he said twisting her arm.

"Yes, yes, Aadi is smart... Now leave my hand, please."

He left her hand smiling in a mocking way, on winning. Shiv and Rashmi started to scold Aadi, "You are not kids anymore. What are you doing? She might have got hurt."

"No aunty, it's okay, it didn't hurt. He was teasing," Kavya defended Aadi.

'*Just like the old days*,' thought Aadi.

Kavya came and sat next to her mom. Rashmi said, "Come here beta, sit with us." Kavya looked at her mom, confused. Her mom nudged her to go so she went. She sat between Shiv and Rashmi. Surprisingly, she did not feel uncomfortable with them. Something inside her warmed up with Rashmi's touch.

"So Kavya, how is your work going?" Shiv asked. On this, she opened up. "It's going fantastic. Today, I closed one very good deal for my company and have three more prospective clients in the pipeline." Kavya got into the flow of explaining how her work was. Her work was her pride and it was visible in the zeal with which she was explaining everything to everyone

there. Both Shiv and Rashmi were listening to her with full attention and interest.

Aadi lost track of her talks somewhere in between and was just looking at her. Her smile, her way of explaining things from the bottom of her heart… The spark that came on her face while she was talking. She was full of life when she spoke about work. Sandhya, on the other hand, picked at Aadi staring at her sister. By now, she knew the purpose of their visit. Maa had told her everything before they came. She whispered in Aadi's ear, "My sister is beautiful, isn't she?" Unknowingly Aadi said, "Yeah…" and realized Sandhya was teasing her. She burst out laughing and said, "Wait, let me tell everyone what you just said!"

"Shut up Sandhya…" Aadi tried stopping her and she started giggling and running away. He caught her by hand, made a puppy face, and curled his lips saying please as silently as he could. She smiled and whispered in his ear, "Chalo maaf kiya… but you owe me one in future jiju!" Aadi had a very genuine and happy smile on her words and said, "Done!" Kavya and all the others noticed it. She stopped talking and asked, "What happened, Sandhya?"

"Nothing di… just fooling around with Aadi. You continue."

But Kavya's link was broken and she realized she had been talking for way too long. "Sorry, I got into the flow. I hope you guys did not get bored." Shiv smiled fondly and said, "No beta… we love listening to you and I am proud of your achievements. What have you planned for your future?"

"Nothing specific, uncle. Just focusing on one thing at a time. I got promoted last year, so this year it's going to be a tough fight to get it again. But the incentives after this promotion will be good. So, looking forward to it and working hard for it."

"I am talking about life, Kavya. Have you thought about marriage?"

Kavya looked around and turned shy. "Have you thought of marriage Kavya?"

"Oh, aunty, not you too please..." she turned shy and tried rushing into the kitchen, but Rashmi held her hand and said, "Don't run away. I am asking seriously."

"It's too early... I am just settling in my job and I have a very long way to go. Anyway, another cup of coffee? I will make one, I am sure you will like it." Rashmi smiled and nodded. She looked at Aadi asking him indirectly if he would like a cup, he gave her a thumbs up and she smiled and walked towards the kitchen.

Rashmi went behind her. "Beta, what is stopping you from getting married?" Kavya let out a long sigh. "Aunty, you already know our finances. Sandhya is a brilliant girl. I don't want her to compromise on studies due to finances. Mom does have her catering business, but it's not sufficient. How will they survive if I step out of the house? Just now she has taken admission in the first year and now…"

"Shhh, Kavya… relax. So it's about finances, is that the only reason?"

Now Kavya got confused, she never thought beyond this point. She said, "It's a very big reason, aunty… isn't it?"

"Yes, of course, but what if your husband's family allows you to work after marriage and let you support your home as you do now? Will you be open for marriage then?" This made her give a sad smile. "All this happens in stories, not in reality. What if after a few months they deny… where will my mom and sister go?"

"We will cross the bridge when we reach there, Kavya. As I said before, if they allow you to work and support your family financially, will you be open for marriage?"

Kavya took time to think this time and then she replied, "Honestly, I never considered marriage seriously due to this issue." Rashmi smiled at her honesty and said, "Okay, do you like anyone, Kavya? Anyone in your life right now?"

"Haha! What aunty? I don't have time for Sandhya, where will I find time to have an affair? And come on, please, we are meeting after such a long time, why are you so stuck on my

mom's mission to convince me for marriage? Chill, I am happy alone."

"It's because there is a very thin line between being alone and being lonely, dear. We all want only the best for you." She fondly pulled Kavya's cheeks. "I know that Aunty and I really appreciate it."

"Then, shall I take it that you are now open for marriage, Kavya?" She just shrugged her shoulders and said, "If you can find such a filmy-story-like family who will support my career and let me support my family too, I might think about it. Frankly speaking, I don't think anyone will agree to let me give my whole income to my mother, let's be practical. But if it makes you happy to search, okay," she said and gave a naughty smile. She was almost sure such families don't exist and she had won this negotiation just like her client deals. Kavya handed Rashmi a cup of coffee and Rashmi had a happy smile of victory on her face.

As Rashmi went into the kitchen, Shiv moved to the balcony and took out a packet of cigarettes. Aditya joined him there, pulling out a lighter. Both father and son rarely smoked together, but today, they both needed one. That moment was as if they were sharing emotions and tension without words. Kavya and Rashmi came to the balcony with coffee cups in their hands for everyone. Kavya handed a cup to Aadi and Rashmi gave one to Shiv. They looked outside the balcony. The view was not great – Just some more buildings and a kids' garden. It was quite windy in the evenings. Kavya's hair with soft curls blew with the wind and covered her face. This was her favorite spot. After a long day at work, she used to spend some time here, sipping hot coffee. She smiled unknowingly, moving her hair off her face and Aadi skipped a heartbeat at this scene.

'*My son cannot hide his feelings at all*,' Shiv thought and finally broke the silence, "So, Rashmi, you guys took very long in the kitchen."

Rashmi smiled and said, "Yes, I have managed to convince Kavya to at least consider marriage proposals."

"Wow! Congratulations, that's fantastic news." Aadi had a genuine relief along with a small smile on his face. Kavya felt shy and embarrassed. She tried hiding behind Rashmi, "Oh, please! Can we all talk about something else? It's very uncomfortable. Besides, I will not compromise on my conditions. And no one will agree to those, so in a way, Dilli abhi bohot door hai."

Everyone laughed on this Shiv said, "Oh, is that so? Tell me about your conditions and what kind of man you are looking for. I will help you search one."

"Noooo… can we talk something else, please?" Kavya was looking down at her coffee mug and trying her best to change the topic. Aadi smiled, looking at her fondly. Rashmi noticed this and poked him, indirectly asking him to stop staring at Kavya.

"So, till when you all are here?"

"Oh yes, that reminds me, what are you doing this Sunday, Kavya? Shiv asked.

"Well, I might go to the office for some time in the afternoon. Need to file a few papers and have some backlog of work to finish."

"Nonsense! You are coming with us to Alibaugh. We are going for a one-day picnic."

"No uncle, please, Sunday is the only day I get some sleep… I really want to get up late."

She was right, weekdays were usually full of work, meetings and helping mom with her catering business. She hardly got time to sleep, and this clicked an idea in Aadi's mind.

"That can be managed," Aadi said. "I can pick you up late, let everyone else go early." Rashmi jumped in, "That sounds perfect. Then it's final!"

Before Kavya could react, they all started discussing the plan ahead. Rashmi and Shiv went out excited to tell Kavita and Sandhya. They both were equally happy with the picnic plan.

Kavya and Aadi were left alone in the balcony now. "So, marriage on cards haan?" Aadi gave her a naughty smile showing off his perfect dimple. Kavya playfully hit him and

said, "Now you don't get started, please. I said 'yes' to Rashmi aunty only to make them happy. But let's be practical Aditya, no one would want a financial burden of family along with a girl."

"Not necessarily, Kavya… You are absolutely worth it. I am sure there will be many guys who would happily take the responsibility of your family along." This came as a shock to Kavya. She never expected this reaction. She was speechless.

"So what kind of a guy you wish to marry?"

'*Someone like you*,' Kavya thought but did not say. She just smiled and said, "What's the hurry? We'll cross the bridge when we reach there." She shrugged her shoulders and said, "Come, let's go to the living room." She turned to move when Aadi held her hand. Kavya skipped a heartbeat and looked at him. "Let's stay here for some more time, please; it feels so nice here." She just nodded and they stayed back, but there was an awkward silence now. Both had so much to talk but didn't know where to start. Aadi was leaning against the wall, relaxed, and looking at her while sipping coffee.

She realized he was staring at her so she asked him, "What happened?"

He smiled and said, "Nothing," as if coming out of a dream.

"Then why are you looking at me like this?"

"Just…" he shrugged his shoulders and his smile widened.

She felt shy and turned to the other side. "Quit staring," she said and now Aadi laughed. He was enjoying her discomfort and shyness. "Okay, Manu. So, how's life?"

"Nothing much… just routine. Office, house, household work. That's it. How are you taking up your role as the M.D? It must be challenging, isn't it?"

"Yes, it is. At times it's scary. Everyone trusts me a lot. It's a very big responsibility. I want to stand by Dad's and all employees' expectations."

"Don't worry, you will. I am sure."

"How can you be so sure, Manu? We have never worked together."

"That's because you are a good soul Aadi and you will never do anything wrong to anyone."

He smiled, but it did not reach his eyes. "I mean it," she reassured. "I am confident you will far exceed their expectations." This time he nodded and said, "We'll see."

"So, how's Pune… and how's your life?"

"It's as much routine as yours, dear, just work and work. Though I have friends to hang out with over the weekend, I miss you a lot." Kavya looked into his eyes, he meant it. "I… never mind. Give me your cup." She was about to say 'I miss you too' but held back her words half-way.

She moved towards him to take his cup. Their hands slightly brushed each other as she took the cup from him. A spark went through both of them and they looked at each other. Aadi softly held her hand, and then released it. She turned all red with this small gesture of his and quickly moved out of the balcony before Aadi could notice her face. He smiled. He was looking forward to Sunday now.

The evening was all laughter and chit-chat followed by dinner. Aadi's family went home in a few hours and Kavya was cleaning the kitchen when Sandhya popped up helping her with washing the plates. "Aadi is damn smart, isn't it Di?" Kavya just said, "Hmm…" Sandhya raised her eyebrows. It was very rare Kavya agreed to her so silently. "Didi, you both are childhood friends… just friends, or more?"

"Sandhya!" Kavya said with mocking anger, "Shut up. We were just friends, nothing more." "You are very sad Didi. If I would have been you…" Kavya went behind her to give her soft push before Sandhya could complete her sentence. "Shut up, Sandhya!" Sandhya started giggling, "You like him, di, don't you?"

"Sandhya, shut up!" Kavya smacked her softly, turning red on her comment.

"Maa…" Sandhya started to say something as if she would tell this to their mom when Kavya started running behind her.

"Sandhya! I will kill you. Shut up." They both were running across the house and Kavita started laughing. "Okay, okay, girls… now go to sleep. Tomorrow is a working day, don't forget. Sandhya, you have an early morning lecture tomorrow. Go to bed now." Sandhya said yes while giggling and went inside.

Kavya went along with her. Kavya went to bed with Aditya's thoughts. She was not able to forget his smiling face. Just then, her phone vibrated. She saw her phone, it was Aadi.

The message read - "Looking forward to Sunday…"

Kavya was too tempted to send 'me too…' but she opted to send a normal smiley.

She got a smiley back and "Can't sleep?"

"Yeah, kind of."

"Me too! Wish it was Sunday tomorrow, but we both have to work tomorrow… Gn dear."

"Good Night."

Kavya was trying to get a grip on her life. '*What an eventful day it was! When I got up this morning, everything was normal. But suddenly, Aditya is back in my life… out of nowhere, Rashmi Aunty and Shiv uncle came; marriage talks… and now this Sunday outing. It's all too much to cope up with and it's moving too fast.*' Secretly, even she was looking forward to Sunday. However, all these sudden events were making her restless. She was not sure if she should be happy or worried. Actually, she was not really used to being happy anymore.

She went to office earlier than her usual time. She had parked quite an amount of work for Sunday, which she had to finish today so that she could enjoy the picnic. She started working at a war front covering as much work as possible on the day. Before she realized, it was lunch time and she got a call from the reception. "You have a visitor." '*Visitor? Strange*.' She checked her diary for any appointments, but there were none. She quickly went to the reception to see Aditya waiting there with a takeaway parcel. "Oh! Hi, how come you are here?"

"I was in this area for a meeting so thought of joining you for lunch. I hope that's okay, Manu?" The receptionist raised her

eyebrow on the mention of Kavya's childhood name 'Manu'. She was looking at Kavya with a puppy face to get herself introduced. Kavya looked at Aditya and said, "Sure, thank you. Aditya, meet Jane - my friend and our receptionist. Jane, this is Aditya, my childhood friend."

"It's pleasure to meet you, Aditya," She said offering her hand for a handshake. Aditya shook hand confidently and smiled. "Likewise," he replied. Jane was practically melting with a simple handshake. Kavya got both jealous and annoyed. She looked at Aditya and said, "Shall we?"

"Yeah, sure," he replied as he realized her jealousy and enjoyed the moment. Kavya took him to the canteen and asked him to wait a couple of minutes as she brought her.

They exchanged small talks of Kavya's work profile over the lunch table. Many people in the office were looking at them in the canteen. Aadi observed it and asked Kavya, "Why everyone seems to notice us so much?"

Kavya just smiled and replied, "One, they have never seen me with any guy in this office. Two, I rarely come here for lunch. I usually either eat alone on the desk or skip it."

"Don't you have friends here in the office?"

"I do have, but I don't really have time to hang out with them to chit-chat. The workload is quite high."

"You loved making friends, Manu."

"Manu had time and energy, Aadi. Kavya here does not have both."

"Hmm, and why no lunch?"

"To maintain the figure!" Kavya tried to joke.

"Haha, but it was not funny Kavya. No matter how sexy figure you have, I won't approve starvation. Not done. Promise me you will eat regularly."

Kavya laughed, "Me and sexy? Yeah, right, Aadi."

"Why? Don't u feel beautiful? You are a total babe, darling."

Kavya got embarrassed at his comments. Of all the people, Aadi found her sexy and beautiful. She still thought Aadi was

joking and decided to go with the flow, "Oh, yes, Aadi… so you think I am beautiful, haan?"

"Yes, Kavya. I think you are the most beautiful woman I have ever met." For a moment, both got lost in each other's eyes forgetting the whole world around. They got a reality check when Kavya's boss came to the table and cleared his throat. Kavya realized and got up quickly.

"Sit, sit… So, Kavya, introduce us to your childhood friend." It came as no surprise to Kavya; Jane had a very big mouth. She was almost sure by now the whole office would know Aadi has come to meet her and he is her childhood friend. She said, "Yes, sure Sir. This is Aadi, I mean Aditya… my friend. Aditya, this is Prakash Sir, my boss." Aditya got up and gave a confident handshake. "Pleasure meeting you, Prakash."

"By any chance are you Aditya Joshi… Shiv Joshi's son?"

"Yes," Aditya said smiling. His father was a very well-known figure and Aditya was becoming famous day by day. It's a pleasure meeting you Mr. Aditya. Please carry on. I don't mean to disturb you," he said winking. Kavya was surprised, it was very rare of Prakash to wink or react like this. Aditya nodded politely and said, "Why don't you join us."

"No, no… It's good to see Kavya eating. She rarely eats nowadays, please carry on."

Aditya frowned a bit as Prakash left, and sat again. Kavya said, "Alright. I am done."

"That's it? You hardly ate four spoons Kavya."

"Look Aadi, I am really not used to having lunch."

"This is really not good. Tomorrow onwards I am going to check on you every day to ensure you have your lunch," he said, finishing the last bite from Kavya's tiffin. She loved watching him eat. He still ate like a child. His love for food was visible in his eyes.

Kavya came to see off Aditya to the door. "So, what time do you get up on Sundays, lazy bones?

"Well, there is no time really. But I will get up early tomorrow. Can you pick me around 'tennish'?"

"Tenishhh?" Aditya said, exaggerating her tone and nodding in agreement with a smile. By now, half the office was curious about whom Kavya was talking to.

"Okay honey, see you tomorrow."

'*Honey? What is wrong with him? Beautiful, honey…*' Kavya never expected these words from Aadi for her. She shook her head and turned around to go back to the office. Half of her team was standing behind with smiling faces and lots of questions in their eyes about Aditya.

"Who was he? Is he your boyfriend? God… please tell me, no. He is so hot!"

"Shut up, Ramya! We are just good friends, nothing more."

"Where is he taking you tomorrow? Are you guys going for a date?"

"Noo… God! What is wrong with you all? We are family friends, we are going for a one-day outing with our families. So please relax and look at the time. Lunch time is already over. C'mon, let's get back to work."

Everyone was teasing Kavya and she was literally pushing everyone back to the office when her phone buzzed.

"I had a great time… thanks!"

Kavya smiled and replied, "My Pleasure…. Looks like you have a fan club in my office."

"Haha…. I am just interested in 1 girl in that office," Aadi replied with a winking smiley.

Kavya was shocked. '*Interested in one girl? Is he referring to me? Of course, you stupid girl…*' her subconscious snapped her back. '*He is just kidding. Don't get ambitious.*' She thought and got back to work.

The day ended very late for her as she was taking off the next day. She looked at her phone, it was 11:30 pm with 5 missed calls. 2 from her mother, 1 from Sandhya, and 2 from Aditya. She checked her messages, dozens of them mentioned worrying about her not responding to calls or messages. She let out a tired sigh. '*Alright… I will catch up with the remaining work on Monday. It's time to go home.*' She wound up her work and

walked out of office, greeting the security guard. It was nothing new for the security also to see her go so late. He greeted her back and closed the office.

Kavya had missed her last bus and now she had to walk for 15 minutes to reach the auto stand. It was a completely deserted road, but it was a shortcut. The other road was from a local market, but that used to take almost 5-10 minutes of extra walk. Kavya avoided this road as much as she could, but today she was too tired to walk even this much. She was literally dragging herself to home, way too tired for this walk at this odd hour. Suddenly, Kavya felt as if someone was following her. She stopped in the middle of the road but was too scared to look back. After a small pause, she resumed walking and again got the same odd sensation as if someone was following her. This time she turned back but saw no one. This was not the first time she felt this way. She had felt it multiple times in the past when she went home late from work, but she never told anyone. Kavya did not want her mother to worry. Besides, she might restrict her from working late. So, she kept it to herself. She started walking faster to reach her destination quickly and now she could clearly hear a crunching sound of leather shoes following her.

She quickly took out her phone and tried reaching Sandhya just to keep her mind distracted, but Sandhya did not pick her call. The next number on the Missed calls list was Aditya's. Without thinking, she called him.

"Hey, up so late? All okay?"

"Hi, I just saw your missed call, so thought of calling you back."

"Just saw? Are you still at work? "

"No, no, I left some time back."

"Why are you sounding as if you are out of breath? Where are you?"

"I am just walking fast," she said. By now she was almost out of breath, but she was too scared to stop.

"Manu, what is wrong? Should I come to pick you up?"

"No, No, I am fine, don't worry. Okay, I'm disconnecting the call, will see you tomorrow."

Aditya paused and then said, "Alright. See you tomorrow."

She reached the auto stand and saw a few autos. She felt relieved to see people and decided to look back. However, as usual, she could not find anyone. She got into an auto and instructed him to take it to Sion–Kelkar road. He started the auto and Kavya relaxed.

She checked her phone, there was a message from Aditya.

"I hope you are okay, you were not sounding normal."

"I am fine… In auto now. Was just tired, nothing else, don't worry."

She was too tempted to tell him the truth, but why unnecessarily complicate things. She decided to keep it to herself. She reached her building and looked up. Kavita was waiting for her in the balcony. When she saw Kavya getting down from the auto, she visibly relaxed and went inside.

As soon as Kavita opened the door for Kavya, she started her complaints, "Is this the time to come home, Kavya? Why only you have to sit back so late? The city is becoming so risky, why can't your company arrange for a drop?" She kept talking in the background. This was routine. Kavya was used to coming late from work regularly and was also used to mom's scolding. She quickly changed and thought of relaxing a bit before coming out for dinner, but ended up dozing off.

Mom came to Kavya's room and saw her sleeping. For a moment, she felt like waking her up for food, but she knew the way Kavya worked. So, she just adjusted the pillow and the quilt, switched off the lights, and came out.

'I hope everything works out well and she says 'yes' to marry Aditya. Can't see her slogging so much,' Kavita thought.

Chapter 4

Kavita and Sandhya left early morning the next day with Shiv and Rashmi in their car. Aditya had come in his own car to pick Kavya. She was still sleeping. Kavita had told him that Kavya had skipped dinner. So, Aditya decided to make breakfast for her. He went to the kitchen and opened the fridge. Eggs, perfect. He made Omelets and Toast bread. It was ten past nine so he decided to wake her up else they would be terribly late to reach Alibaug. As much as he was tempted to chuck the entire plan and spend the day only with Kavya, he knew he had to be patient.

"Hey, lazy bones… get up," Aditya said, sitting on a chair near her bed. Kavya smiled stretching her arms and turned on the other side. She thought she was dreaming. "C'mon Manu, it's almost nine-thirty, we need to leave. Mom and dad are about to reach already. Now she realized he was actually there. '*Oh shit! How long has he been here*?' She quickly got up pulling her quilt along with her knees.

"Good morning… sorry to keep you waiting."

"No problem! Now come out fast, I have made breakfast for you."

She was surprised, "You know how to cook?"

'*God! When will I get used to seeing him*?'

Aditya smiled. "I have stayed away from the house long enough to learn cooking, Manu… Now get up."

She smiled and said, "Yes, you go ahead, I will join you in a minute." Aditya raised his right eyebrow and asked, "Why aren't you coming out of bed right now?"

She was in her nightwear… Bunny nightwear, and was too embarrassed to come out of the quilt in front of him in her childish outfit. "It's nothing, you please go ahead and I will come."

He got the clue and pretended to leave. "Okay, okay… but come quickly."

He stepped out and Kavya removed her quilt folding it. Aditya popped in from the door and burst out laughing. "I saw you! It's kinda cute, darling."

"Adityaaa…" Kavya picked up a pillow and ran behind him to hit him. He ran away laughing. Kavya quickly got him and started hitting, but he held her hands saying, "Why someone is feeling shy? I have seen you in bunny clothes before, you always look cute in this, Manu." Kavya backed off. She ran her left hand through her hair which had messed up and come over her face, blocking her view. Aditya released her hand and folded it. She walked backward and said, "I will be back in ten minutes."

She directly went for a shower and quickly came out of it. Kavya loved outings but never really got time. She was wearing her favorite and the only blue denim she had with a white top. She tied her hair in a high ponytail and wore big, round earrings. She applied Kajal and some lip balm and quickly came out with her handbag.

"Not bad!" Aditya said looking at his watch, "from Bunny PJ's to ready in less than fifteen minutes. I am impressed." Kavya felt shy again at the mention of her nightwear. She joined him at the dining table, "Oh please Aditya, I am sure you were something equally funny. You used to wear Spiderman nightwear when we were kids."

Aditya smiled and said, "Yeah, I still have a similar one," and winked. Kavya skipped a heartbeat every time she saw Aditya laughing or at times, even when she just saw him. This

is not going to help Kavya. *'Don't fall for him so hard that you cannot turn and walk back. Just take it easy.'*

She was lost in her own thoughts when Aadi shook her chair, "O' hello? Where are you lost?" She quickly recovered and changed the topic immediately. "This omelet is perfect. Mine never turns out this fluffy. What did you do?"

"Magic!" he said, "Whenever you want to eat a fluffy omelet, just call me; I will come and make one for you." She gave him a weak smile but did not say anything. Even after skipping her dinner, she was not able to finish her breakfast. Aditya realized what she was about to say, but he interrupted even before she could say it, "Nothing doing Kavya, you need to finish this. Kavita Aunty told me you skipped dinner yesterday. We are not leaving until you empty your plate. Eat quickly, meanwhile, I will make hot chocolate milk."

"Please don't prepare milk, I will finish this. I won't be able to have both."

"Of course you will have both. Look at yourself, you are fading in front of me. I won't allow this. Promise me you will eat properly, Kavya." She smiled looking in his eyes.

"I promise. I usually don't eat breakfast, Aadi, so it's a good start, isn't it? Now please don't push me for milk."

"Okay…" he said. She quickly finished her breakfast and cleared the plates. She picked up her bag and said, "Shall we leave?"

"Yes!" he replied excitedly and they both left home together. Aditya opened the door of the car for her. Kavya softly went inside the car. Aditya then swiftly went to the driver's seat.

This is not the same car that you picked me up last time.

Yeah, both are Audi, but this is a two-seater."

Kavya raised her eyebrows and nodded. She was a bit intimidated by the entire thing but chose not to say anything. Aditya was observing this and decided to change the topic.

"Play some songs, unless you are planning to sing, Manu," Aditya said giving a smile sideways. Kavya mocked him. "Haha, very funny." She started her attempts to understand the system

to play music and finally looked at Aadi with a sigh. He said, "Here, go to this menu…" their hands brushed each other softly and a shiver went down Kavya's spine. She pulled her hand back. Aditya felt the same wave rushing through him, but he did not react. He played a romantic number by Bryan Adams – 'Everything I do'. Both of them looked at each other, then Kavya looked away because she was worried. Her emotions for Aditya were clearly visible on her face.

Aditya held her hand and started driving swiftly. She gasped at the touch of his hand and said, "Aadi…"

"Hmmm?"

"Nothing…" She could not say anything and softly struggled to release her hand from his. She saw a hint of a smile on Aditya's face. "What happened, Kavya… you were saying something?"

"Aadi… what are you doing?

"What am I doing, Kavya?"

She opened her mouth to say something… but closed it again. Aditya looked at her playfully raising his eyebrows and smiled. She gave up. Her face had turned bright red. Aditya was slowly running his fingers over her hand. With his simple gesture, Kavya was almost in a different world. She was not able to think straight. Even Aditya was finding it difficult to control his own emotions so he let go of her hand and softly asked her, "I think you had a very long day at work yesterday."

Kavya was mentally not there at all. She did not hear it. She was in her own world. Aditya called her again, "Manu…" which brought her back to reality.

"Hmm?" she said and looked at him innocently and Aditya skipped a heartbeat. '*How can someone be so simple and beautiful?*' He quickly got a grip on himself and asked again, "You had a long day yesterday?"

"Yeah, but that's usual."

He was not happy to hear that. "Why? What's the usual time you leave work?"

"Around ten," Kavya said casually.

"What? And how do you travel back home?"

"I walk to the auto stand and come home by auto."

"Do you always get an auto immediately?"

"Goddd! Aditya, you are so bossy. I am not a kid anymore."

"That's the point, Kavya. A beautiful girl like you traveling alone at night. Is it really that safe?"

She got hung on the word 'beautiful' and did not answer.

"What happened Kavya?"

'*Do you think I am beautiful?*' she was thinking it but ended up saying it out loud unknowingly.

"Of course you are! You are one of the most beautiful girls I have ever seen. Don't you feel beautiful?"

"Nothing, it just came out wrong," she tried changing the topic. "The city is safe, don't worry."

"Don't try to change the topic, Manu. Don't you feel you are beautiful?"

She gave out a long sigh and took a pause before speaking up, "I don't know Aadi. I mean, look at other girls of my age, and look at me. At times I feel I dress like my mom and feel as if I am of her age only."

"It's called elegance dear, and it's beautiful. Besides, beauty is not what you wear; beauty is who you are, and trust me, you are beautiful inside out."

She almost had tears in her eyes. No one had really told her she was beautiful in such clear words ever before. She just said, "Thank you, Aadi."

He pulled the car aside when he saw her face, and halted. "Hey!" Aadi held her face in both his hands and asked, "Are you okay, Manu?" She just nodded. He wiped a tear with his thumb and said, "I mean what I said, Manu," and kissed her forehead. He wanted to propose her at that very moment. He paused a bit longer and released her face. Silence became a bit odd so he decided to bring the car back on the road and started driving.

He changed the songs to more light-mood songs. "We should reach in another forty minutes. Let's halt and eat something." They halted at a roadside restaurant and she ordered black

coffee. Aditya opted for a regular coffee with toast sandwich. You should eat something, Kavya."

"No, I am fine…"

"Okay, will share the sandwich," he said simply.

Aditya saw a family nearby with a young couple playing with a kid and smiled. He looked at Kavya and she was looking at them as well. "So, Manu, I am sure your marriage topic will come out again today. What kind of a guy are you looking for?"

"Oh please Aadi, give me a break. Maa is already behind me for marriage for many months. Now you don't get started. In fact, I should ask you, what are your plans? You are now twenty-nine, settled nicely… are you not considering marriage?"

"Hmm… Why don't you look for a girl for me? Of all people, you know me the most. What you think, what kind of a girl I should marry?"

Kavya smiled and started talking, "Yours is a very simple family like mine. I think you should marry a very simple, beautiful girl who will respect you and respect your parents. A fun-loving, chill girl… what you think?"

"So, you mean someone like you," Aadi said looking into her eyes, sipping his coffee without breaking the eye contact. Kavya got embarrassed. She did not realize unknowingly she had described herself as a prospective bride for Aditya. She turned bright red and looked down. "No, I mean…" Aditya raised her face with his right hand to make her look at him. "You mean?" Aditya asked. She quickly removed his hand and tried to look the other side. "Let's talk something else."

Aditya laid back in his chair and smiled. "We both know what is happening, Kavya. It's just that I am admitting my feelings openly and you are not. Let us see till when you manage to pull it off."

Kavya was shocked at his words, she was speechless. '*If this is not a confession of his feelings, then what is?*' She didn't know how to react. Aditya saw her confusion and smiled a bit more, showing off his dimple. Kavya picked her coffee mug and realized it was finished. She kept it down and looked at

Aditya who was still looking at her. 'Shall we go?" she asked. "Whatever you say, princess," Aditya said. They both got up and went to the car.

For a long time, they both traveled in silence. Aadi wanted to give her time to digest what he had just confessed. When the highway was over and the landscape was lush green on both sides of the road, Aditya switched off the AC and opened all windows and the top of the car. Kavya was not aware it was a convertible and looked at Aditya who just looked back and smiled. "It's beautiful out here, isn't it?" She nodded enjoying the wind. Her hair flew freely with air. She was about to tie them when Aditya stopped her. "Let them be open today, Manu, you look beautiful like this."

Kavya looked down giving a shy smile and nodded. She slowly started opening up and opened her arms moving them out of the window with the wind. Since the time Aditya had met her back, for the first time, he saw that carefree, relaxed smile on her face. He played 'what a wonderful world' by Kenny G and she smiled further. It was their favorite song. Both of them started singing along with the tune.

They reached the farmhouse humming songs. Aditya parked the car and Kavya jumped out of it quickly. After a long time, she was feeling so relaxed. She quickly looked back and Aditya joined her. Everyone was inside having lunch. Aditya and Kavya freshened up and joined everyone at the lunch table. Shiv and Rashmi looked at each other when Aditya and Kavya sat next to each other. Rashmi whispered in Shiv's ear, "Our family feels complete now, Shiv." Shiv nodded with a smile.

After lunch, Shiv, Rashmi, and Kavita opted to take a round of the nearby farms, while Sandhya, Kavya, and Aditya decided to chill at their farmhouse itself. They played some board games and Sandhya dozed off in some time. Kavya made coffee for herself and Aditya. They both sat on the patio. Kavya hugged her cup with both her hands, smelled her coffee, and smiled, "Perfect." Aditya smiled looking at her.

Kavya looked around and said, "It's a beautiful place. When did you guys buy this?"

"It looks beautiful and complete today as you are here, Kavya. It's been a few years we bought this, but it felt like this place was waiting for you to blossom up."

Kavya felt shy at his comment and tried to hide her face behind the coffee mug. "Do you come here often?"

"I wish to come here often with you," Aditya said, laying back in the chair not breaking the eye contact with Kavya.

"Uff, please Aadi. I am observing since morning what you are up to. You are behaving… I don't know… It's just not… I don't know what to say."

Aditya smiled at her. He came forward and kept his cup on the coffee table. He raised his hand towards Kavya asking for her hand. She looked at him, confused. "Do you trust me?" he asked. Kavya nodded.

"Then give me your hand."

Kavya was almost trembling when she gave her hand in Aditya's hand. She felt the same spark running through her like this morning and she closed her eyes to absorb the moment. Aditya was holding her hand with both his hands and said, "Now I am going to ask you a few questions, and I want you to answer them very honestly. Okay?"

"What's going on?" she asked, confused with this sudden conversation and tried to pull back her hand.

Aditya pulled it back saying, "Relax… You trust me, right?" he asked again.

She hesitantly nodded again.

"Kavya, we were best friends as kids, but the day I left for studies, that moment when I went away from you, I realized I felt more for you. Much more than just being friends… I love you. But all these years, I was quiet because we both were too young… Too young to take a step ahead, and think of a future together."

Kavya tried speaking, but Aditya interrupted her, "Please let me talk Manu. It has taken a lot of courage and rehearsal to

speak this out in front of you. I have never seen a girl like you. So simple, full of life… You have been through a lot in all these years and yet not even once have I seen you complaining or falling apart with hardships. I met you after many years, and trust me, watching you today makes me respect you and fall for you even more." Aditya left her hand and put it in his pocket to take out a ring. He sat on his knees and opened the box. "I want to spend the rest of my life with you, Kavya. Will you marry me?"

By now, tears started rolling over Kavya's cheeks. She was so full of emotions that she was completely chocked to say anything.

Aditya sat back in his chair, keeping the box aside. He covered her face with his hands and started wiping her tears. "Baby, please don't cry. It twists my heart to see you cry. I mean… what I want to say, baby, will you marry me? I promise you, I will take care of Sandhya and Kavita aunty like my own sister and mother. You won't have to worry about anything. I have waited for long enough for this day to come. Life will be perfect."

Aditya was about to talk a bit more when Kavya raised her finger and kept on his mouth. She looked in his eyes and said, "Yes."

"You mean yes… yes?" She smiled and looked down. Aditya raised her face with his hands. He was not able to believe what he had just heard. "Kavya, look at me." She tried to free her face from his hands and he smiled. "Manu…" She finally looked in his eyes again. "Will you marry me?" She held his hands with hers and said, "Yes, Aadi."

Aditya had tears of happiness in his eyes. She softly wiped his tears. Aadi opened a box and took out the ring.

"Wait…" She said and Aditya skipped a heartbeat. "What happened Manu?"

"We will need Mom's permission, I don't know how she will feel. Until a few days back, whenever she asked me about marriage, I said no outright. And now, suddenly, this… And

what your mom and dad will think? We are no match, Aadi… Our finances…"

"Shhh… Manu… everyone knows that I was planning to propose to you. Our families are with us. And why do you feel we are no match? We are a perfect match. Finances cannot define relations." Kavya nodded. "We all were just waiting for your 'yes'," Aditya said smiling while putting the ring on her finger. She was stunned by the big, white rock on her finger and got lost looking at it. The ring was a bit loose. She took her hand closer to have a look at it. Aditya was watching her. "Beautiful…"

"Yeah, the ring is very beautiful," she said. Aditya laughed, "No Manu, I was talking about you. You look beautiful." She smiled and looked at him. She realized what he just told her.

"Wait a minute… You mean, my mom, Sandhya, your parents… everyone knows about this? Since when all this is going on? Why no one told me anything?"

"We came to Mumbai with the intent to propose to you for marriage, Manu. But when my mom called your mom, aunty told us that you didn't want to marry so soon. I wanted to be sure you don't have anyone in your life right now or there was no other reason than family to say 'no' for marriage. So we all decided to take it slow. But I could not resist for long and ended up proposing you today. Aditya said smiling.

Kavya nodded. She did not know what to say. They both sat on the patio in silence listening to the birds' hum. Aditya was feeling relaxed after ages. The girl of his dream had finally said 'yes'. This was the best movement of his life.

Kavya heard Sandhya's voice calling her from inside the house and got up to move inside. She took her cup and bent forward to pick up Aadi's cup. He reached for it at the same moment to pick it up and took her hand. "Aadi…" Kavya tried to get her hand free. He took out the cup from her hand and held her hand softly kissing it. She looked away. Aditya whispered in her ear, "Get used to it baby," and she smiled looking down. "Come, let's give the good news to Sandhya."

She nodded and went inside hand in hand with Aditya. Sandhya saw them both and raised her eyebrow. She looked at Aadi and he nodded smiling. She ran in Kavya's arms giving her a tight hug and they both fell down on the sofa. "Sandhya, go slow," Kavya said. "I am sooo happy for you, di. I was waiting for this since so long." She kissed Kavya on her cheeks and hugged her again. Both sisters had tears of happiness in their eyes. "Hey, hey. Do you girls cry so often? I guess I will need some time to get used to all this," Aditya said. Sandhya looked at him and released Kavya and hugged him. "You better take good care of my sister, Aadi."

"I fully intend to," Aadi said looking at Kavya.

Sandhya was jumping in the entire house and called mom. "Mom, where are you?"

"We are around. Why? What happened?"

Aditya signaled her not to tell anything over the phone. He wanted to tell them in person.

"Nothing mom, come home soon."

"Okay, we should be home in fifteen-twenty minutes. We are on our way back. We need to travel back. Pack your bag and wind up the kitchen," Kavita said.

"Yeah mom, just come soon."

Sandhya jumped, "Mom coming in fifteen minutes. I am so excited!" she said jumping once again. Kavya and Aadi looked at each other. Kavya turned shy once again and looked away. Sandhya went inside to pack her bag.

"Aditya…"

"Hmm?"

"How are you planning to tell our parents?"

"Tell our parents what?" Aditya said playfully.

"This…" she said, pointing at her ring.

"C'mon Kavya, don't be so coy. We will do it together, okay?"

"Oh… I don't think I will be able to face them. It's enough difficult to face you and Sandhya right now."

Aditya laughed and raised her face to make her look at him. "Is it?" She looked away and Aditya turned her face again.

"Aadi, you are being playful on one hand and here I am… I don't know what to do."

They heard the door lock opening sound and Kavya lost the color of her face. Aditya laughed harder looking at her. "Just relax, baby. I will do it."

"I am going inside, let me close the kitchen. I have a lot of work."

Aadi tried stopping her, but she got her hand released and ran inside.

Shiv entered the living room and saw Kavya running to the kitchen. He looked at Aadi, "What happened?" Aditya smiled and walked towards his father and hugged him. Then, he told him, "She said yes, dad."

"What? When did you propose? That's big news!" Shiv hugged him back tightly. Rashmi and Kavita walked inside and saw father and son. "What happened?" Rashmi asked Shiv.

Rashmi, "Kavita… Kavya said 'yes'." Kavita instantly had tears in her eyes. Rashmi hugged her. "Come, let's meet our daughter."

Kavya was in the kitchen with Sandhya. Sandhya was talking all the crap in this world to make Kavya feel shy. They both were winding up the plates and food. She saw her mom and Rashmi coming and turned to the other side. They both entered the kitchen. Kavita raised Kavya's face and asked, "Is that true?" Kavya nodded and hugged her. Both of them started crying again.

"We still have time for farewell," Rashmi said and they both smiled. Kavita released Kavya and Rashmi hugged her. "I have been waiting for this day, beta. I can't tell you how happy I am," Kavya hugged her back.

Rashmi took out a box of sweets and said, "Come to the living room, let us enjoy this happy moment together." Kavya took mom's hand in hers and asked, "Mom, I am sorry."

"Sorry for what?"

"No… I said 'yes' without taking your permission."

"You are mad, Kavya. I am very happy with your choice. There cannot be a better match for you than Aadi." Kavya visibly relaxed on her mother's comment and smiled.

Kavita whispered in Kavya's ear, "Besides, I know you loved him. You have his photos in your cupboard, which you used to see. Did you tell him that?" Kavita asked playfully. "Oh, no, mom! Please don't tell him this. I am not ready yet." Kavita laughed.

Shiv came into the kitchen by then. Kavya saw him and looked down. Shiv hugged her, "Congratulations beta." Kavya hugged him back. "Thank you, uncle."

"Don't call me uncle now. Call me dad," Shiv said.

Kavya had tears rolling down her cheeks again. Shiv also had tears in his eyes remembering Kavya's father. '*Wish he was here*…' he thought. He pulled her hand and said, "Come with me, I want to see how my son looks with his future wife. Come on Kavita, Sandhya… come outside."

They all went out to the living room. Aditya was with his mother. They both stood up as Kavya came out. Shiv made her sit on the sofa and instructed Aditya to sit next to her. Rashmi opened a box of sweets and offered it to both of them. They both touched the feet of the elders to take their blessings. The forever of togetherness was about to start now.

They all reached back to town late at night. Kavya was quieter than usual. What difference can one week make? She was still struggling to believe what was happening in her life. Aditya… who was her childhood crush until a few days back was now her fiancé. Sandhya, on the other hand, was jumping around the entire house planning Kavya and Aditya's marriage. Sandhya was one pampered and spoiled kid. Kavya never let her get a reality check even after they lost their dad. Kavya, in a way, took over her responsibility. She was determined to not let Sandhya feel or miss anything in life. She tried giving her everything she missed during her college days. But Sandhya was wise enough to see how much her sister was stretching herself

to make both ends meet. She ensured of not crossing any lines or demanding anything which Kavya and her mom could not afford. Sandhya was full of gratitude and never took her sister's hard work for granted. Every day she prayed to God for the happiness of her big sister. Her wishes and prayers had turned true today.

Chapter 5

Kavya's phone vibrated. It was Aditya. She picked up the call.

"Hello…"

"Hi…"

There was a long pause. Both of them didn't know what to speak ahead.

"Thank you for saying 'yes', Kavya, it means a lot to me. I love you."

"Thank you, Aditya." That's all she managed as a reply. She wanted to tell him how much she loved him, but she was too short of words to talk to him right now.

"Say something Kavya."

"I don't know what to say Aadi. This is all so sudden. I am still trying to catch up."

"Hmm… I understand. Actually, mom and dad are planning to call Kavita aunty in some time to invite you all to our place for dinner tomorrow."

"Oh! What's the occasion?"

Aditya smiled, "To plan our wedding ahead, Kavya."

"Oh…" she said and kept quiet again.

"I am so looking forward to it, Manu." By now Kavya had started thinking all the finances of the wedding in her mind. She had not planned it anytime soon and thus, the budget was going to be a big constraint for her.

"Aadi, we need to talk something before we take this ahead."

"What Manu?"

"Look, don't take me wrong, but I was not expecting a marriage any time soon. Financially, I am not ready for this marriage at all."

"Manu, relax. We will handle it…"

"No Aditya, I cannot let you spend everything. It's a matter of my family's self-esteem too."

"Okay, okay, we will share the expenses, and we will get married whenever you are ready. Okay?"

"Hmm…"

"And say…"

"Say what?"

"Well, to begin with, say you love me!"

"Aaddiii…"

"What Aadi? C'mon Manu, say it once."

"I can't, I feel shy."

"Okay, say I…"

"I"

"Say 'Love'"

Kavya started giggling.

"C'mon, say it…"

"I will, but not right now."

"Okay sweetheart, good night. See you tomorrow."

"Good night, Aadi."

Kavya kept the phone down. Sandhya and Kavita had already gone to sleep. She looked at the watch, it was 11:30 pm. '*Go to sleep Kavya, you have a working day tomorrow*,' she told herself.

Kavya got ready and went to the office earlier than her usual time. She had her ring on the finger and was secretly hoping no one would notice it, else it will be a long list of questions and teasing. She quickly went to the washroom and saw her reflection in the mirror. Her cheeks seemed red, eyes were brighter. '*What difference one day can make!*' She remembered all the events of yesterday and felt shy. She smiled and left the washroom.

Slowly people started coming to the office. Jane halted by her desk and asked her if she would join for a coffee. Kavya agreed and they both started walking when Jane asked her, "So, how was your weekend?"

"It was nice," Kavya said smiling, tugging a string of hair below her ear.

Jane raised her eyebrow, "Why do I feel it was more than nice? Did you meet that dude again? What's his name?"

"His name is Aditya… yes, we went to his farmhouse with the family."

"And?"

"And what? Nothing…" Kavya tried to hide her face. She turned to the other side to get the mug for coffee.

"C'mon Kavya, I have been waiting since long for you to date someone, don't hide from me now."

"Oh Jane…" Kavya tried to change the topic when Jane noticed a ring on Kavya's finger.

"Wait a minute! What's that? Oh shit! Are you…?"

"Shhh… please keep quiet."

"Are you engaged?"

"Yes…"

"O M G…." Jane started jumping in happiness.

"Shhh, Jane, please keep quiet."

"Nonsense, this is big news; everyone must know idiot!"

"Everyone…" Jane went on the floor, by now Kavya was too shy to even come out. Jane literally pulled her out from the pantry area.

"Attention, please… This shy little smart girl from our office is finally taken." She declared raising Kavya's hand in the air, showing off her finger.

Everybody started clapping and cheering. They all gathered around Kavya to congratulate her. Prakash was surprised and for a moment could not react to it at all, but eventually, joined everyone in congratulating her.

"You took us by surprise, Kavya," Prakash said shaking hands with her. Kavya smiled and nodded. He held her hand a

bit longer than usual which made her uncomfortable. She finally rescued her hand from his. Prakash gave her a tight smile and walked off. Jane raised her eyebrow and whispered in Kavya's ear, "He looked like someone stole his puppy."

"Oh shut up Jane, maybe it's just that I might leave the job soon and his work will get hampered."

Jane smiled, "You really think so sweetheart? I know men better than you. Let's have a bet; this irritation was more to do with losing you than work."

Kavya pushed her softly and said, "C'mon big mouth, let's get back to work."

"Yeah, I know… but I want to know the full story during lunch break."

Kavya's day went in a jiffy with work and all the chatter, teasing going around her. Aditya kept buzzing her periodically which made her day.

She started winding up sharp at 6:00 pm as she had to go to Aditya's place for dinner. She wanted to get ready properly. Sandhya was going to help her with makeup today. She was about to leave when she heard the same leather soul crunching sound, which she had heard while going home late last night. '*Must be a coincidence*,' she thought and walked out of the office.

Kavya wore a simple Maroon colored sari with a cream colored border, open hair, and very basic makeup. Sandhya had a good hand on makeup. But Kavya never really allowed her to experiment on her face. Today was an exception.

Kavya looked in the mirror and could not believe her own reflection. "You look beautiful, di. Aditya is going to be flat today," Sandhya said giggling. Kavita came and nudged Sandhya, "Call him Jiju now; you can't keep calling him by his name."

Kavya felt shy with the entire conversation, "Oh come on, you two. Please don't get started." The three of them and Sandhya's phone rang. It was Aditya.

"Hello, Jiju…"

Aditya smiled, "I like my new name."

"Wassup… Can't wait to meet my sister? She looks killer today."

Kavya softly punched Sandhya in mockingly.

"Ouccchhh…" Sandhya overacted and said, "See Jiju, your would-be wife is hitting me."

"Sandhya…" shouted Kavya.

"Okay, okay, we are leaving now. Bye, bye."

She kept the phone down and ran as she saw Kavya was running behind her to hit her.

Kavita stopped both of them and told Kavya, "You are not a kid anymore, don't do all this now."

"But mom," she started but was cut by her mom, "Shhh… don't argue with me. Aditya has sent a car, it's downstairs. Come, let's go."

Kavya's phone vibrated with a message from Aditya, "What are you wearing? Can't wait to meet you."

Kavya sent him smiley asking him the same question, "What are you wearing?"

He sent the same smiley back, "See you in some time!"

Kavya smiled at her phone and joined Kavita and Sandhya in their conversation.

Rashmi and Shiv were on their toes for welcoming their would-be daughter-in-law. The entire house was decorated with flowers to welcome her. Rashmi was wearing a heavy designer blue sari. Shiv was twinning with her in a blue blazer. Aditya was wearing a white shirt with a grey blazer and a trouser. He was visibly relaxed as they were all set waiting for them to join.

Kavya entered the house with her family. Aditya saw her. He was too stunned to say anything. She looked like a dream. He was just standing in the middle of the room while everyone else sat.

Shiv realized it and softly patted his shoulder to make him come back to his senses. Aditya quickly recovered and sat on the sofa across the room.

The housemaids served them all with delicacies cooked specially for today. Everyone insisted Aditya to sit next to Kavya so that they could take pictures of them together and see how they looked. Kavya was hardly talking. She was not even able to look at Aditya. Something like butterflies fluttered inside her every time she saw him. She was avoiding eye contact as much as she could and that was extremely appealing for Aditya. It was making her irresistible for Aadi.

Rashmi came out with a gift and a sweet box. She completed the ritual and gifted her a Sari. She fed her the sweets to officially take her as her daughter-in-law. Kavita did the same with Aditya. Rashmi realized they both were not able to talk and told Aditya, "Why don't you show her our house and leave us alone to take ahead the marriage preparations."

Kavya said, "Aunty… I mean mummy, I wanted to say something."

"Yes, beta?"

"Aunty, we are not financially prepared right now for the wedding."

Shiv interrupted, "You are like a daughter we never had, Kavya."

"Uncle, please let me complete…"

"No Kavya, this time you will have to let me talk first. Do you know, your father had helped me professionally to set up this business?"

This was news to her. "No…," she said.

"Well, that's the fact. When I had hit a rough patch in my company, your dad stood by me like a brother. He helped me with his business contacts with whom I am still doing business. Before I could give anything back to him, we lost him. I tried giving it back to both you and Kavita, but you never took anything. Today, wherever my company has reached, your dad has a big share in that. The least I can do is take care of his daughter's wedding who is now my daughter too. Will you please let me do at least this much? If you think I am your father, then you won't say no."

Kavya landed in tears again and nodded. Shiv came and hugged her. "I wish your dad was alive today, Kavya, he would have been so happy."

"Come on dad, don't make my girl cry so much. She has agreed now, you guys take ahead the discussion. Let me show her around."

Shiv punched him, "Don't make stories. Tell me upfront you want some privacy." Everyone laughed while Kavya hid her face in Shiv's coat. Shiv released her from his arms and said, "Go ahead, I hope you like this house. Although we will be staying in our Pune house, this is more of your future weekend home."

Kavya smiled and went with Aditya. Aditya took her to the balcony of his room and offered her tissues. She said thanks and wiped her cheeks slowly. She offered the tissue box back to Aadi who was too lost looking at her. She looked down feeling shy and slowly tried walking out to keep the tissue box back.

Aditya held her hand, "Where are you going?" Her bangles clinked as he held her hand. "Here, give it to me." She turned back facing him, offering the box of tissues and instead of taking it, he held her other hand too.

"What are you doing, Aditya?" She said trying to release her hand.

"What am I doing Kavya?" Aditya asked playfully.

"Aadi please, someone will come…" the tissue box fell on the floor and Kavya panicked. "Let me at least pick it up first… please Aadi…"

"No!"

"Aditya, what our families will think? They are just…"

Aditya pulled her close and she lost all her words.

She moved her lips but no sound came out. Aditya laughed putting his head behind.

'My God, you look so sexy,' Kavya thought aloud.

"Really, you think so?" Aditya asked.

"I think so what?"

"You just said I look sexy…"

"Oh my God, did I say it aloud?"

Aditya laughed again, "Yes, Manu, you did."

"Please leave me, Aditya. I am feeling shy."

"And I am loving it. Okay, complete what you were going to say yesterday on the phone and I will let you go."

"What was I saying on the phone?" Kavya pretended as if she was trying hard to remember.

"Well… you were going to say you love me, Manu."

Kavya looked down and just nodded saying no.

"C'mon, say it once."

She hid her face in his chest. Aadi hugged her. "I will wait for the day when you say it, dear."

"I will," she said.

Aadi's hands slowly traveled down to her waist. She was too shy to look up at him and held his blazer tightly with both hands. His hands touched her bare skin and she let out a soft moan.

"Aadi, please leave me." Kavya finally managed to form words. He whispered in her ear, "I'm not holding you, Manu, you are holding me." She heard a hint of a smile in his words. She realized she was holding his blazer and felt embarrassed. In the heat of the moment, she did not even realize when he had released her hand and when she held him. She let go of his jacket immediately. Her hair, by now, had become a mess and she was as red as a bright rose. She tried bringing them back with her hands and bent down to pick up all the tissues, Aditya went down along. She quickly picked all but Aditya picked the last one in his hand. She raised her hand ahead to take it from him reluctantly and he held her hand. "Aadi..."

"Yes, Kavya?"

"We should go out. They all must be waiting for us."

"Please let's stay here for some more time. I want to have you all by myself." She managed to free her hand and nodded shyly saying okay. She kept the box on his study table and saw a collage of photos. Aditya saw it and came to explain the occasions. There were many - his childhood photos, joining the company, him working on the shop floor, his first day as MD,

etc. He was explaining each event earnestly and she got lost looking at him instead of photos. '*Is it even real life what I am living today?*' No matter how much she loved Aadi, she never thought even in dreams that this day would come. Yet today, here she was standing next to him as his would-be life partner. She thanked God once again for this happiness when Aditya shook her and brought her out of her thought trail.

"Hey, where are you lost?"

"Nothing," she quickly changed the topic, "Why can't I see my photo here?" she asked playfully.

Aadi smiled and opened a drawer without breaking eye contact and took out a small album. That had only Kavya's photos - since her schooling days till as latest as of when he came with a Chinese takeout to her office. "Hey, when did you click this one?"

"That time when you were busy talking to Jane."

"Hmm..." she was speechless. He had all her memories stored with him exactly the way she had kept them all with her. She was feeling like hugging him right now, but she was too naive with these emotions so she kept quiet.

"My office team got to know about us today. Everyone teased me the whole day." Aditya smiled. "Tell them, they will have you only for a few more days," she looked at him and smiled.

"We have not told our staff yet, we will have a proper announcement soon," Aditya said. She was looking down at her hands. Aditya raised her head, "You are looking gorgeous today, Manu." She felt shy and looked down again. Her smooth hair fell on her face in soft curls. Aditya was leaning against the table, he took her hair and tugged them at the back of her ear and held her face for some time. She was looking too irresistible. Kavya closed her eyes soaking his touch. He moved forward when he heard Sandhya's voice and they both quickly backed off.

"Hello, love birds. I hope I did not disturb you."

"Well, you almost did," Aditya said looking at Kavya who punched his arm and told him with her eyes not to comment further.

"Well, your marriage date options are finalized and mom sent me to call you both."

"Yeah, we'll come in five minutes," Aditya said. "Ahem, ahem... looks like I did disturb you after all." Now Kavya hid her face in his hands too embarrassed to react. Aditya quickly stepped forward and pulled Sandhya's ear, "Stop teasing us, your time will come soon." Sandhya giggled and said, "Come soon..."

Aditya removed Kavya's hands from her face. She was still looking down and said, "Aadi, I think we should go out now."

"Why? Are you scared of me?" Aditya asked playfully. She softly pushed him and said, "No, it's just that what they must be thinking what are we doing here since so long?"

"Hmm... what all we can do here for so long, Manu?" Aditya asked.

"Stop pulling my leg and come now."

Aditya gave out a long sigh and said, "Alright, let's go."

As they entered the room, Rashmi quickly pulled Kavya close and said, "Good you guys came, we have taken out two dates looking at your horoscopes. One is the end of this month so around fifteen days from now. The second one is the end of the next month, thirtieth November. Post that, the suitable dates are only next year, post July."

"No, no, we can't hold it till next year," Aditya said spontaneously and Kavya felt embarrassed. "No, I mean, isn't it too late?"

"But we won't get enough time for preparations. Next month is like hardly forty days. How will we manage everything?"

"We are not planning a big wedding, beta," Shiv said. "We were thinking we will invite only close family and friends for the wedding, around forty-fifty people here in Mumbai and then keep a grand reception in Pune. What you think?" Shiv purposely thought of this. Even though Kavya had agreed on expenses, he knew she would want to avoid big spending.

"Yes, that way the preparations will be less, but still, just forty days.." Shiv took her hands in his and said, "Don't worry, you just say yes, rest we will take care of" She looked at Aditya to see what he thought. Aditya realized it and said, "I am cool with this month end also." Everyone burst out laughing.

"Relax son, forty days is hardly any time. Enjoy the courtship till then." Aadi gave a shy smile and ran his hands through his hair messing with them.

Rashmi opened another box of sweets as the date of marriage got fixed. Sandhya whispered in Kavya's ear, "Di, forty days to go... The countdown begins!"

Kavya told her to keep quiet, but she kept beaming up. Sandhya was extremely excited with her sister getting married. Kavya, on the other hand, was dealing with a lot of emotions at the same time. She was happy, but also nervous, very uncertain, and sad for leaving her family. She was lost in her own thoughts when Shiv called her name.

"Kavya…"

"Yes, uncle?"

"How much is your notice period in the current company?"

"It's one month."

"Okay, then it works perfectly. You will get a few days break before marriage. I hope you would like to work for my company."

Kavya had not thought of this, although the thought instantly clicked her mind.

"Yes uncle, it will be a pleasure. Thank you so much. I hope I will reach your expectations."

"Of course you will. I have full faith in you," Shiv said.

Aditya was sitting all restless in front of her.

Kavya asked him with her eyes, "What happened?"

He tried telling her back with signs, "Let's step out."

Kavya nodded, "No, can't… everyone is here."

Aditya again made signs pleading.

While they both were trying to talk in sign language, everyone around noticed it and Rashmi finally asked, "What is going on with you two?"

"Mom…" Aadi said running hands through his hair.

"Actually, I wanted to take Kavya out for dinner."

"Let us also enjoy time with our daughter, Aadi. You both will keep meeting now." Rashmi said, hugging Kavya who hugged her back.

Shortly afterward, dinner was served. Everyone discussed marriage plans and venue options. Shiv called a few people and asked them to keep the venue options ready when they come back.

That gave a reality check to Aditya that he will have to go back to Pune urgently tomorrow to prepare for a meeting. He had parked all meetings, but a few of them were critical and he had to take them up soon.

"Dad, when are we planning to go back? I need to schedule a meeting with Mr. Parker."

"Oh yes, Aadi. I was thinking Rashmi and I would go ahead tomorrow. You can come in a day or two."

"No, actually, I should come along. Have quite a few critical meetings."

"Hmm. Alright, then let's leave post lunch tomorrow."

Aditya nodded and looked at Kavya who instantly looked sad hearing the news. So now she won't get to see Aditya daily like the last few days, but she tried to keep her face normal as much as she could.

Aditya realized it and held her hand below the dinner table. She looked at him and he whispered, "Just a matter of a few days, then we will be together forever." She smiled back at him and resumed dinner.

Chapter 6

Kavya had to resign from work today. She was again having very mixed feelings. Until a few days back, this company was her world, and now, suddenly, she was going to leave it all for a new life. She got ready earlier than usual and as carefully as she could. Convincing Prakash was not going to be easy. She was wearing a plain lemon yellow dress with purple dupatta. Her hair tied to one side with silver small earrings and bangles. She applied Kajal and perfume. '*This should do,*' she thought and came to the living room.

To her utter surprise, Aditya was already sitting there, talking to her mother. "Good morning, Kavya," he said looking at her.

"Aditya, what a surprise!"

"Actually, I came to take you out for breakfast. I am going back to Pune today so thought of meeting you before I leave."

"Oh yes," she instantly felt sad with the thought but did not let it show on her face.

"Shall we go?"

"After you mam…" Aditya said and she smiled. She hugged her mother and said bye. Aadi hugged Kavita too and left with Kavya.

"So, where are we going?"

"Surprise!" He said and opened the door of his car for Kavya. As she settled in, he went to the driver's seat.

They both went to a nearby restaurant which was too quiet. Kavya asked him, "There is no one here, is it even open yet? We have come very early."

"No one is around because I booked the whole place for us. I wanted to spend some good time with you before I go back."

Kavya raised her eyebrow. "You are mad," she said. Aditya pulled a chair for her to sit and sat across the table.

"Can't you stay back for a few days?" Kavya asked.

"Really can't, baby. To be honest, I was so anxious since the time we planned to come and ask you for marriage, I was not able to focus on work. I had parked a lot of meeting last week and this week. Need to cover it up before marriage so that we get a few days off."

"You were really that nervous?" Kavya asked playfully.

"Let us just say, my heart had stopped beating till you said yes," Aditya said doing exaggerated acting.

Kavya giggled on it and Aditya skipped a heartbeat again. "You look beautiful when you laugh, Manu."

"Thank you," she said looking into his eyes.

Aditya held her hand and Kavya let out a small gasp. '*It's gonna need some getting used to*,' she thought.

"I am going to miss you," Aditya said, playing with her fingers with his.

"I will miss you too, Aadi," Kavya said, looking at him.

Aditya held her hand a bit firmly and she looked down. A waiter came and Kavya tried to pull her hand back, but Aadi did not let it go.

Aditya had pre-ordered a variety of breakfast items. Kavya looked at him, pleading with her eyes to let go of her hand. Aditya just smiled.

As soon as the waiter left, Kavya asked Aadi, "What are you doing Aadi? There are waiters around here."

"So what, you are my fiancé now, I can do much more than just holding your hand publically, you know," he said with a wink.

"Shut up and leave my hand. How would I eat?"

"Here, let me feed you," he said, taking a piece of Omelet in his fork. She ate. He kept feeding her for some more time. Finally, she said, "Please Aadi."

"Alright. But you need to finish your plate."

"No ways, I already ate a lot. I can't finish all this."

"No ways, Manu, you eat way too less for your age. You must promise me you will take good care of yourself when I am not around."

She nodded, overwhelmed, seeing him care for her so much.

"What?" Aadi asked her taking a bite from his sausages.

"Nothing, I am not used to someone taking care of me so much. I have lived all these years so much on my own. It feels good to see someone care," she said looking into her plate.

"Manu…"

"Hmm?"

"Look at me."

She looked up. "I love you… I have waited to have you in my life for so long. I skip a heartbeat every time you look at me with a smile and I am never going to take you for granted."

Now she landed in tears with his words and quickly tried wiping them with a tissue.

"Hey, baby… please don't cry."

"I am not crying," she said sobbing like a kid.

Aadi laughed.

"Shut up…" she punched his shoulder.

"Oucchhh! You hit so hard, baby," and she started laughing.

"Mr. Over Acting, finish your breakfast."

He smiled and got back to eating.

Kavya held his hand, "Aadi…"

It was a surprise for Aadi. It was the first time for him that she did it. He raised his eyebrow and looked at her with a happy, smiling face.

"Yes, Manu?" He said, putting his other hand on hers.

"I…" She wanted to confess her feelings back, but something inside her fluttered so hard that she could not. She felt shy and looked down. "I will miss you."

Aadi kissed her hand softly and said, "I will miss you too, baby. But see, just thirty-nine days to go now. Then we will be together forever."

She nodded and picked her cup of coffee.

"By the way, Manu, well tried… you were very close to saying 'I Love you' today," Aditya said giving a sideways smile.

"Shit…" he realized. Kavya thought, "Oh please, I was not going to say that…"

"Oh really?"

"Yeah, really…"

Kavya looked at her watch. "Shit, I am late. I need to reach office on time."

"Relax, finish your breakfast, I will drop you to your office. When are you putting your papers?"

"Most likely today," Kavya said. "I am not too sure how it's going to go. Prakash Sir was not happy yesterday."

This concerned Aadi, "Not happy as in?"

"I don't know, he was just wired yesterday." She tried avoiding the topic ahead as she felt Aditya was getting insecure about her.

"Hmm… Let me know if he does any funny business about your reliving."

"Don't worry, Aadi, he won't. He is a good man." Aadi just nodded.

"Shall we leave?"

Aditya drove her to her office, but she was not feeling like getting down. Both of them were sitting silently in the car.

"I will try to come over the weekend, Manu, so we can go shopping together."

She nodded. "Take care of your work first, I don't want you to compromise on work at all." Aadi smiled.

Aadi ran his hands through his hair. "Bye Manu."

"Bye Aadi." Aadi gave her a quick kiss on the forehead and whispered in her ear, "I wish I could give you a proper goodbye kiss, but we are below your office building."

She came out of his arms and straightened her dress. "Oh, I wish that too," she said giving him a shy and naughty smile.

Aditya was really surprised this time. He was not expecting this comment from her. She was slowly opening up to him and he loved it. Before he could catch her, she quickly got out of the car laughing. "Bye Aadi."

"I will see you over the weekend, Manu. Remember… we have unfinished business."

Kavya giggled again. "Will see…"

Aadi wore his sunglasses and waved back at her.

She stood there until he went, then she went inside the office.

She quickly went back to her desk and started her laptop, humming a song. Everyone noticed it. It was very unlike Kavya. She usually used to be very serious and focused. Rarely people had seen her relaxed and so happy. She realized everyone was looking at her so she quietened quickly. She had saved her resignation in the drafts. She took a long breath and sent it. By now Jane had reached her desk to join her for coffee and they both headed towards the pantry.

Kavya was telling Jane about all the things of weekend and yesterday, when their office boy came to the pantry to inform Kavya, "Prakash sir wants to see you."

Jane raised her eyebrow, "Did you put your papers?" Kavya nodded. She knew Prakash would call her for a discussion. However, he would send someone to the pantry to call her? She surely did not expect this.

She quietly kept her cup down and excused herself from the pantry. As soon as she went in Prakash's cabin, she saw him pacing like a lion in the cabin.

"What is this Kavya?"

"What happened, sir?"

"You sent a resignation letter?"

"Sir, I am getting married at the end of the next month. I will be shifting to Pune. So yes, I need to resign."

"How can you take such a big decision without discussing with me?"

Now she was really surprised but decided to keep calm.

"Sir, I understand I should have given you heads up before, but this was really not planned at all. Everything happened really fast."

"Shut up Kavya! You love Aadi, it's visible on your face," Prakash said.

Kavya got annoyed. "What's the problem with that? Of course, I love him. Wait a minute, are you angry because I am getting married or because I am leaving this job?"

Prakash realized what he had just said. "Forget it, just leave from here."

"NO, I need to know."

"Leave immediately I said," Prakash shouted at her and Kavya got scared. She quietly walked out of the cabin.

More than half the floor heard what happened inside. Almost everyone was standing. Kavya came out with tears in her eyes. She quickly ran to the restroom, Jane followed her there. She was sobbing when she reached the washroom. As she saw Jane, she hugged her and started crying.

"Kavya, relax. I told you yesterday, it was more than you leaving the job. You are too naïve to understand these emotions, but everyone in the office knew Prakash is over-sweet to you."

Kavya looked at Jane with horror. "What?"

"Of course he was. Look at you, who would not fall for someone like you? In fact, because of Prakash sir, half the office boys backed off."

All this was too much to take for her. She never really considered herself beautiful and never thought someone would find her desirable. "Now what should I do?" Kavya asked Jane innocently.

Jane smiled. "Now you just relax. You have not done anything wrong. You don't need to worry about anything. Besides, you are on notice period now! So chill."

Kavya relaxed after talking to Jane and nodded. She quietly came back to her desk and got back to work. Few of her coworkers came and spoke to her to make her relax. She decided

to ignore the incident and got back to work. Prakash came after some time to her desk and she stood up as she saw him.

"I am sorry Kavya for what happened in the morning. Please contact HR and get your exit formalities initiated."

"Yes sir, thank you," she said.

Saying this, he walked off quickly and Kavya visibly relaxed. She had a lot of work to hand over. She quickly contacted HR and got all the forms and formats for the handover. It was well past noon when she realized she had not checked her phone once. She picked it up and saw 4 missed calls from Aadi, 1 from her mom, and quite a few messages.

'Hi, Manu. Miss you, where are you? Are you okay? Why aren't you picking up the call? Call me back."

'*Oh my gosh! Why does he worry so much?*' She called him back.

"Hi, Aadi."

"Hi Manu, where were you? I have been trying to reach you."

"I was… a bit occupied," she managed to finish her sentence as she was thinking what to tell Aadi.

"What happened?"

"Nothing serious, I resigned and it seems it's not gone down well with my boss."

"Did he say anything?"

"A bit…"

"Kavya, you must learn to communicate."

She sighed, "Well, yes, he did say a lot of things, apparently he was loud enough to let the entire work floor hear it."

"What?"

"Relax Aditya, I can handle it myself. He just apologized to me. It's all sorted."

"How can he talk to you like that in the first place?"

"Aditya, I was the top performer of his team. Of course, it's a big hit for the company."

Aditya kept quiet.

"Aadi…"

"Hmm?'

"Don't be angry, dear… I am fine, everything is fine."

"Alright Manu, soon you will have your own company so you don't have to go through this again."

Kavya smiled at the thought of her own company. "If this is all a dream, then I never had such a beautiful dream in my life, Aadi."

"I love you Kavya."

"Bye Aadi."

"Say it, baby!"

She just giggled.

"Bye Kavya," Aditya said smiling.

She caught up with all the missed calls and got back to work. By the time she finished a major chunk of work, it was almost 4:30 pm. She had missed her lunch again but decided to have a quick bite with Jane. She was half-way done when she got a message on the phone, Prakash wanted to see her urgently. She gave out a big sigh and left her food half-eaten. Jane empathized with her and told her not to react to anything. Prakash was irritated again.

"Kavya, where is the report I had asked you to prepare?"

"I've emailed it to you already."

"I am talking about the hard copy…"

"It's on your desk beside your laptop."

"Okay, go…"

Kavya left quietly. '*If this is how the notice period is going to go, it's going to be tough*.'

She came back to the canteen to finish her lunch. Jane asked her what happened and she told her the whole incident.

"I feel you should report this to HR."

"I don't want to spoil my terms and leave, Jane."

"So, you will keep taking such crap? C'mon, you have been the top performer throughout. This is not nice."

"Hmm… if it repeats, I will think about it."

"Her phone buzzed; it was Aditya and she immediately had a grin on her face. Jane picked on it and said, "You are in love, my girl."

Kavya picked up the call giggling with Jane.

"Hi…"

"Hi sweetheart, how is your day going?"

"Going bad. My boss is… Anyway, you tell me, how's your day going?"

"It's dull without seeing you. Did your boss say anything more?"

"Well, he seems really upset with me putting the papers. We had an argument again," Kavya said truthfully. "But I guess I can handle it. It's a question of just 30 days, isn't it?"

"No, you are not going to entertain any more nonsense."

"Aadi, relax… I am fine."

"I am getting into a meeting, Kavya, I will call you back later."

Aditya had an action-packed day. He had a lot of work piled up. He aligned all meetings of the week and spoke to his critical customers. He met Mr. Parker and closed the deal. Now he was getting into a meeting with Jatin for the new venture suggested by Kavya. He was intending to present that company to her as a marriage gift."

The meeting took pretty long. Jatin was Aditya's right-hand man. They both were college mates. Post completion of college, Aditya offered him the job and Jatin took it. Aadi was a visionary and Jatin was his execution partner. They both worked like brothers and were almost inseparable. Aditya gave him all the freedom and Jatin never took him for granted.

Aditya was a bit concerned about Kavya's office issues and Jatin picked on it.

"You are not here, Aditya. What's wrong?"

"Kavya is facing trouble with her boss for handover. I don't know why, but I am sensing it's more than work handover."

"Maybe you are just getting insecure. But don't worry boss, we will have him checked."

Aditya smiled, "You are the best." They had a high five and then left the meeting room.

Aadi came back to his cabin and saw Kavya's photo. A few more days… he thought. In the next few hours, he caught up on all the emails and replied wherever required. He was going through a few contract papers when he got a knock at the door from Jatin.

"Yes?"

"It's not very good news, boss. I got Prakash checked."

It immediately got Aditya's attention. "And?"

"Well, he is a complete womanizer. Married with one girlfriend and I also got feedback that he is interested in Kavya."

"Who is the owner?"

Jatin had already taken out all information contacts anticipating Aditya's actions.

"Mr. Carter." He handed out the bio of the company and of Mr. Carter.

The next few hours went in making some phone calls and finding ways out… The final call was made to Mr. Carter with the closure of the issue. In some time, Prakash got an email from Mr. Carter asking to relive Kavya with immediate effect, clearing all her dues. It was marked to HR to ensure it was taken ahead smoothly.

Prakash saw the email and got furious. Before he could call Kavya, HR was in his cabin to inform him that they have very clear instructions from Mr. Carter that Prakash will not be a part of Kavya's exit process. They were also planning a small send-off party for her in the next 1 hour which will be attended by Mr. Carter himself.

Kavya got a call from HR for the meeting. She got scared if Prakash had created a new issue. She reached the HR cabin and got a very warm welcome. All her relieving letters were kept ready, along with her full and final sheets. Kavya got confused. "But I just resigned in the morning, how can I get relieved the same day? I need to give a handover."

"Don't worry, Kavya, you have done a very good job of maintaining the data neatly. We are sure whoever joins in your place won't find it difficult to take over the work. You have

been a top performer throughout your tenure thus, Mr. Carter decided to relieve you early as a marriage gift. You can start winding up your desk. We will have your farewell party in some time."

Kavya nodded and collected all her papers and left. She was feeling very sad. Last day at work. Till a few days back, this company was her world, and now, suddenly, everything had changed.

She went back to her desk and everyone gathered around as they got to know she was leaving. She was trying her best to control her tears, but when people started giving her goodbye hugs, she could not control anymore. So many things to pack. The office was like a second home for Kavya, maybe the first home, as she spent more time at the office than at home. Her desk was her own small world; so many memories. Now suddenly, she had to leave everything and go. Her phone buzzed... it was Aditya.

"Wassup? I miss you."

Leaving all this for a new world and new found happiness, she thought.

"I miss you too," she replied.

Everyone was called to the conference room. Mr. Carter was already there. There was a cake on the table which said "All the best Kavya". '*Oh my gosh! Mr. Carter is here for my farewell. Why, how?*' Kavya thought. Mr. Carter rarely visited this office. This was one of the ventures for him. He was a very busy man. '*How on earth he got to know about me and decided to come?*' She was too intimidated to say anything.

Mr. Carter gave a farewell speech highlighting all the good work Kavya had done during her tenure. This came as a big surprise to her. 'How does he know so much about me?' Prakash, on the other hand, was not even invited for the farewell.

Mr. Carter reached the end of his speech. "It's a rare chance our company got to work with someone as talented as Kavya. We wish her all the very best for her future. I would like to give her a small token of appreciation for all the hard work

she has done for us." He handed her an envelope. Kavya was speechless. Everyone asked her to say something. But she was not able to. She excused herself for a minute and went out of the conference room to get a grip on her feelings. She came back a bit more composed and started talking.

"This company stood by me when I was nothing, just a fresher with a zeal to learn and grow. But Prakash sir gave me a chance. It means a lot to me. 'Trust' - a five-letter word has the biggest impact on people's lives. Trust people around and let them know it. You will be amazed at what they can do to stand up to your expectations. Work hard. What is life? For me, life is today. We don't have control over tomorrow or yesterday. These twenty-four hours is the only life we all get. Make the most of it."

Everyone started clapping. Kavya cut the cake and slowly people started going back to their desks to wind up. It was well past six and Kavya was still winding up everything. She decided to make a quick summary sheet of where, which data is stored so that it would easy for someone else to take over. She kept all her belongings aside and restarted her computer. She got so engrossed that she did not realize it was 12 am when she finished it. '*Oh my gosh*.' She quickly shut down the PC and moved out.

'*Which route to take for home? Come on Kavya, it's the last day, what can possibly go wrong, take the shortcut*,' she thought and started walking. She was thinking about giving a long call to Aadi tomorrow morning and explain everything that happened. She was amazed that HR can take such a harsh decision on Boss's wrong behavior, but she was also happy and secretly thanking them in mind for it. If at all she had to take this behavior of Prakash for a full month, life would have been living hell.

Chapter 7

She was too engrossed in her thoughts when she had the familiar of someone following her. The same leather cracking sound of shoes. It was very late today and she was not even halfway to the auto stand. She stopped to reconfirm the sound and the sound of someone walking stopped shortly after. Now she was sure someone was following her and she started running. '*Don't look back, Kavya… don't look back!*'

She ran for almost five minutes when her bag got stuck and she fell down. She could hear that whoever was following her, was coming closer, but before she could turn and see, she heard the sound of a slap. She quickly tried getting up when a man in a black uniform helped her get up.

"Are you okay, mam? Mam?"

"Who are you?"

"We will tell you everything shortly. Here, take this…" he offered her a water bottle.

"No, I don't want it. Who are you?" She turned around to see Prakash was held by another man who was beating him badly. Kavya quickly went to stop him. "Stop… what's wrong?"

"Mam he was following you."

"What?" She looked at Prakash with disgust. "Don't worry, we will take care of all this."

"But who are you guys, why are you calling me mam?"

"Aditya sir had sent us for your protection. You please go ahead in the car, we will fix everything here."

'*Aditya sent bodyguards? Why?*' It was too much to take. Her head started hurting as she slowly walked towards the car. Her phone rang… it was Aditya.

"Hi Manu, are you okay?"

"Aadi, what is happening, who are these guys, why were they following me?"

"You please relax. First, tell me are you alright?"

"Yes, I am fine."

"Why you never told me someone is following you, Kavya?"

"How you got to know this Aadi?"

"That's not important."

"That's important for me."

Aditya gave out a sigh. "I will explain to you everything tomorrow morning. Right now you just go home and relax. You are safe now."

"I am not liking this Aadi. You can't spy on me."

"Then you need to learn to communicate, Kavya." Aditya was trying his best to control his anger but was failing.

"I didn't want to trouble you…"

"Trouble me? Do you realize what could have happened today? For heaven's sake, Kavya… get real!"

"Are you forgetting the fact that you have come into my life just one week back, Aditya? I was alone before that and was fighting my own battles."

She was right. They both never really got time to speak everything.

"You are right… I am sorry."

"It's okay," she said weakly. "Just don't scold me next time, please," she said almost in tears.

"Sorry Manu, I didn't intend to… I was so worried about you, about everything I got to know."

"How you got to know?"

"I will tell you everything tomorrow morning. Right now you go home and relax, baby."

"Aadi…"

"Hmm?"

"I am scared… Why was Prakash following me?"

"Don't be scared baby, no one can hurt you. I am there."

She started sobbing.

"Manu, please don't cry… I can't handle it. Do you want me to come?"

"No," she said, trying to calm herself. "I am fine. I'll be fine."

"I love you, Kavya."

"I wish you were here right now. Aadi…"

"Take care, baby."

"You too."

Kavya could not sleep the whole night. The thing in the morning, she called Aditya to know what exactly happened. Aadi was in the gym.

"Good morning, baby, slept well?"

"Could not sleep at all… are you going to tell me what happened, now?"

Aadi told her the entire incident. "When Jatin told me Prakash liked you, somehow I felt he was going to get nasty in some way or the other. Then I remembered your call late at night that day. Though you never told me anything, I had a hunch that something is not right and decided to keep protection around you." Aadi swiftly avoided the part of her relieving being pushed by him in return of a big business he gave to Mr. Carter. He was smart enough to know Kavya won't appreciate it. But at the same time, she was too naïve to understand this.

"Oh my gosh, Aadi! You had a doubt someone was following me?"

"Someone as beautiful as you, baby; of course, there will be many guys around you wishing you would say 'yes' someday. But I must protect what's mine…"

Kavya could not say anything. "Hmm…" she relaxed as Aadi told her everything.

"So what's your plan for the day?"

"I don't know, Aadi. I have never had a break in my life, I am already getting bored. Just imagine… we wake up and we don't have anything to do."

Aadi laughed, "Enjoy your holidays, spend time shopping around."

"That's a good idea, I can go out shopping for our marriage. What kind of clothes you would like me to wear after our marriage?"

"I would like to see you without them actually," Aditya said laughing.

"Aadi…" Kavya's face turned bright red on his comment. "You are mad, you say anything."

Aadi laughed harder. "I am sure your cheeks must be deep red right now. I wish I could see them."

"No, please… don't make a video call right now. I was asking seriously."

"Buy anything you like, baby. I have kept a car and a driver there, he will hand over a credit card to you. Shop anything you like."

"Aditya, this is too much. I don't need a car, I don't need a card. I have got my FnF yesterday. I will buy what I can afford."

"But Kavya…"

"Please Aadi, we have discussed this."

"Fine, but you must take the car and the driver; it's not for comfort, Manu, it's for your safety. I am not around, I will worry all the time."

"Okay…"

"Enjoy your day princess."

Kavya giggled. "Yeah, I will."

Kavya got ready for a non-working day. Sandhya forced her to wear her white sundress with yellow flowers, which barely reached her knees and kept her hair open with a simple hairband. No makeup, it was a leisure day!

Sandhya bunked her college to accompany Kavya in shopping. Kavya just remembered Mr. Carter had handed her an envelope. She quickly checked her bag and took it out. It was

a check worth 1.25 lakhs. '*What the...*' she thought. '*Why did he give me such an amount?*' Their usual sendoff contribution came to 15-20K. But this was too much. She decided to contact HR to get it corrected. But as soon as she called them, she, in turn, got a justification of how she deserved it. She gave out a big sigh and decided to save 50k straightaway in the name of her mom, in case of extreme emergency, and spend rest of the amount.

She reached a local mall in the city. She knew this place in the back of her mind. She had visited here multiple times, but never really bought anything, looking at the price tags. Today, however, was different. She had money in her account.

Kavya bought two simple pair of jeans with three cool t-shirts that went well with the jeans. She also took two simple evening-wear dresses. Sandhya literally forced her to try on a party-wear dress. She was parading in and out of the trial room and was making poses like a model. Sandhya had never seen her sister so happy and free. She thanked God once again, but right now, she needed to thank Aadi. As Kavya went with another set of dresses to the changing room, Sandhya made a video call to Aditya.

"Hi!"

"Hey, girl... wassup?"

"Bunked my college today, out with di"

"Did she buy anything... where is she?"

"Jiju, I have called you not, di, so you have to talk to me first."

Aadi laughed, "Yeah, yeah, so tell me, what u bought?"

"Actually, I called you to say thank you."

"Thank you? For?"

"I have never seen di so happy and carefree. It's like she is a different person altogether. It's happening only because of you. Thank you." She almost had tears in her eyes.

"Hey, C'mon. She deserves every happiness in this world. I promise you she will be like this from now on for the rest of her life."

Sandhya nodded wiping her tears, "Why do I get the feeling you have a contribution in her early relieving also?"

Aditya raised his eyebrows, "You are smart, but don't tell your sister, she will kill us both."

"I know... you are the best, bro!" Sandhya said and Aadi laughed.

"Wait, just stay quiet, okay? Di is coming out, let me show you a live ramp walk." Sandhya quickly turned her mobile camera.

Kavya came out of the trial room in a black off-shoulder long dress which had a thigh length slit. She had paired it with a rose-gold robe and pencil heels. She came out mimicking a model's ramp walk and Sandhya whistled. "Di, you have a figure to die for." Kavya giggled at her reaction.

Kavya was making faces and poses in front of the mirror. Aditya could not control his laugh as she gave a flying kiss to herself in the mirror. And she realized it was Aditya's laugh. She immediately straightened and asked Sandhya who was laughing along.

"I just felt like I heard Aadi laugh," she told Sandhya.

"Coz you just did!" She turned the phone, it was Aditya on the video call.

Kavya got so embarrassed. She covered her face with her hands and ran into the trial room.

"Jiju, I guess she is gonna kill me soon. I will call you back later... Bbye!"

"Hey, buy the dress she just tried, I loved it."

Sandhya nodded...

"Di, please come out, I was just kidding; I have disconnected the call."

Kavya came out in her own dress. She had turned red and Sandhya laughed again.

"C'mon di, you can't be this embarrassed."

"What he must be thinking about me? God! Why was I dancing in front of the mirror and that flying kiss... shit!" She covered her face again. Sandhya quickly picked the dress and

the full set from her hand and ran to the billing counter. "We are buying this."

"Sandhya wait... it's too costly. I tried it for fun. We don't need such a dress."

"Jiju loved it, he asked me to buy it for you."

Kavya could not argue on this and gave her the card.

Then they bought a few function-wear dresses for all three of them. Her choices were so simple that she barely spent anything even after buying all this.

By the time they reached home, it was evening. Sandhya was famished. She jumped on whatever food available.

Kavya got a video call from Aditya; she disconnected it and made a regular call.

"Hii..."

"Hii..."

"Why u did not take the video call?"

"Coz I am still feeling shy to face you after this morning's incident."

Aditya laughed.

"Don't you dare laugh on me..." Kavya said mockingly.

"I was just having a little fun..."

"You know what, darling? You look so much more beautiful like this, and yes, you looked killer in that dress. You can make any ramp model jealous with your figure. I never noticed it in Indian dresses. You looked like a total babe."

"Oh please, can we talk about something else?"

"Okay, okay, but I hope you have bought that dress. Wear it on our honeymoon."

"Hmmm…" was the only reply she managed.

"Where do you want to go for our honeymoon?"

"I haven't thought about it."

"Bali?"

"Bali? Sorry but, I don't have a passport..."

"That can be done quickly. Let's see, let me explore a few options. I will send those to you."

"Okay," she said.

"Hey, my mom is planning to come there by Thursday to buy marriage saris of your choice. Apparently, she also can't stay away from you."

"Who else cannot stay away from me? Kavya asked playfully.

"Oh, there's one guy in Pune, who is waiting to see you..."

Kavya giggled. "Then he needs to wait longer."

"Hey, I have an idea..."

"What?"

"Why don't you come to Pune with mom? You anyway have not seen this house. We can do your shopping here in Pune. We can also plan a small party for the office staff. Our marriage announcement is still pending."

"Aadi, you need to focus on work. I don't want your work to hamper because of me."

"You are so boring, Kavya."

"Even I want to meet you, Aadi, as much as you want to meet me, but we need to be practical, right? Running a company is a very big responsibility and besides…"

"Oh please, don't lecture me. Let's do one thing, I will work extra hours today and tomorrow, and Thursday you come with mom. I will cover maximum work in these two days, okay?"

"You will work even when I am around. We will shop in the evening."

"No ways... are we negotiating?"

"Of course..." Kavya geared up. I will come for two days, you will work during the day and will shop in the evening."

"I will work for two hours... and come back."

"Four hours... take it or leave it, deal?"

"God! You negotiate real hard, Kavya. Okay, four hours and we are meeting on Thursday."

Kavya smiled, "You have not seen me negotiating deals."

"I can imagine..."

"Hmm…"

"Can't wait to see you, princess."

"Me too."

"I love you, Kavya."

Kavya giggled in return as she knew Aadi wanted to hear it from her.

"Why aren't you saying it?"

"I feel shy..."

"And I love that. Okay, give me a kiss."

"Aadi..." Kavya said, lowering her voice what are you saying? Mom and Sandhya are around." Kavya felt shy.

"C'mon, you can give it to your mirror image in the mall, then give me one."

"Shut up!"

"I love to see you when you blush."

"How can you say I am blushing right now?"

"You are in the balcony right now, must be looking down as we talk. You are playing with your dupatta and your cheeks are pink."

"My God, Aadi!" She immediately left her dupatta.

Aadi laughed. "You are an open book, Kavya. It's very easy to predict you."

"Hmm..." she said.

"See you on Thursday then. Remember, we have something unfinished."

Kavya gasped and Aditya laughed.

"Bbye Manu."

"Bye Aadi."

Aditya disconnected the call. Since the time Kavya had said yes, he was not able to stop smiling. '*Maybe I should have proposed a few years earlier,*' he thought. '*No, I was right to wait. I had to give her time to settle down.*' He ran his hands through his hair messing them up. I need to get back to work.

He walked towards the study room and saw his father working in his room. "Dad, you are still working? Anything urgent?"

"Haha… no, actually, I was making a guest list for your marriage. Come here.

These are the four venue options, and I find this resort perfect for the reception. Our guests can stay here and attend the reception."

"This looks perfect, dad."

"Anyone specific you want to invite?"

"Esha and Jatin are on my guest list already. That reminds me, I was thinking of calling Kavya here with mom on Thursday, we can do shopping here. And we can also introduce her to our staff. She has not seen this house too."

Shiv started laughing.

"What happened, dad?"

"Aadi, you don't need to find reasons to call her here."

"Dadd..."

Aadi got up as Shiv started teasing him.

"Don't run away, we have a lot of planning to do."

"Dad, I need to get back to work."

Shiv raised his eyebrows. "Someone is working hard, I am impressed."

"Kavya took a promise from me that I won't let work hamper, else she won't come."

"She is a damn bright girl. Which department are you planning to place her in?"

"She actually came up with a fantastic idea for a budget brand, dad... I am thinking of letting her run it independently. But she will need formal training before that. So, I think the way I started, she should start from scratch."

"You are right. C'mon, off you go now and get back to work."

"Yeah, dad. Good night."

The next day, after completing catering order with mom, Kavya and Kavita made a list of all the preparations required for the marriage along with a costing sheet. Thankfully, with the FNF and Mr. Carter's farewell gift, they were able to meet the expenses. Besides, marriage was going to be a low affair so it had to fit in their budget properly. Kavya made complete day wise schedule for marriage shopping as if it was a complete project. Kavita was extremely overwhelmed to see her like that and burst out crying. "I am going to miss you, beta." Seeing her

mom cry, Kavya also started crying. "Mom..." She hugged her and both cried their hearts out.

"Aditya and his family are good people. I am very happy you are going to be a part of a good family." Kavya nodded as she sobbed like a kid. "Kavya, c'mon, we have a lot of work to do. Cheer up now." But she was so overwhelmed with the thought of leaving mom and Sandhya, she was not able to control. "Stop crying now, beta, else I will call Aditya." But it did not help. Kavita got up and brought her phone from the bedroom. She called Aditya.

"Hi beta, I hope I am not disturbing you," Kavita said wiping her own tears.

"Hello, aunty... I mean mummy. No, No, it's cool. Are you okay? You sound upset."

"We were actually making a list of marriage preparations and we both landed in crying. Now I am not able to stop Kavya from crying, can you help?"

"Mummy, c'mon, she will always be your daughter. We will keep visiting Mumbai frequently. Please don't worry."

"I know you will take good care of my daughter, Aditya, I am not worried at all. Here, speak to her."

Kavita handed over the phone to Kavya.

"Hi..."

"Hi..." she said crying.

"Baby, please don't cry, it twists my heart."

"I don't want to leave my mom and Sandhya," Kavya said sobbing.

"Then bring them to Pune, let us all stay together."

"Who will take care of mom's catering orders? At times, they are big. She never calls domestic help, how will she manage? Sandhya needs to focus on her studies."

"Kavya, you are getting married, that does not mean they won't be your family now. The way my family will have you, your family now has me. We will find a way out of everything. Don't worry. Do you trust me, baby?"

"Hmm..." Kavya said, wiping her tears.

"Good, now quickly give me a smile."

Kavya sobbed again.

"I swear, Kavya if you cry even a minute more, I will leave everything and come there."

Now she smiled at the thought. "No, I am okay..."

"Good girl. Please relax, your family is now my responsibility, okay?"

"Hmm..."

"Love you, Kavya..."

"Aadi..."

"Yes, baby?"

"I..."

Kavita came in the living room. "Are you okay now?"

"Yes, mom."

"Bye Aadi..." Aadi smiled and disconnected the call. '*I need to talk to dad on Kavya's house finances*,' he thought and got back to work.

Rashmi came next day early morning directly to Kavya's house. She was very impressed with Kavya's organized way of planning everything. They talked a lot and had lunch together when Sandhya came from college. Post which, they all went out for shopping.

As Aditya wanted to be a part of Kavya's shopping, they decided to finish Kavita and Sandhya's shopping. Rashmi took them to the best store in the city and Kavya became uncomfortable.

"Mummy…"

"Yes, beta?" Rashmi said. "It's so lovely to hear mummy from you. I always wanted to have a daughter." She hugged her.

"This is a very costly store. Can we shop somewhere else, please?"

"Don't you remember what Shiv said that day? Please don't hesitate, let me do something for my daughter." Kavya could not say no and entered the store.

They bought all the stuff for themselves except marriage clothes, what Rashmi wanted to buy from Pune along with

Kavya's shopping. Then they went for gold shopping. Kavya was uncomfortable throughout with Rashmi spending so much money, but she could not say anything. Rashmi noticed it, but she thought of handling it on the way to Pune when they both would be alone.

Kavya and Rashmi dropped Kavita and Sandhya home and directly started for Pune.

Chapter 8

"Kavya..."

"Yes, mummy?"

"Did you like today's shopping?"

Yes, everything is beautiful. Thank you so much."

Rashmi took Kavya's hand in her hand and said, "I could see you were not comfortable."

"It's not like that mom..."

"Then help me understand beta."

"You spent so much in one day, it was more than our total marriage budget. I don't know if we will be able to do so much back for you, papa, and Aditya."

Rashmi smiled at her honesty. "I am glad you spoke, Kavya. Your mom and I, we both started our lives at the same level. Both Shiv and your dad had startup businesses and if you remember, initially, Kavita and I had done the catering business together."

Kavya nodded. "Unfortunately, we lost your father. Shiv moved his business ahead and you guys had a setback. All these years, Kavya, you or Kavita did not let us help u at all. While I am extremely proud of you the way you handled everything, it was a very sad feeling... helpless feeling for us to see our best friends suffer.

I always wanted you as my daughter-in-law, Kavya. I have waited for this for long. God has given this chance to Shiv

and me to do something. Please don't take it away from me this time."

Kavya hugged her and they both started crying. "I am sorry, mummy, I never realized that while we were keeping our self-respect by saying no, indirectly we were hurting you. We never really intended that way."

"Shh, Kavya, I never misunderstood you or Kavita."

"We missed you a lot, mummy."

"I missed you too, beta."

They reached Pune catching up on all the years gone by. Their car halted in front of a big bungalow and Kavya gasped.

"Is this..." is all she could say.

Rashmi wrapped her arm around Kavya. "Yes, this is your new home."

Kavya became extremely quiet, intimidated by the place.

All the home staff members were standing at the main door with flowers along with Aditya and Shiv to welcome Kavya. It intimidated her further... '*So many house staff*?'

Everyone showered flowers to welcome her. Aditya was in simple black jeans with a blue t-shirt smiling at her. He just did a lip movement saying welcome. Kavya gave him a weak smile.

She touched the feet of Shiv and Rashmi before entering the house. Rashmi introduced her to all staff members.

They came inside. It was a huge living room with three different types of sitting arrangements. There was a staircase that went upstairs followed by a patio on the backside... and a few doors there... she was struggling to understand which door goes where. It was probably the biggest house she had ever seen.

"You must be tired. Aditya will show you your room. Freshen up and join us in some time." Aditya beamed and told her, "Come..."

Kavya followed him quietly as they reached up. There was a big passage with multiple doors, again. She unknowingly held Aditya's hand tightly.

"What happened, Manu? Why are you so quiet?"

"This house is so big... it's bigger than the entire 'chawl' where I live, I think."

Aditya stopped walking and took her hand, which he was holding and kissed it. "It's our house, Kavya. It belongs to you also now. Don't let it intimidate you." She nodded and rested her head on his hand as they walked slowly with Kavya hugging his hand. He was warm and she loved the feeling. She did not realize what she was doing until Aadi spoke.

'Manu..."

"Hmm?"

"I am loving what you are doing, it's just that... It will be very difficult for me to control myself till marriage otherwise..."

"Oh!" She realized and stepped aside, trying to release the hand.

"No, I want to hold your hand."

She looked down.

He opened the door of one of the rooms. It was almost the size of half of her house. A dedicated sitting arrangement, study table, and a big bed. There was a washroom with bathtub and an attached walk-in wardrobe. The walls were peach in color with white and peach combination floral curtains. A big window on the other side of the bed gave a hill-view. She was amazed looking at the detailing taken care of while designing it.

"This, I was thinking, will be your room after marriage. How is it? We can get it redecorated as per your choice. My room is next door."

"It's beautiful, I don't want to change anything here. It's perfect." Aditya smiled back. He was giving her time to settle in the room.

Kavya just realized Aditya said his bedroom was next door... Why? She thought.

"Aadi..."

"Hmm?" He said leaning on the dressing table with crossed legs.

"I... wanted to ask you something."

"What happened baby?"

She turned so that she did not have to face him while talking. "You just said, your room is next door." Aditya realized her confusion but decided to control his smile and kept a serious face.

"Yes, that's correct."

"So, we will be staying in... I mean..."

"What happened, Kavya?" Aditya asked with a mocking seriousness.

"I don't know how to ask."

"Try it…"

"So, even after marriage we will stay in different rooms?" she finally asked...

Aditya hugged her from behind and kissed her neck smiling. "You think I will be able to stay away from you after marriage?"

"Aadi... What are you doing? The door is open."

"Our bedroom is separate, love. This room is only when you need some privacy or want to get ready, want to study or work alone. Stuff like that."

"Oh!" she said, visibly relaxing.

Aadi shifted her hair from her neck and kissed her again.

"Aadi..." she said, her pulse rate increasing. "Don't..."

"C'mon Kavya, don't be coy..." his hands played with her waistline. Kavya closed her eyes and turned, getting into his arms.

"I missed you," she whispered in his ear.

"I missed you too, baby," Aditya said.

"Aadi…"

"Hmm..."

"The door is open."

"Relax..." and hugged her a bit more tightly.

She let out a small moan as he kissed her cheek and tried going away. Aditya pulled her back and pinned her to the wall.

"My kiss is pending, baby."

She looked down covering her face in her hands. He slowly removed her hands and held her face in his hands. Her eyes were closed and she had a smile on her face.

Aditya slowly kept his lips on hers. They were softer than what he had thought of. He kept kissing her slowly till she started responding him back. Her hand ran through his back. Aditya pressed himself on her a bit and she gasped. Taking this as a cue, Aadi deepened the kiss. Kavya had never experienced this feeling before. Her knees were going weak. Aditya held her hair and started kissing hard. His other hand went on the inner line of her dress and she gasped again. Aditya lifted her and took her to the bed. Her shoes fell off before she could realize she was on the bed with Aditya on top. Aadi kissed her one last time and finally got up and laid next to her.

She got up as soon as Aditya shifted. She was out of breath. Aditya pulled her back and she fell in his arms.

"Aadi..."

"Hmm?"

"We are yet to get married, we should not do this right now. It's wrong."

"It was a simple kiss, Manu."

"Simple?" she said, looking at him innocently.

Aditya took her face in hands and kissed her again. This innocence was rare to find, especially in someone as beautiful as her. It made her look almost irresistible for Aadi. If this was big for Kavya, then he had a lot to teach her. He finally broke the kiss and wiped his mouth with his right thumb. Kavya looked at him, she had turned all red. She quickly ran into the washroom to hide.

She was standing behind the door, breathing heavily. '*God! What's happening in my life?*' she looked at her reflection and blushed.

Aditya knocked at the door.

"Kavya?"

"Hmm..."

"Come out baby."

"No... you please go, I will come in some time."

'I am not going anywhere," Aadi said playfully.

"Aadi please..."

"Hahahaha…"

Kavya came out shortly after to take her dress from her bag. Aditya was watching the view outside the window, soaking in the breeze... so relaxed... so peaceful. Kavya stood there watching him for some time. "Stop staring at me and go get ready, girl," Aditya said after some time looking at her. She blushed again, took her dress and quickly went to the washroom.

It was a new dress Kavya had bought, lavender color with fluffy sleeves. It hugged her curves perfectly and reached below her knees. She kept her hair down to one side and quickly came out.

"I am ready," she said. Aditya looked back. "You look lovely." She felt shy and looked down. "Thank you."

Aditya came close to her and raised her face with his hands. "The more time I spend with you, Manu, I regret not choosing an earlier date." Kavya looked away. "You are mad."

"Yes, I am... madly in love with you." He leaned forward, Kavya placed a finger on his lips nodding her head saying no. "Lets' go down," she said and hugged him.

Aditya smiled and hugged her back. "As you say, my princess. Come."

They stepped out of the room holding hands and the reality of the huge house hit her again. She gripped Aadi's hand tighter. Aditya wrapped his arm around her waist giving her reassurance.

It was almost dinner time so Rashmi decided to have an early dinner. Kavya joined Shiv and Rashmi in the living room.

"You guys took a pretty long time," Shiv teased Aadi, who looked down messing his hair. Kavya turned red and looked down too. Rashmi and Shiv burst out laughing, looking at their reaction. "Look at them, Rashmi... it's going to be so much fun teasing them after marriage." Kavya tried hiding the grin on the face with her hand. "Oh stop it, Shiv. Don't embarrass them more. They have come only after an hour," Rashmi said teasing further.

"Mommm..."

"Okay, okay, let's go for dinner. Come beta..."

They all went to the dining room. Aadi pulled a chair for Kavya and made her sit next to him. All the dishes were of Kavya's choice. She was surprised and looked at Rashmi. She smiled and said, "I had asked Kavita what you like." Kavya was overwhelmed by the gesture. She just curled her lips and said thank you. Rashmi nodded.

Dinner was further teasing and laughter. Kavya was relaxing as they spent time together. Shiv proposed to check out one of the marriage venues post dinner. Rest of the three were nearby and could be covered tomorrow. Everyone agreed quickly so they all went in the car together. Shiv was driving, Rashmi sat next to him. Aditya and Kavya sat on the backseat.

"Papa, isn't it late? They must have closed the place by now."

"The owner is my friend, don't worry, I have spoken to him."

"Oh, okay," Kavya said. She was nervous. Wedding venue... it was a big step. Aditya realized it and held her hand. Kavya got scared more. She pleaded him with her eyes to leave her hand. He just gestured her to relax. "Nervous?" he asked. She nodded. "Me too," he said.

Shiv cleared his throat, "Son, don't forget we are in the car too." Rashmi started laughing. "We must get used to it, Shiv. These love birds find it difficult to keep their hands to themselves." Kavya pulled her hand and hid her face.

"Dadd... we were just talking!"

"Yeah, right... I know," he said and everyone laughed.

They reached the venue and Kavya almost fainted. It was a stadium. She got down from the car. Shiv asked her, "How do you like this venue, beta?"

"Isn't it too big, papa?"

"I am expecting a big guest list, beta. We will need it."

She gripped his hand. "Don't think too much, just go with the flow, beta. Do you like it?" She nodded. "It's just that I never thought of a big event like this."

"I can understand..."

He went ahead to talk to the owner with Rashmi when Aditya joined her. "How is the place?" he asked. "It's.... very big."

Aadi smiled. "It is... I loved it. But let's explore all the options, then we will take a call."

"Hmm..."

"Why are you so quiet?"

"This is all a lot to take, Aadi... a big wedding, a big house... I am a very simple person; I am not used to all this."

"I can understand, baby. I am there with you. Do u trust me?"

"Yes," she said.

"Then don't worry. It's going to be our wedding... our day... big, small doesn't matter. You just relax and enjoy."

She smiled at the thought.

'Now that's my girl," he said. "Come, let's look at the other side."

They looked around a bit more and then went back home. They all sat back together and discussed the marriage plans ahead until late night when Kavya almost started dozing off in her chair. Finally, they all went to sleep. Aditya accompanied her to her room.

"Good night, Aditya."

"Good night, Manu," he said but did not leave.

"What? Go now..."

"Do you really want me to go?"

She just blushed and looked down. "If you come inside, I don't think I will let you go..."

Aadi raised his eyebrows on her confession.

"Manu..."

"Goooo..." she said and pushed him out dramatically.

Aadi gave exaggerated expressions and started walking.

"Aadi..." she said from behind and he came back immediately. "What?" he asked with a puppy face. She gave him a quick kiss on his cheek and before he could realize, she closed the door.

"Manu... cheater…" he knocked at the door. Kavya giggled from inside.

"Good night, Aadi."

"I will see you tomorrow, princess. Good night."

Kavya sat on the sofa near the window. It was dark, but she was not feeling scared; it was beautiful. Before she could realize she fell asleep on the sofa.

Aditya came early morning and saw her sleeping. She was looking so cute that he chose not to wake her up. He just kissed her forehead and left. He was going early to the office to complete his committed four hours of work so that he could spend the whole day with Kavya.

Kavita called her at 7.30 to wake her up.

"Hi!"

"Kavya, you are still in bed?"

She realized she was in Aditya's house.

"Shit... what time is it mom?"

"It's seven-thirty."

"Shit... Mom, I will call you back in some time. Let me get ready."

She quickly took a shower and got ready. Kavya chose simple maroon Punjabi suit today. She looked at the dressing table; it was fully-loaded with everything a girl can dream of. '*I wish I knew how to use it*.' She applied kajal and bindi and quickly went to Aditya's room, but he was not there. She immediately felt sad and called him.

"Hi…"

"Hello, sleeping beauty!"

"Where are you?"

"I am in the office. I will be home by eleven."

"Aadi, you promised you will work half a day."

"I promised four hours, Kavya. We did not define which four hours. I called early morning meetings," he said simply.

"Cheater!" She said.

"Oh really? Who cheated yesterday?"

"Bye Aadi..." she said giggling.

"See you soon, baby."

She went down and met Rashmi. Shiv had gone to office with Aditya. They had a joint meeting.

"Hi, mummy, good morning."

"Good Morning, beta."

"Sorry, I overslept."

"No, no... You are on time. These guys left too early. Come, join me for breakfast."

"Actually, I overate yesterday and am not really used to breakfast. Can I have milk?"

"Yes, sure." Rashmi just looked at one of the maids who got the cue and quickly went into the kitchen.

The designer will come in some time. Until then, let us go through the options he has forwarded.

"Designer?"

"Yes, our company designers' team will do custom designs of wedding dresses and jewelry."

"Oh!"

Rashmi smiled. A servant came with a glass of milk and handed it to her.

The Next few hours went in shortlisting designs. Her phone rang, it was Aditya. She blushed and looked at Rashmi.

"Looks like someone can't stay away even for four hours..."

"How do you know about four hours?"

"Shiv told me," Rashmi said laughing.

"Mom..."

Rashmi messed her hair. "Take the call..." and went inside the kitchen.

"Hi..."

"Hi... wassup?"

"Shortlisting designs. I wish mom and Sandhya were here."

"Hmm..." Aditya looked at Jatin who was in the car with him at that time. He kept the phone on mute and said, "Please arrange to bring Kavita aunty and Sandhya here." Jatin smiled and got on the phone to make arrangements.

"Hmm?" she said as Aadi did not speak for a few seconds.

"Nothing, I am on my way home."

"Aadi..."

"Look at the watch, baby, it's eleven am."

Kavya giggled. "Yeah, right. Come soon."

Aditya and Shiv came home with the designer. They went through many designs together. Kavya liked one sapphire colored dress. Aditya realized it and pushed it ahead.

By 1 pm, they heard a car driving in.

"Have you called anyone?" Rashmi asked.

Aditya smiled, "A small surprise for Kavya."

He quickly went out to receive Kavita and Sandhya. He touched Kavita's feet and brought them inside.

Kavya beamed seeing mom and quickly ran to hug her. She was smiling ear to ear looking at them. She looked at Aditya and formed words thank you on her lips.

Aditya gave her a flying kiss and she blushed.

By the end of the day, all the dresses, decor, and marriage invitations... everything was frozen. They all were having a light conversation when Aadi swiftly told her to come along. She went with him. Aditya took her out from backdoor and went to a parked car where they met Sandhya.

"What are you doing, Aadi? Our parents..."

"Shhh… di just get in the car."

"Where are we going?"

"Clubbing..."

"How do you know all this, Sandhya?"

"I have gone a couple of times in Mumbai."

"What?" Kavya asked almost shouting at her.

"Relax, Kavya," she is not a kid anymore.

'But why lie..."

"Di, I didn't intend to hurt you, but you would not have given permission. Mom knows about it."

"What? You could tell mom but not me? Now I am really hurt, Sandhya."

Sandhya wrapped her hands around her neck, "Sorry di. Please, please, please…"

"No Sandhya, stop this..."

Then Sandhya started tickling Kavya and she finally laughed.

"Okay, but promise me you won't hide anything from me in the future."

"I promise, di. You are the best!" She gave a quick kiss to Kavya on cheeks.

"Is this dress allowed at the club?" she asked, looking at Sandhya.

"No. Jiju, we need to go shopping first."

"Look at the bag to your right, I already bought one."

Kavya took out the dress. It was a short, red dress."

"No way! It's too short."

"C'mon di... you'll look cool in it. Come on, wear it."

They halted at a restaurant nearby where she changed clothes quickly in the restroom. Aadi had bought all matching accessories. The dress barely crossed her thighs and was way above knees. Kavya was constantly pulling it down.

"Di, you look like a total babe, just don't get conscious. Here… Let me help you with makeup." Sandhya quickly fixed her liner, lipstick and half-tied her hair. Kavya looked beautiful.

She came out of the restaurant and people started turning their heads. Aditya held the door for both of them. Aditya gave her a hand to sit as she settled in the car. He kissed her hand. "You look beautiful, dear." Kavya blushed.

"Ahem, ahem... don't get any ideas, I am here."

"So what? She is my fiancé... and you don't get to say anything here, little girl..." Sandhya giggled.

For the first time, Kavya danced her heart out till her legs hurt. She was so happy that her life felt like a blessing. Aditya joined them on the dance floor shortly after and started dancing along. He was damn smooth on the dance floor and Kavya was surprised. Aditya wrapped his arms around her waist and started dancing. Kavya wrapped her arms around his neck. Aditya smiled, showing off his perfect dimples and Kavya skipped her heartbeat. '*Will I ever get used to this?*' He pressed his hands a bit harder and she looked down. Even in the noise and crowd of the club, she felt as if they were alone.

She playfully pushed him and took a quick turn and started dancing. Aditya laughed and joined her moves. Right then, a girl came and tapped his shoulder from behind. Aadi gave her a big smile and they hugged. Kavya immediately felt jealous. She whispered something in his ear. Aditya excused himself and they moved away.

Kavya noticed Aditya talking to her. That girl looked as if she had directly come from the cover of some fashion magazine. She seemed upset and Aditya was trying to explain her something. Kavya tried her level best to control herself but finally went to Aditya.

"Hi..."

"Hi, Kavya, meet Rachael, my friend."

"Rachael, meet Kavya, my fiancé."

Rachael saw Kavya top to bottom and gave a sarcastic smile. She offered a cold hand to Kavya saying pleasure.

Kavya had a confident handshake, she nodded and said, "Likewise."

Rachael raised her eyebrows. "All the best," she said and walked off. "What was that?" Kavya asked Aadi as soon as Rachael left. Aadi ran his hands through his hair and said, "We have a common friend's circle. She had proposed me a few months back and I said no. Now she got to know I am getting married and got upset."

"Oh..." Kavya said making a sad face.

"Hey, I never dated her, Manu."

"I know... But I am sure there must be many more like these."

Aadi smiled. "But my eyes are only struck on you."

"She is beautiful," Kavya said feeling sadder. "Then why me, Aadi?"

"Kavya, for heaven's sake... you are beautiful inside out. I am having a tough time here saving you from all the men around."

Kavya was not convinced, but she gave him a hug. "Aadi..."

"Hmm?"

She just hugged him back and they went home.

"Aadi, stop the car on the way, I need to change."

"Why?"

"I can't go home in these clothes. What will mom and dad think?"

"Come on, Kavya, they are very modern, they won't mind… trust me."

"Aadi, I am not feeling brave enough."

"Mostly they will be asleep by then, so please chill."

She could not argue ahead and kept quiet. Sandhya kept bumping and dancing even in the car.

Chapter 9

Next day morning, Kavya got up at six. She had slept with Sandhya and mom. She could not say goodnight properly to Aditya so she decided to meet him before he went to the office. Kavya knocked at his door twice but got no response. She, finally, opened the door and went inside. She saw her photo beside his bed and smiled. Right then, Aditya came out of the bathroom. He was wearing blue trousers with a white shirt. He was yet to button it up. Kavya saw him and realized he was getting dressed.

"Sorry, I should've... I will come back after some time."

"Wait, Manu."

"Aadi..."

"Relax sweetheart... it's not as if I am naked."

Kavya had no courage to look at him. Aditya was buttoning his shirt.

"Manu…"

She looked up and her eyes went to his toned, bare chest. Somehow, she lost control over herself and stared at his toned body. Aditya realized it and started unbuttoning the shirt.

"Wha... what are you doing Aadi?"

"I am doing what you want me to do but don't have the courage to say."

He walked towards her and she walked back. She reached the wall and Aditya opened his shirt completely.

He took her hand and kept it on his chest. "Touch me, Manu." Kavya closed her eyes with this sensation and looked down blushing. Aditya kissed her hard and Kavya responded back this time... her hands exploring him, feeling him. Aditya stopped when they both were out of breath. He looked at her and wiped her lips with his thumb.

"I love you, Manu." She blushed and tried escaping.

"Wait, Manu... go out after five minutes."

"Why?" She asked innocently.

"If you leave this room with this blush on your cheeks, everyone will understand we have been busy…"

"Oh..." she stepped back.

"I have ordered breakfast in the room," he said wearing his blazer. "Come, join me." She sat next to him and he pulled her in his arms.

"Aadi..."

"Oh come on, I really can't keep my hands to myself with you around. You will be going back today and we will probably meet directly for the wedding functions. Let us enjoy this moment together." She nodded shyly. They spoke of their wedding plans, arrangements, families, and everything they could think of.

"Aadi… I wanted to tell you something."

"What?"

"After years, I called someone dad. I can't explain to you the feeling."

"He is your dad, baby. He adores you."

"I know… it's just that after so many years, a complete family… it's a very…" She could not finish the sentence as she was very emotional. Aditya hugged her. "I miss uncle too. I am sure wherever he is, he will be very happy and proud of his daughter."

"Aadi…"

"Hmm?"

"Come to Mumbai, soon. I will miss you."

"I will miss you too, dear." He gave a quick peck on her forehead.

"Get ready quickly once I go to the office, okay? I can't wait to see you soon."

"I am already feeling nervous to stand in front of so many people as your fiancé."

"Our company is like our extended family, Kavya. They all are very close to dad and me. It's a very big day for me," Aditya said earnestly.

"I hope they will like me…"

"They will fall in love with you, Kavya, the way I did…"

"You say such sweet things," Kavya said.

"I know, I know," Aadi said, making faces and she giggled.

"I love this sound, baby."

"And I love your dimples when you smile," she said, running her fingers on his cheeks. Aditya turned his head and kissed her fingers and she looked down feeling shy.

"I am gonna miss you, baby. Come in my life soon."

"I am already yours, Aadi."

They gave one last hug to each other before Aadi left for work and Kavya went to her room. Kavita had got ready and gone down already. Sandhya was still sleeping.

She saw a bright blue designer sari with accessories on her dresser and got confused. She went down to ask mom.

"Mom, sari?"

"Yes, Kavya," Rashmi said. "For the office event, beta. They all will be seeing you for the first time. So we thought of sari, but only if you are comfortable. Else wear anything you like."

"No, no, I will wear the sari."

Rashmi and Kavita smiled.

"I have sent someone to help you with hair and makeup. Go get ready."

Kavya quickly took a shower and started wearing her sari. Sandhya was up. She was having breakfast. They heard a knock on the door; Sandhya quickly got up.

"Yes?"

"We are here to get Ms. Kavya ready," the ladies said.

"Here we go princess," Sandhya said looking at Kavya. They quickly took over the charge and started draping sari on Kavya. They made her hair and makeup in less than 20 minutes and they also helped Sandhya get ready shortly after. Kavya looked into the mirror and could not recognize herself. "Is that even me? How can I look so different?" Sandhya whistled looking at her and they both giggled and went down.

Kavita saw her daughters coming down and had tears in her eyes. Rashmi saw it and hugged her. "Now she is my daughter too, Kavita, don't worry about anything," Rashmi reassured her.

As soon as she reached down, Rashmi gave her a warm hug and said, "Shall we go?" Kavya just blushed and nodded. Rashmi called Shiv and informed they were starting from home. Shiv and Aditya had made all arrangements in the office already. All the employees were called to the auditorium.

Kavya reached office and gasped again. It was a multi-story, huge building. She gripped Sandhya's hand who patted it softly. They went directly to the auditorium. Aditya quickly came forward to take Kavya and the families on stage.

"You look beautiful, Manu," Aditya said. Kavya just blushed and looked down.

Shiv made a formal announcement of Aditya and Kavya's engagement declaring the marriage date and warmly inviting everyone for the reception. Kavya and Aditya joined hands to take everyone's blessing. Everyone clapped and cheered for them. Shiv and Aditya introduced Kavya to all key people in the company. Kavya was mentally trying to remember as many names and people as she could but in vain. The list was very long so she decided to study each person's profile during this break. The introduction session was followed by a grand lunch for the staff. Everyone got busy meeting people.

"Aadi..."

"Yes, Manu?"

'I must have done something really good in life to get so much love. It's all because of you. Thank you."

"I love you."

Kavya blushed and looked down.

"I..."

"I...?" Aditya said mocking her.

And she blushed harder.

"Don't be so cute, baby, I can't take you anywhere private right now."

"Shhh... Aadi... you are such a..."

"I am such a...?"

"Nothing..."

Aditya started laughing when Jatin joined them.

"Congratulations bhabi, congrats bro!" He hugged Aditya.

"Kavya, meet my brother, my best buddy and my… everything at work. Jatin."

"Jatin... Kavya..."

"Bhabi I have heard so much about you since the time we were in college, rather half of our batch knows your name."

"Jatiinn.... dude, relax..." and Jatin laughed.

"Some other time, enjoy your day," he said and left them alone.

Post lunch, they explored other venue options. One of them was a resort. Kavya loved it. It was less intimidating and had nice cozy huts. It was closer to nature. They entered the venue and Kavya had the perfect smile on her face. Shiv and Aditya looked at her and then looked at each other smiling. They both knew at that movement that this was the venue to be finalized. Everyone could not agree more.

After finalizing the venue, Kavya, Sandhya, and Kavita were standing near the car to go back. Both Aditya and Kavya looked sad when Sandhya beamed and said, "Guys, twenty-five days... that's it, then you love birds will be all free." Both of them smiled.

"Kavita, I will stay in touch with you for the preparations. Shiv has already the booked hall that you suggested. It's perfect.

You don't worry about any preparations though, we are there." Kavita hugged Rashmi and said thank you again.

"I wish I could also hug you," Aditya said and Kavya looked down blushing. "Then go for it, jiju. Who is stopping you?" Sandhya said in a low voice as she overheard the conversation. Aditya pulled her ear, "You are gone this time."

"Maaa, help..."

"I am sure you must have done something, Sandhya… Aadi, don't leave her," Kavya giggled as they both fought. Finally, he left Sandhya as he saw Kavita coming towards the car. He touched her feet and opened the door for her to sit. Kavya went and touched Shiv and Rashmi's feet. They blessed her and said, "We all are waiting for you, beta. Come soon." Kavya nodded with a smile.

Then, Kavya waved Aadi bye and got into the car.

As soon as the car started, Kavya's phone buzzed. It was Aadi. Sandhya started laughing. Someone can't stay away even for a minute." Kavita joined the laughter. Kavya saw the message:

"Manu, have a safe drive. Message me once you reach."

Kavya sent him a kiss smiley.

"Don't tease me, baby, I will come there right now."

"Haha, keep dreaming… you will meet me directly in the functions now."

"Love you, Manu."

"Love you too, Aadi." She texted.

Aditya saw the message and jumped in his room. He called her, but she disconnected the call.

"Manu, I want to talk to you right now."

"Mom around Aadi… I will call you tomorrow. BBye."

"Cheater!"

"Hehe… gn Aadi."

"Gn, Manu, I will wait for your call tomorrow morning."

Aditya smiled to himself when his phone buzzed. It was an email alert. He gave out a big sigh and got back to his study desk.

Next day morning, Kavya got a video call from Aditya.

"Hi…"

"Hii…"

"You were saying something last night," Aadi said.

"Oh, is it? I forgot… I think," Kavya said.

"Come on, Manu, I have waited for so long to hear it."

Kavya looked down.

"I wanted you to know my feelings, Aadi, that's why I told you. But I feel shy."

"Once Baby, look at me…"

She looked at the phone screen.

"Aadi… can I say it when we meet? Not now, please, I am not feeling brave enough."

Aadi smiled. "Okay. I love you."

She blushed harder.

"I got to go, baby. Miss me…"

Talking to Aadi over the phone; video calls; shopping trips… this was all new routine for Kavya. She kept telling herself not to take anything for granted and daily thanked God for all the happiness she was getting. Kavya learned all Aditya, Rashmi, and Shiv's favorite dishes from her mom. All three of them called her almost daily. Kavya also studied the profiles of all the critical people in the company - their names, tenures, departments… even there likes and dislikes, hobbies, etc. So that she could gel in the team faster. This was a new industry for Kavya so she dedicatedly studied the technical side in as much detail as she could on the internet. Days were passing by fast and marriage was coming close. All the invitations were sent. Her packing was almost over.

She packed her final bag. Last few hours in this house… So many memories… feelings… keeping all these behind and moving on. She was missing her father a lot. Today was Kavya's mehendi and tomorrow, wedding. She was extremely nervous, anxious, happy, and sad, all at the same time as if all the emotions were coming together and making her stomach flutter. She badly wanted to talk to Aadi, but she knew even he

would be surrounded by relatives right now. She was almost in tears, not knowing what to do. Sandhya and Kavita were busy attending guests, and her phone buzzed. It was Aadi…

"Hi…"

"Hi, Manu. How are you, all set?"

"Aadi… I am very nervous."

"It's our day, baby. Don't be nervous, I am there with you on every step you take ahead from now on."

"Hmm…"

"Kavya, are you crying?"

Kavya sobbed a bit more.

"Leaving my mom and Sandhya behind… so many memories… it's all very intimidating."

"Baby, you are not going to leave anything. They will always be there with you."

"Hmm."

"Come on, cheer up now. Give me a quick smile."

"Hmm."

"I will come there right now and tickle you otherwise…"

This thought made her smile.

"Manu, you are my world. You don't need to worry about anything. I am there with you, okay?"

"Hmm."

"I love you."

"Come soon, Aadi…"

"Say it, baby."

And she giggled…

Aditya smiled… "Now, that's my girl! I will see you very soon."

Kavya kept the phone down. She was feeling better but still overwhelmed. She decided to step out of her room and was immediately surrounded by relatives and loud chatter. Mehendi artist had just arrived so they started the ritual shortly.

Kavya closed her eyes and remembered her father. She took his blessings before applying mehendi. She saw her mom on call, crying. She called her to be with her.

"What happened, mom?"

Nothing…"

"Who had called? Why are you crying?"

Kavita smiled. "It was Aditya. He told me you both spoke and you were crying. So he assumed that even I must be emotional, so he called me."

"Oh, what did he say?"

"He said, your daughter will be yours for the rest of the life, just accept me as your son now."

Kavya smiled but had tears dropping from her eyes. He was so thoughtful of everything. She wanted to text him right away or talk to him, but both her hands had mehendi.

She called Sandhya…

"Sandhya, I need a favor."

"What sis?"

'Come here," she asked her to bend forward.

"I want to talk to Aadi in private…"

Sandhya giggled.

"Sandhya, shut up! I am serious."

"Di, it's just a question, of a few hours now, control, dear," and she giggled again.

Everyone started laughing. Kavya blushed very hard and left the topic. She made a mental note to thank him whenever they meet next.

She was sitting with mehendi on her hands. Sandhya was occupied too, taking care of guests. Kavya felt bad that she was not able to help her sister today. Very unlike Sandhya, she was behaving all matured and grown up, all of a sudden. After some time, Sandhya sat near her and kept her head on her shoulders. She was tired of running around. Kavya softly kissed her forehead and got emotional.

"I am going to miss you, di…"

"I will miss you too, Sandhya." Tears started flowing out of their eyes. They hugged each other when all the relatives started consoling them, teasing Sandhya that she was the next in line. Kavya smiled at the thought of Sandhya's marriage. '*Yes, one*

day she will be where I am today.' Sandhya defended herself saying it was a far-fetched thought and she had to focus on her studies right now and then her career. Kavya agreed to her and got into the discussion.

Kavita came with the lunch plate in the meantime and joined both her daughters. Sandhya was getting mehendi done on her hand so Kavita offered to feed lunch to both of them. They both agreed quickly. Kavya ate a few bites. She was looking at Kavita. Kavita was very tired. She took it all on herself to cook food instead of ordering out. She was up very early as she wanted to ensure Kavya ate everything she liked before getting married.

Kavya was way too emotional to continue eating. Tears started running her eyes again. So much love… care… her family was doing everything they could to make her happy. She thanked God for everything and was praying for her mother and sister's happiness. Kavita saw Kavya crying and started crying herself. Kavya quickly got up and went to the balcony. She needed fresh air.

Kavita joined her there with the lunch plate. "Eat, beta… you have a very long day tomorrow. Besides, I don't know when I will get a chance to feed my daughter again like this." On these words, Kavya hugged Kavita and started crying badly. "I will always be your daughter, mom. I will never grow up for you." Kavita consoled her, "Of course you will always be my little princess." She kissed Kavya's forehead and forcibly made her finish her plate and turned to go back to the kitchen.

"Maa…"

"Yes?"

"Did you eat?"

"No, I will eat now. I am not hungry."

"No maa, please wait here."

"Chachi…" she called her aunt to make a plate for Mom.

"Please sit here with me for some time and eat."

Kavita nodded and sat next to Kavya as chachi brought a plate with food.

"Just imagine, Kavya, a few hours from now, you will come here as Mrs. Aditya Joshi," Kavita said smiling but had tears in her eyes.

"Maa… please, now you don't get started."

She wiped her tears and nodded.

"Maa, you need to promise me something."

"What?"

"You will not take catering orders without domestic help… or even better, don't take orders at all."

"We both know, Kavya, that's not possible. You know the expenses."

"Maa, I will be earning. I will send my whole salary. Don't worry about finances. I will take care of it. But I don't want you to do this alone."

"Okay, I will have domestic help."

"Hmm…" Kavya nodded.

"Kavya, you need to stop worrying about us. We will be fine. You need to openly embrace your new world. If you want us to be happy, then you need to be happy first."

"I am trying, maa. It's all very sudden."

"Aditya is a good boy and you always loved him… It's a rare treasure to love someone and get loved back from the same person. Your father and I had very few years of togetherness. But they were so good that those memories are enough for my lifetime. I am glad my daughter is experiencing the happiness of loving someone and getting it back. Don't ruin it by worrying about us. Set yourself free beta."

Kavya nodded shyly.

"I love you, mom."

"I love you too, beta."

Kavita went inside. Kavya was feeling better after talking to her mom. She was standing by the window when Sandhya quickly clicked her pic.

"Sandhya… What are you doing?"

"Di, Jiju was missing you; he wanted to see you."

"Sandhya, wait… let me see."

"Sent already di," Sandhya giggled and immediately got a call.

"Hi, Jiju."

"Hey… wassup?"

"Nothing much, I am done with mehendi on one hand so enjoying the freedom of one hand. Di is stuck though."

Aditya laughed. "I need a favor from you."

"Anything for you, jiju. Tell me?"

"I wanna talk to Kavya for two minutes, can you arrange?"

"And what do I get in return?"

"Anything you want, dear."

"Just promise me to keep my sister happy, okay?" Sandhya said getting emotional.

"Sandhya, tell me one thing…"

"Hmm?"

"Do all three of you have this problem?"

"Which problem?"

"All three of you cry even with the blink of an eye."

Sandhya laughed at this and wiped her tears. "You are stealing my big sister from me. I can't help it."

"Your sister is not going anywhere, Sandhya. You are just getting an additional partner in crime."

This time she really laughed. "Hold on a second. Let me give the phone to her."

Sandhya attached headphones and kept the phone in Kavya's lap. "It's jiju." Kavya immediately had a smile on her face.

"Jiju, I must confess something… nothing can cheer up di's mood the way you do."

Aadi smiled.

Kavya told Sandhya with eyes to leave… Yeah yeah… I am going… Kavya smiled as she left.

"Hii…"

"Hii…"

There was a long silence…

"Say something," Aadi said.

You called, you say something. I don't know what to say."

"Hmmm… I am missing you, Manu."

"We are meeting in a few hours."

"Yeah, in a few hours, you will be mine forever…"

"I am already yours, Aadi."

Aadi smiled raising his eyebrows. "Kavya…"

"Hmmm?"

"I love it when you openly acknowledge your feelings."

She smiled…

"Don't be shy, baby. I mean it."

"How can you know exactly what I feel?"

Aadi laughed. "Just… magic."

"Aadi…"

"Hmmm?"

"We will be married by this time tomorrow…"

"Yes… you will be Mrs. Kavya Aditya Joshi."

Kavya's breath stuck for a second. "It still all feels like a dream, Aadi."

"Few dreams come true, baby. You coming to my life is one of them."

"Aadi… I am nervous."

"Don't be, baby, I will be there with you. You just relax and enjoy your day."

"Hmmm."

"And say…"

Kavya giggled. "I can't think straight right now. Can't think of anything…"

"Then think of our time together in my house… in my bedroom."

Kavya's cheeks started turning red at those memories. "Aadi please…"

"Please what baby?"

"I mean please don't…"

"Don't?"

"I am feeling shy."

Aadi laughed. "Soon you will be all mine, Manu. Get used to this…"

Kavya was too short of words to respond.

"Love you, Kavya."

"I… I will see you tomorrow, Aadi. Missing you."

"Miss you too, dear. Listen…"

"Hmmm?"

"Go to sleep early tonight. We have a big day and long night tomorrow."

"Aadi…" Kavya felt shy and covered her face with her hands.

"Haha, I am sure you must be looking like a bright red rose right now. So won't tease you more. Bye baby."

"Bye Aadi."

Kavya disconnected the call and had a fully flushed face. She decided to stay back until her pulse normalized. She was looking forward to tomorrow now.

Chapter 10

The day started very early. At 4 am, all makeup artists and dressers came to get Kavya ready. She was not used to it at all. She was extremely excited. It was for the first time in her life she was getting dressed like this. Sandhya kept beaming around getting ready and helping to finalize things. Sandhya was avoiding getting emotional as much as she could. She tried being away from Kavya's room and kept doing household work and took care of guests. Kavita had got ready early in the morning. She was sitting in front of the home temple and was chanting prayers for her daughter's happiness.

Kavya got ready after around two hours and looked in the mirror. She could not believe her own reflection. She was wearing a bright red Kanjivaram sari with golden border; hair neatly tied in braid… a few unruly hair came on her face. She was wearing all the jewelry given by her mom and her in-laws. The sari was draped differently showing her perfect curves. She felt shy looking at her own reflection. She was wondering how Aadi must be looking. It was just a few days they had not met, but she was missing him already.

Aditya could not sleep the whole night. The entire house was decorated like a bride. There were decorators specially hired for house decoration for Kavya's grand welcome. Aditya wore a cream color kurta with a bright red dupatta to match Kavya's Sari. All family members were around him all the time, chatting,

teasing him… So he could not call Kavya after yesterday evening. He was pacing in his house waiting for everyone to get ready so that they could go to the marriage hall. Watching him restless, everyone teased him all the more.

Kavya's family reached the hall. It was decorated with red, white, and pink roses. She was sitting on the stage with her mother. The rituals started. Kavya focused completely on the rituals and did not notice Aditya coming. She had closed her eyes and was praying when Aadi entered the hall. He saw her and stopped at the door. Her beauty never ceased to amaze him. To top it, today was the first time he saw Kavya had got ready so nicely. '*I must have done something really good in life to have her,*' he thought. He was very eager to talk to her. She opened her eyes and saw him staring at her. Not knowing how to respond, she waved at him. He gave out a small laugh at her gesture. '*How can someone be this cute?*' He waved her back and his family members started laughing at them. "They both are like love-struck puppies," everyone said. Kavya quickly looked down in embarrassment. Aditya was still standing there and watching her. His family finally shook him and brought him out of the thought trail.

Aditya was asked to join the stage with his family for the rituals. He sat next to Kavya. Kavya was too shy to even look at him. She was trying her level best to focus on the instructions of the pandit and was following them. Aditya finally spoke.

"Manu…"

"Hmmm?"

"Look at me."

"Shh… concentrate," she said, trying to hide her smile.

"You look beautiful."

"So do you, Aadi. Now, concentrate."

Aadi smiled. "Manu…"

Shiv cleared his throat as he heard Aadi talking. He quickly straightened up and Kavya giggled softly. Aadi looked down embarrassed. "Keep patience for a few hours, son. Focus on the rituals, then you have the whole life to talk." Shiv told Aadi in

a low voice. Aadi nodded. He closed his eyes and thanked God once again for bringing Kavya to his life."

Aditya and Kavya performed all the required rituals. Pandit Ji handed over Mangalsutra to Aditya and asked him to tie it around Kavya's neck. Aditya saw her through it. This is it… the moment they became man and wife. Kavya looked at him, their eyes met and both of them were flooded with emotions. The moment both of them were looking forward to, for so many days… years… this was it. Kavya looked at Aadi and closed her eyes joining hands, thanking God for this happiness. She promised in her heart to give every happiness in this world to Aditya. Aditya tied mangalsutra and whispered in her ear, "Congratulations Mrs. Joshi." Kavya blushed with her eyes closed.

A few more hours went with the rituals. Aditya and Kavya could not talk to each other much as there were people around all the time. However, they were very happy. Both families were very happy; it was visible on their faces. It was a very close-knit function with only family members and close friends, which made it all the more memorable and special. Both Kavya and Aditya did not opt for a formal reception on stage with photos. Instead, they both spent time with family members sitting around together, laughing, and having fun. The photographer was clicking candid photos of both of them.

Kavya sat next to Aadi for lunch. Their hands brushed and Kavya felt the same wave of feelings run through her body. She looked up at Aadi, who was already looking at her. From his look, she could tell, he felt the same. She felt shy and looked down. As she put her hand on her lap, Aditya quickly grabbed it. Kavya got scared and tried to pull her hand back as they were surrounded by the whole family. She looked at Aadi with pleading eyes, to let go of her hand. Aditya was relaxed as if nothing happened.

"Aadi…" Kavya said in low voice.

"Hmmm?"

"Leave my hand."

"I don't need to… I am holding the hand of my wife now."

Kavya smiled and looked down. "There are people around, Aadi."

"So?"

"I want to eat, I am famished…"

"Let me feed you." Aadi raised a spoon towards her and everyone saw and started cheering him. Kavya turned red. She ate it and pleaded once again.

"Please…"

"Alright angel."

After lunch, Kavita and Sandhya started packing Kavya's final bags to send them with her. Kavita was miserably crying. Sandhya was trying her best to hold back her emotions. Kavya was sitting out with her new family. She realized Kavita and Sandhya were not around for long and started searching for them. Aditya saw that and asked her what was wrong.

"Aadi, I can't see Mom and Sandhya."

"Let me see." Aadi got up.

"No, let me go…"

"Then let's go together," he held her hand.

"Excuse me, everyone, we will be back in a movement."

"Sit down Aditya, why are you in so much hurry to leave. Spend some time with us too," his family teased. Kavya felt shy and tried freeing her hand.

Aadi just winked and said "Can't wait," and started walking with her while everyone laughed.

"Aadi, what they must be thinking…"

Aadi laughed harder, "Get used to it, Kavya, I love showing my love in public."

She pinched him.

"Ouch… what are you doing?"

"I love pinching you in public," she said and started giggling.

"I missed this sound," Aadi said softly bringing her hand to his face and softly kissed it.

"Shhh… what are you doing? We are here to search for my mom."

"Yeah… let's check the room inside."

They are not there. Where were they? Kavya got worried. Aadi pressed her hand. "Hey, relax. They will be around. Let's check the other room." They both were sitting there, hugging each other and crying their hearts out. Kavya saw them and landed in tears herself. She clung to Aditya's hand and closed the door before they saw her.

"Manu…" Before he could say anything ahead, she was in his arms, crying.

"Manu, look at me…"

She nodded saying 'no' in his chest.

"Manu… for heaven's sake, please don't cry, I can't take it. Look at me."

She looked up, wiping her tears.

"Sandhya was your sister till today, now she is my sister too, and your mom is now my mom too. I promise you, they will be fine."

"I am going to miss them, Aadi."

"I know, but we will keep coming to visit them."

She was still crying.

"Manu, do you want to take them to Pune today along with us?"

Kavya smiled at the thought and Aadi visibly relaxed.

"No," she nodded.

"Then, be strong baby… we need to do this together, okay? They will be fine when they know you are happy."

She nodded again.

"You look sad, I am feeling bad, baby."

She finally wiped her tears and looked at him with a smile. "I am fine…"

"That's my girl. Come, let's go inside."

Aadi opened the door.

"Hello there…"

Before Kavita could react, Aditya went and hugged her tight.

"Aditya, what are you doing."

"I am not going to leave you till you stop crying, mom."

Kavya was standing beside Sandhya, consoling her. They both laughed as they saw Kavita struggling to come out of Aditya's embrace.

"No, I am not leaving you. First, you need to stop crying."

Kavita landed in tears once again in Aditya's arms. Aditya started slowly consoling her, "Kavya is not going away from you. She is just a phone call away. Now you have one son added to your kids. Please don't cry."

Kavita patted Aditya's back and finally came out of his embrace. "I know you will take good care of my daughter. I am not worried. I am just emotional."

Once he saw Kavita coming back to normal, he shifted his focus to Sandhya and pulled her cheeks. She got annoyed… "Ouch… what are you doing?"

"Haha… I love doing this," he said.

"Jiju… leave me!"

"I am so glad Kavya told me what makes you mad. You dare cry again, and I will do this each time…"

"Di… you told him? Jiju… leave me…" they both started fighting. Both Kavya and Kavita laughed and looked at each other.

"Take care of your health, mom. And don't skip meals, I won't be there to scold you now." Kavita nodded and they both hugged landing in tears again.

"Oh God! Come on, not again please…"

Aditya hugged both of them when they heard the door open. It was Shiv and Rashmi, they came searching for Aditya and Kavya. Rashmi went to Kavya and pulled her in her hug. When you both were gone for so long, I wondered where you are, so we decided to come." Rashmi held Kavita's hand and said, "We all are one family now, Kavita. Come to Pune anytime you feel like. It's your house too. Please don't worry about Kavya. I always wanted her as my daughter, you know it. Today is a dream come true for me."

Sandhya was watching it all and was controlling herself. She was looking okay from outside, but from within, she felt

terrible. Kavya was her support system. She looked up to her for everything. All of a sudden, she was feeling absolutely lonely, as if she was in a dark room sitting alone. '*Don't cry, Sandhya, not now; some more time… then you will get alone time to cry. Pull up for some more time…*' she kept telling herself.

Rashmi and Shiv went ahead to coordinate and pull out the cars. Kavya and Aditya said their final goodbyes to Kavita and Sandhya. They got into the car. It was only two of them and the driver. Aditya wanted it that way as he knew they won't get to talk at all during the full day because of rituals and family members.

Kavya let out a big sigh as the car moved out of the venue. Aditya knew she was still emotionally shaken with the feeling of leaving her family behind. He pulled her in his arms and before he could say anything, she was crying again.

"Cry your heart out, baby. I can understand." His hands were running through her hair, consoling her, calming her down, softly kissing her forehead apologizing for taking her away from her family. Kavya was holding Aditya's hand so tightly that it almost hurt. He could feel the depth of her sadness and promised himself in the heart '*today will be the last day she is crying. Her life ahead will be full of only happiness*'.

Kavya felt better after crying for some time and got control over herself. She realized she was in Aditya's arms and there was a driver sitting in front. She quickly tried to straighten herself, but Aditya held her back thinking she is pulling off from crying.

"Relax baby, cry your heart out. I am here for you."

"Aadi… I am fine now," she said in a meek voice, then she whispered in his ear, "Let me sit straight, the driver must be watching us."

Aadi smiled knowing she was fine now. "Then let him watch, you are my wife now."

"Shh… Let me go." She tried sitting straight

He pulled her back. "On one condition."

"What?" She looked up innocently at him.

"Don't look at me like this, baby… we still have a full evening to go."

She smiled and ducked her head down.

"Say you love me and I will let you go for now…"

"Aadi…"

"Say it, baby."

She shook her head.

"Say, I…"

"I…"

"Say, love…"

She pulled Aditya's Kurta down and he got surprised. She quickly gave him a kiss on his cheek which took him by surprise and he loosened his grip for a second. Kavya quickly sat straight as his hands shifted and started giggling.

"Cheater," he said.

She blew him a kiss and Aadi raised his eyebrows.

"Wait for some time, baby, then this blown kiss won't be sufficient."

She looked down feeling shy.

"I love it when you turn shy. You look perfect with flushed cheeks," Aadi said, running his fingers on her cheeks. "Aadi…" she eyed at him and pointing towards the driver that he might be listening.

The Drive back to Pune went with all the light-hearted flirting and talking. Aditya was ensuring Kavya calms down and is okay before they reached home. Meanwhile, he texted both Kavita and Sandhya ensuring they are fine. Their car was about to reach home. Aadi took Kavya's hand in his and said, "I hope you will like the look of our house."

'*Our house*…' Kavya's mind lingered around the thought for some time. New house… new life… so many people in the house… such a big place… She got nervous with the thought and her hand pulled out naturally.

Aditya realized it and asked her, "Are you nervous, Manu?" She looked down and nodded.

"I am noticing since morning, why are you not looking at me?"

"Coz I am feeling shy."

"Shy of?"

"Just… you are looking very …"

"Very?"

"Very good today."

Aditya laughed. "That's not what you were about to say. I am looking very…?"

"God… Aadi… please not now. We are about to reach."

"Say it, baby…"

"If I look at you, I don't think I will be able to look anywhere else. How can you look so sexy even in ethnic wear?" Kavya said almost as if she was complaining. Aditya laughed hard on this and said, "You have a funny way to give compliments, sweetheart…" She realized what she had said. "Oh God!" She covered her face in her hand. Aditya softly pulled her hands and turned her face to make her look at him.

"I love it when I see you falling for me."

"I have fallen for you so hard, Aadi, it scares me at times."

"The feeling is mutual, Manu," he said softly kissing her hand.

"Stop it Aadi."

"Why?"

"Coz otherwise I won't be able to stop myself," she said pulling her hands back. Aditya raised his eyebrow. "Is it? Then let's see how far can you control." His hands started trailing her hands slowly crawling to her shoulders. His fingers softly brushed her neck, going to her back. Kavya had closed her eyes. It felt as if something was burning inside every place he touched her. Her breath had quickened. She held his hand. "Please stop," she said. He pulled her in his embrace and said, "Can't wait to have you all by myself honey."

"Me too," she said.

They reached home. Kavya was stunned looking at the decoration. It was way over the top to what she had thought

of. The entire house was covered with lights and flowers. The theme was peach and white, Kavya's favorite colors. She was struggling to see even an inch of wall. She held Aditya's hand tightly, who patted it softly.

"Do you like it, baby?"

"This is all so beautiful, Aadi. I still can't believe my eyes!"

"It's all peach and white… reminds me of the first time I saw you after coming back." She looked at him in confusion and then realized, "Oh, the day I met you to hand over the gulab jamuns." He smiled fondly. "Yes."

"What did I do in my life to deserve so much love and happiness, Aadi?" Kavya said, almost in tears. "Hey, don't cry, please. You mean the world to me, Manu, I want every happiness in this world for you." She held his hand and said, "Aadi…" He looked at her and she said, "I love you…" Aditya raised his eyebrow in surprise and beamed. She finally said it. "Manu…" Before he could say anything more, the driver opened the door of the car and Kavya giggled wiping her tears.

"You have a very bad timing sense, Mrs. Joshi."

"Teach me then, Mr. Joshi," Kavya said, challenging him.

"I have way better things to teach you today, sweetheart. Just wait for it."

Kavya realized what he is referring to and turned red. Aditya got down and gave her a hand to get down from the car. The entire staff showered flowers on them as they entered the house. Rashmi and Shiv welcomed Kavya with a warm hug and watery eyes.

There was a small family dinner arranged with close family to welcome Kavya. The formal reception was tomorrow. Shiv popped open the champagne and raised a toast for Kavya and Aditya wishing them the best for their married life. This was followed by cake cutting and dance. The entire evening went in teasing, chit-chat, and music. Shiv and Rashmi knew how to throw a party. People looked forward to it. Today was a very big day and they did not leave any stone unturned to make it fully special for Kavya.

Kavya was not used to sari's much and was feeling uncomfortable now. The beautician had draped it so well, it did not move even an inch through the day. But it did not help. Rashmi realized it and asked her if she wanted to change. She just shook her head to say 'no'. Her mom had told her not to dress casually if there were people around.

All the family members slowly started heading back. Aditya's cousins took Kavya to Aditya's room teasing her. She was completely flushed with their constant teasing.

They left the room shortly after. Kavya was standing by the window. There was a big mango tree just outside the window so she was not able to see the moon clearly, but the room was filled with moonlight. She opened the window to feel the fresh air. As soon as she opened the window, she felt a cold breeze and quickly closed it back. She looked at the room. It was decorated with red roses.

She was nervous. '*Am I ready for this? Where is Aditya? Aditya…*' Her mind mingled around his thoughts a bit longer. She remembered all the moments spent in the last few days. Aadi's sudden visit to Mumbai; his proposal; her visit to Pune; their marriage… it all still felt like a dream. After all, Aditya was her sweetest dream, and he was her husband now.

She remembered his words before entering the house and felt shy. She looked out of the window again and suddenly heard the click of unlocking the door. Her heart pulsed up. She was too shy to look back at the door. She heard the door closing behind. Her hands reached the end of her sari and she clung to it looking down. '*Is it Aadi? Of course, it must be Aadi… who else will come at this hour?*' She waited for long to hear his voice but did not hear anything. Finally, she gathered all her courage and looked around. She saw Aditya was standing right in front of her, a few feet away, relaxed, in his black pants with a grey t-shirt, leaning against the wall and watching her. She was too nervous to know what to do. His eye contact was so strong, it almost told her not to look away.

"Hi…" She managed to say. Aditya smiled. "Hi," he said. There was a long silence again. Kavya gave a shy smile and looked out of the window. Aditya stepped towards her. She took a step back as soon as she realized. Their eyes met. Aadi stopped there and raised her hand towards her. She looked at him nervously. He gave her a reassuring nod asking for her hand. Nervously, she gave her hand in his and in an instant, he pulled her in an embrace. Kavya almost melted in the moment. All the reluctance, nervousness, doubts… all of it went at that moment. This was her comfort place.

Aadi hugged her and whispered in her ear, "Manu…"

"Hmmm?"

"I have waited for this moment for years. I can't forget this day for the rest of my life."

"Me too…" she said softly.

He pulled her out of the embrace and looked at her. "You look lovely."

"Thank you… but why did you change?" Kavya asked a bit disappointed.

"Why? You wanted to undress me yourself? I can wear it back if you want!"

"No, no…. I didn't mean it that way," Kavya said looking at him and saw a mischievous grin on his face. She realized Aditya was just pulling her leg and she felt embarrassed. She covered her face in his hands and went back in his embrace. Aditya laughed.

"Manu…"

"Hmmm?"

"I love you."

"I..."

He pulled her away and held her face in hand. She looked away. "Come on! Once, please…" She hugged him and whispered in his ear, "I love you too, Aadi." His hands moved to her waist and touched her bare skin. Nervousness hit her once again. She tried pulling away. Aadi realized her nervousness and whispered in her ear, "Nervous baby?" She nodded softly.

"Me too." This caught her attention and looked up. "We will take it slow, we have the whole life together, Aadi said." Kavya was again deeply touched by his thoughtfulness. She again had tears in her eyes. "For heaven's sake, lady, if you cry again… You will have consequences," Aadi said, running his hand through his hair.

She gave out a small laugh and nodded. "I am just too nervous, emotional, anxious… I don't know what more right now."

"You don't need to feel any of it, Kavya. You are with me now and I will wait till you are ready. I just want one promise."

"What?"

"You will come and tell me when you are ready. Don't feel shy at that time."

She looked down feeling shy on his comment and nodded in agreement. "You are not angry at me, right? It's just that I… I mean…"

Aadi took her hands. "What Kavya?"

"I don't know…"

"You don't know what?"

"I mean I know… but I have never…"

Aadi realized what she wanted to say. "You need to learn to communicate openly with me, Kavya. I know you don't have any experience." She looked up. "How do you know that?" He smiled, "I can read your body better than you, Kavya." She looked down. "That's why we will take it slow. But for now, let me kiss my wife." Holding her face in his hands, he came forward to kiss her. His eyes closed automatically as he leaned forward. Kavya quickly pinched his hand.

"Ouch! What are you doing?" She started giggling and ran away. Aadi smiled. "You better come back angel," Aadi said walking towards her. She kept walking backward till she hit the wall, then she started sliding over. Aditya reached her and held both her hands. She tried getting free and Aadi smiled. "Try it, baby." He quickly planted soft kisses on her hand without breaking eye contact with her. She felt shy looking at

the raw desire in his eyes and was afraid her own raw feelings might be visible in her eyes. She looked away. Aditya released her hands and held her waist. Her skin burned as he touched her and she let out a soft moan. Aadi kissed her neck and she gave him a hug. He held her head and touched his lips on her, holding back the kiss. She was tentatively kissing him back. The desire became intense inside as he did not kiss her the way she anticipated from her experience with Aadi. He was purposely holding back to tease her, to provoke her. He was dying to take control and kiss her hard, but he had to give her time to learn and explore.

She nervously kissed his lips back slowly, not knowing what to do. She tightened her grip of hands and looked down. "Aadi, you are killing me." He smiled and held her head. He kissed her sucking her lips softly, his hands exploring her flesh. She let out a soft moan as his hand slid inside the sari. Taking the cue, Aadi deepened the kiss and explored her mouth with his tongue. She sucked it. Aadi was trying his best to control and go slow. He did not want to scare Kavya with his raw passion for her. Her hand went in his t-shirt and Aadi lost control. He swiftly lifted her up and she got scared.

"Aadi, what are you doing?" Aadi smiled. "Taking you to bed honey."

"Put me down, I can walk." Aadi laughed. She punched him softly and clung his shirt tightly. "Don't… I am getting scared. Please put me down."

"Aah… there you are. Kiss me and I will put you down," he said leaning forward offering his cheek for her to kiss. She softly kissed it. "Please put me down now."

"Say, Aadi, I love you…"

"Haha… No way!" She said pretending to be brave.

"Oh, is it?" Aditya loosened his grip a bit to give her the feeling as if she was going to fall and she hugged him tighter. "I will fall…" Aditya laughed harder and placed her carefully on the bed leaning beside her. Kavya looked away, her hair fell in soft curves on her face. Aditya moved them away with

his fingers and kissed her cheeks. Aadi's hand flowed over her body, exploring her… feeling her… A strong heat of desire ran through her body and she hugged him. Her sari was falling apart as she turned. She became nervous and got up.

"What happened, Manu?"

"N… nothing… just…"

He got up and hugged her from behind knowing this was too much for her.

"We will wait till you are ready," he said kissing her neck from behind.

"I am sorry, Aadi… I didn't want to disappoint you."

"Hey…" He made her turn. "Stupid girl, it's just the first night. I know we have rushed our marriage and have not spent enough time together. We have a complete life ahead. I am not disappointed or anything. In fact, I had thought of this way before."

She took his hand in hers and kissed it softly, curving her lips saying thank you. She was chocked with his love and respect for space. He planted a soft kiss on her lips and pulled her in an embrace.

Chapter 11

Kavya got up in the morning too warm. It was just sunrise. She was still in Aditya's embrace. Her sari was on the floor and she remembered the night before. She flushed with the very thought of the events. She looked up at Aadi. He was sleeping peacefully. It was the best site to wake up to. She slowly came out of his embrace and slept some distance away, watching him… watching his features. It was a rare chance as she usually felt shy to look at him openly. She ran her fingers through his hair softly, so that she does not wake him up. Unknowingly, her fingers went over his cheeks and she got scared he might wake up. She tried pulling back her hand when Aadi held it saying, "Touch me, baby."

"Oh gosh, Aadi, are you up already?" He opened his eyes and gave an amused smile. "Well, I can get used to this…" She tried freeing her hand, but he pulled her close.

"Leave me, Aadi, everyone will be waiting for us."

"Give me my good morning kiss and I will set you free," he said, leaning back in bed stretching his other arm.

"Aadi please…"

He pulled her quickly, making her fall on top of him.

"Kavya please…" Aadi said, mimicking her. She looked down. "After a shower," she whispered and looked into his eyes. "I will wait," he said and kissed her hand before releasing her.

She ran to the washroom to hide and came out after a minute to take her clothes and towel. Aadi was still in bed. She got stuck at his stretched site.

"Quit staring, Manu…"

"How do you know I am looking at you?"

He leaned on one hand and gave her a lazy smile. She felt like running in his arms and kissing him hard but did not have the courage to follow her heart. She took a step back and went to the washroom. '*Soon*,' Aadi thought.

Kavya took the shower thinking of Aditya. Her heart skipped a beat every time he saw her. She wrapped herself in a bathrobe and stepped out. She saw Aditya was standing near the window with a cup of coffee in his hand. She had thought he would be gone by the time she came out.

"Oh…" she saw him on a call and stood there, clinging to her robe. Aditya raised his eyebrow looking at her and continued the call. She looked irresistible. Kavya was too stunned to pick up her clothes and go back to the washroom as if his eyes commanded her to stay there. She finally came to her senses and reached her dress. Aadi held her hand and wound up the call.

"You look edible, Kavya." She blushed and tried picking up her clothes. Aadi pushed her to the wall, "Do you know you have a sweet pink tinge all over your body when you blush?" Kavya looked at him as she did not understand what he was saying. He shifted her robe a bit from her shoulders, showing her skin turning pink and kissed softly. "Oh God…" she whispered. "I like red," he said, pointing towards her red bra and she blushed harder, getting embarrassed. Aditya saw it and kissed her forehead before walking back, but Kavya held his hand.

"It was a pleasant surprise." She pulled him towards her softly and hugged him. Aadi was waiting for this. He hugged her hard, crushing her in his arms. She was on fire with desire. She gave a love bite on his neck and Aadi let out a soft moan. "You are driving me crazy, lady. If you continue this, I won't be able to hold back."

"I don't want you to hold back," she whispered. Aadi pulled her out of the embrace, to look at her. "Are you sure? I thought you are not ready," he asked, not able to believe his ears. She was looking down at her hands. She just nodded saying yes.

"Why you did not say anything yesterday?"

"I wanted to tell you, but I was nervous. I still am, but that doesn't mean I…"

Before she could say anything, Aadi pulled her close and crushed her mouth kissing her hard. She kissed him back with equal passion. He opened her robe and pulled her close to him and Kavya let out a soft moan. Her hands reached his back when they both heard the door knock.

Kavya got scared and Aditya laughed. "Relax, Manu…" he planted a soft kiss on her cheeks and handed over her clothes. She was too embarrassed to react and quickly ran to the washroom. Aditya opened the door and saw Rashmi.

"Hi, mom."

"Good morning, son." She kissed his forehead and looked around. "Where is Kavya?"

"She is getting ready."

"Oh, that's great. But it's pretty early even now. I had come just to tell you both to relax and don't be in a hurry to come down. I am sending breakfast upstairs."

"You are the best mom," Aadi said.

Rashmi laughed. "I know, I know."

Rashmi was about to leave when Kavya stepped out of the washroom. She was wearing a light olive colored dress. She looked very different with Sindoor, Mangalsutra, and green bangles, and her hair open and taken on one side.

"Here she is…" Rashmi stepped ahead and Kavya touched her feet. Rashmi pulled her in a hug instead. "Good morning, beta," Rashmi said.

"Good morning, Mom."

"Are you okay, you look flushed? I hope you don't have a fever," she said checking her forehead. Kavya got embarrassed and Aditya gave her a mischievous smile. "No, mom, I just

took a hot shower. Maybe that's why…" Kavya said. "Sorry, I am late." "Nonsense, you are up very early. It's just six-thirty am. We have a relaxed day today. Don't worry. I am sending breakfast upstairs."

"We all can have it together, downstairs," Kavya said. Aditya nodded 'no' from behind and Rashmi noticed it and laughed. Kavya looked down not knowing how to react.

"Chill. We all have breakfast in our rooms on holidays. I just dropped in to say good morning. Make yourself at home and let me know if you need anything."

Kavya smiled, feeling relaxed.

Rashmi stepped out and Aditya closed the door quickly. "Aadi, what are you doing?"

"My wife just told me something, a few minutes ago. I want to hear it again."

Kavya blushed and turned back. "A few things are not to be said, they are to be understood."

"Oh really?" Aadi said giving her a hug from behind when the servant knocked on the door. "Oops!" Kavya said, giggling.

Kavya and Aditya stepped away quickly. "Hi, Ruchi," Kavya said.

"Hi, bhabi, I just came to confirm if you would like to have breakfast here or downstairs."

"Downstairs…" Kavya said warmly.

"Sure, it will be ready in ten minutes."

"Okay…" Aadi said and Ruchi stepped out.

"Aadi, I know mom said we can have breakfast here, but it's my first day after our marriage, I want to have it with mom and dad."

Aadi smiled and said, "Alright, but you won't get away with all these excuses for long." He smiled and his perfect dimple showed off once again. Kavya quickly gave him a peck on his cheek and whispered, "I don't wish to get away for long." Before he could catch her, she stepped back and giggled.

"Keep teasing and I will make you pay back for all this tonight, kitten."

She giggled harder and said, "Will see. Now go take a shower."

Aadi stretched his arms lazily and said, "Later, let's have breakfast first." She pushed him back saying, "Nothing doing. Go take a shower first and come down."

"Okay, okay… as you wish my princess." Kavya turned to go out when Aadi called her.

"Manu…"

"Hmmm?"

"Join me in the shower."

"Aadi…" she said feeling shy as she stepped out of the room. Aditya went for a shower smiling at her embarrassment.

Kavya went down and touched the feet of Shiv. Rashmi was pleasantly surprised to see Kavya downstairs. She made her sit next to her and served her plate.

"Where is Aadi?"

"He has gone to take a shower."

Both Shiv and Rashmi looked at each other surprised. "So early?" Kavya was not aware, Aadi was very lazy on holidays and got ready almost by noon. "Kavya… beta you managed what I could not in all these years. I am impressed," Shiv said. Kavya just smiled and looked down feeling shy. Rashmi whispered in her ear, "I thought he won't let you out of the room today, that's why I was sending you breakfast upstairs."

"Mom…" Kavya said feeling shy on Rashmi's teasing. Rashmi laughed and patted her back making her relaxed.

Aditya joined them after a short while taking a seat next to Kavya. He was wearing a white t-shirt with cargo tracks. Kavya looked at him and thought, '*How can someone look so good, it should be made illegal*.' Aditya realized Kavya was staring at him and raised his eyebrows giving a smile. Kavya realized she was staring and ducked down.

Aadi sat next to her and placed his hand on her legs. Kavya let out a small gasp but kept quiet. His hand ran up and down on her thighs making her cheeks turn red again. She tried removing his hand but Aditya smiled. He removed his hand

and started eating. He whispered in her ear, "Now that's the perfect shade of blush. It goes well with this dress, you know, that's why I was teasing you," he said chewing his food.

Kavya waited for some time and then pinched his leg. "Ouch!" Aditya said loudly. All heads turned to them and Kavya got scared. "What happened, Aadi?" Shiv asked.

"No, just burned my mouth. Food is very hot."

"Yeah, I believe you, son," Shiv said and everyone laughed.

Kavya smiled and looked down feeling too shy. She looked at Aadi and mouthed the word 'sorry…' Aadi smiled and whispered, "I will tell you later today, how to say sorry." She looked away avoiding thinking ahead.

After breakfast, Aditya wanted to visit the office for some time for a few critical things that needed immediate action. Shiv was not happy to send him to the office so soon. Kavya offered to go along with him as she was very eager to start her work.

"No way, I am not sending her to the office at least for the next one month. Let her live her life."

"Mom, please," Kavya requested making a puppy face. "I won't do any work. I will just go and explore, meet people while Aditya finishes his work."

"How can I say 'no' to this look?" Rashmi said smiling and Kavya beamed. "I am also coming," Shiv said. "Aditya will finish his work while I will introduce everyone with my daughter."

"You guys have exactly two hours to come back home, okay? Be home before eleven. We will have early lunch today. We have the reception today evening. I want Kavya to rest for some time post lunch, before getting ready."

"Yes, mam," both Shiv and Aadi said together and everyone laughed. "I will come in a minute," Kavya said excusing herself.

All three of them were very happy to see Kavya so excited to join the office. She was still not aware that Aditya had bought a company Kavya had suggested. She came down quickly with her purse to join Aditya and Shiv. Shiv took out his car and made Kavya sit in the front instead of Aditya and he got annoyed. Kavya teased him while sitting in the car.

They reached the office building and stopped at the main entrance. Kavya started praying, closing her eyes before getting down. It was her first day. She wanted everything to go smoothly. Shiv saw her praying and smiled fondly. He patted her head blessing her. "You are going to rock, beta. Don't worry, I am with you," Shiv said. Kavya looked at him and nodded. She always missed her dad. Today she got the reassurance, which only a father can give, from Shiv. "Thanks, dad… for everything." She smiled at him.

Aadi opened the door for Kavya and she got down taking his hand. "Welcome to your office, Mrs. Joshi."

"My office?" It was a big step, a very big step. She had done as much study about the company and people as she could, but nothing could have prepared for this day. Aditya took her hand in his and patted it softly, giving her reassurance.

She had Shiv on her right side and Aditya on her left. Life is a blessing Kavya thought looking at both of them. She told herself, *'Kavya, everything is going to be perfect coz you have two God-sent angels with you.'* She walked in confidently with them.

Aditya went to his cabin while Shiv took her to the other cabin. "This is your cabin, beta," Shiv said. "My cabin?" Kavya said, surprised. "Well, your future cabin. Once you are ready. I want you to start from the shop floor, the way Aditya did and work in each department for some time. We will have your periodic reviews to ensure you are learning everything. Once we feel you have got a grip of the function, we will shift you to a new one." Kavya loved the idea. 'That's perfect," she said. "Let me tell you, beta, it's not going to be easy. Aditya is a slave driver, very few people can reach up to his expectations at work."

"I will do my best, dad."

"At any point in time, if you feel it's too much for you, I am just a call away. I will step in."

She nodded.

Shiv smiled at her enthusiasm. "Come, let's go to the conference room. There is a small presentation Aditya has set up to introduce you to the core team of the company."

Kavya walked along with Shiv. "Dad, I have done some study before marriage on the core team."

"Oh really? Let's see then," Shiv said smiling.

Everyone was looking at them as they walked towards the conference room, amazed with the fact that Kavya chose to come to the office the next day after her marriage.

They settled in the conference room and Jatin started the presentation. "Wait…" Shiv told him. "Just open the photo gallery first; I want to see how much she has studied," Shiv said bluntly. Jatin got confused but followed the instructions. He quickly texted Aditya of what had happened. Aadi, seeing the message, was pleasantly surprised and decided to join the presentation.

"Sir, Aditya is joining us, shall we wait?" Shiv nodded. "Get me coffee till then."

"Sure, sir." He looked at Kavya. "A glass of warm water for me, please." He smiled back at her.

Aditya joined shortly after. Shiv pointed him to sit next to him. "Kavya has done some research already on our companies' core team. I want to see her depth of study. Come, son, let's sit. Kavya got up confidently and stood on the other side.

The first photo flashed, it was Mr. Gokhle.

"Mr. Gokhle. Total experience, sixteen years. Joined our company seven years back as a manager. Has received two awards and heads quality of our company since last three and a half years. One of the five employees of Kalpana industries to receive mid-term increment. His research paper on Fabric quality control in apparel merchandising has won him international recognition."

Both Shiv and Aditya were stunned at the depth of her knowledge and study. '*This is too good*,' Aditya thought but decided to grill her further. "Can you tell us a bit more about his research paper?"

"Sure," Kavya spoke flawlessly not missing any detail of his research. She finished after ten minutes and Shiv could not keep himself from giving her applause. Kavya smiled, satisfied that she could impress them. They went through all the other core team members. Kavya managed full information on 22 people out of 23 core team members. The last person about whom very less information was available was Shiv as he was not on any social media site.

She also suggested, "We need to build social media handlers for Dad. His visibility is important," and Aditya could not agree more. He was so proud of her. She was so young, yet so dynamic and thoughtful. Today, he met a very different Kavya. She was shy and vulnerable at home. Kavya in office was the stark opposite. She was bold and confident. She feared nothing when she spoke her mind. At that moment, Aditya knew, she had a long way to go.

"Kavya, can you wait in your cabin for some time, we will join you shortly," Aditya said. "Sure," Kavya said confidently and excused herself from the conference room. As soon as she left, Shiv looked at Aditya, who smiled back at him. "She is brilliant, dad. I am sure she will take this company to the next level."

"I can't agree more, son. I think we now truly have a right hand for you, who can lead the entire backend operations single-handedly while you focus on expansion and Jatin focuses on customer handling. I feel our core team is complete now."

"With this pace, dad, she will be ready in the next few months."

"Don't push her too much, Aadi. Let her have a work-life balance. She has been slogging for years. I want her to live her life too."

"I know, dad. But this is a rare talent. Her eye for detailing is mesmerizing and so is her memory. I mean, come on, half the things she told today, even I could not remember."

Shiv smiled agreeing to Aditya. "I am telling you again, Aadi, let us go slow. Give her time to relax and you need to relax a bit too."

"Dad, come one!"

"No, Aadi. She deserves your time and attention right now. These days won't come back. Don't ruin it by spending time working. I am there to look after the business. I know I have not been actively involved lately, but I can surely run my company again for a month or so. Spend quality time with her, son. Make her feel at home. Post that, you both only need to run the show for the rest of your lives."

Aadi nodded.

"Where are you guys going for your honeymoon?"

"I have not planned it yet dad."

"Nonsense…" Shiv rang the bell and the office boy entered the conference room.

"Call Jatin."

"Dad, let me at least hand over the work to you."

Shiv raised a hand gesturing her to stop arguing, "That, let me and Jatin decide." Jatin entered the room.

"Yes, sir?"

"Jatin, we need to kick your boss out of India with his wife for honeymoon."

Jatin smiled. "Sure thing. Any specific place in mind boss?"

"Let Kavya decide," Aditya said.

Shiv smiled. "Come, let's go. Kavya must be waiting."

"Yeah." Aditya got up with Shiv and all 3 joined Kavya in her cabin. She was sitting on the front side of the table instead of her designated chair.

Shiv saw that and asked her, "What's wrong?"

"Nothing is wrong, dad. I want to earn that place and not get it. Once you think I am ready, I will sit there."

Her honestly and dedication touched Aditya's soul once again. Shiv smiled at her and nodded. "That's my girl. I am extremely proud of you, beta. You have given me a pleasant surprise today. I am confident you will do wonders in this company."

"Thank you, dad." Shiv stepped out of the cabin to take the round. Jatin joined Aditya and Kavya.

"So Bhabi, sir just asked me to make your honeymoon bookings and Aditya told me to book wherever you wish to go. Where would you like to go?"

Kavya turned shy and embarrassed as Jatin spoke and looked at Aadi. Aditya realized it and told him, "I will discuss and tell you by the evening." Jatin smiled and nodded leaving the room. Aadi sat on the table in front of Kavya and took her hand in his.

"Manu, I am extremely proud of you."

"Thank you, Aadi, but I have not done anything. This information is a matter of public availability. I just went through it."

Aditya nodded. "Can you wait here for some time? I need to make a few calls and finish one meeting. We will leave in an hour."

"Sure, please take your time. I am fine."

"I will send across your laptop. It has your email id set up and some more information. You can go through that till then."

"That will be perfect," she said.

Aadi kissed her hand and she looked down. "Don't look so cute, baby… I need to work." Kavya giggled, "You always look cute to me, imagine how I manage to…"

"To?"

"To… nothing," she said avoiding the topic. "Go now, finish your work."

"No, first, complete what you were saying."

"To… keep my hands to myself," she said looking at her hands.

Aditya took her hands and placed on his chest. "You don't need to keep them to yourself. I am all yours."

She pushed him. "But right now, you need to work and I need to study, so… gooo…"

"Yeah. See you in a few hours, baby." Aditya winked and walked away.

Jatin came with their IT head who set up her laptop, IPad, official mobile and other things. She sat and started reading

each document carefully, taking notes in her new IPad. She was used to maintaining 2 diaries. 1 for daily work and 1 for learning, in which she maintained all notes. Now she had IPad! So, she decided to make digital notes.

Kavya did not realize time passing by as she was too engrossed in her studies. Aditya came in her cabin and sat on the chair at some distance. She did not realize anything and continued to study. He finally could not resist so he came forward and hugged her from behind. "Come on angel, time to go home."

"Can I please finish this?"

"It has 70 more pages, Kavya. No, mom will kill us both."

She frowned making a pout of her lips. Aditya laughed looking at her expression. "You look like someone stole your puppy." Kavya smiled. "I love working, Aadi."

"I know, baby… and I love that about you." He kissed her forehead and took her hand. "Come, let's search for dad."

Shiv was already in his cabin waiting for them to finish their work. They went home together discussing the current business decisions. Kavya did not talk much and paid more attention to their conversation; listening and understanding their thought process. Aditya was extremely aggressive in business. He took calculated risks and was sharp in decision making. Listening to his business vision was mesmerizing. '*I can listen to him like this for the rest of my life,*' she thought. Aditya looked at her and raised his eyebrows, asking her if she wanted to say anything. She just nodded 'no' and held his hand. He smiled back at her, gripping her hand, and continued talking.

They reached home by quarter to one and all 3 of them got a nice scolding from Rashmi. "Look at the time. Why did you keep her at work on the very first day for so long?"

"No mom, it's not their fault. I was too engrossed in studying one important report, I actually requested Aadi to wait some more."

"Kavya, you have got married just yesterday; don't be so hard on yourself. Shiv, at least you should have understood." She looked at Shiv with anger.

"Sorry, mam," Shiv said and Kavya giggled. Watching her laugh, Aditya landed in laughing himself.

"Don't you dare laugh, I am serious," Rashmi said with mocking anger trying to hide her own smile and Kavya giggled a bit more.

"This is not fair," Rashmi said. "How can I be mad on her?"

Kavya hugged Rashmi. "Then don't be mad at me, mom. Can we have lunch? I am hungry."

She patted her head. "I was hoping you will be hungry. Come…"

Before they went ahead, Kavya got a tight hug from behind from Sandhya. "Diiiii!"

Kavya had an instant glow on her face. She turned and hugged her. "When did you come? Why did you not call?"

"Madam, where is your phone? I have been calling since morning."

"Oops… sorry, I forgot to check. I was a bit occupied."

Kavita came out of the kitchen. Kavya ran in her arms as she saw her. They both had tears in their eyes. Just one day… but they missed each other already.

"You were supposed to come in the evening, right?"

"Yes, but Rashmi called us early to spend time with you," Kavita said looking at her daughter. "It's just 1 day, but you already look so different, beta."

"C'mon, mom, it's nothing like that," Kavya said, feeling shy, looking down.

"You had lunch?"

"No, we were waiting for you."

Aadi felt good to see Kavya so happy. They all sat for lunch while the servants served food. The afternoon went in all light-hearted chit-chat and revisiting marriage moments. Kavya looked at Aadi, he was relaxed, kidding around with Sandhya. She felt overwhelmed. Both Aditya and his family were doing everything to make her happy. She missed dad at this moment. '*Wish he was here… Our family would have been complete,*' she thought. Shiv saw her sitting quietly and came to sit next to her.

"What happened, beta? Are you tired?"

"No, dad. I am fine," she said trying to smile."

"You can tell me…"

"You all are doing so much for me, life has become so perfect, dad; I am getting scared."

"Don't be, beta… you deserve all this. Learn to embrace happiness openly."

She nodded. "I wish dad was here today."

"I am here, Manu…" Shiv said patting her hand softly. Kavya had tears in her eyes. She leaned her head on Shiv's shoulder and nodded. She quickly got grip on herself and smiled back, wiping her tears.

Aadi saw it and asked her raising his eyebrows if everything was fine. She smiled and said yes, and whispered thank you. He blew her a kiss and she turned shy.

Sandhya saw it and cleared her throat. "Ahem, ahem… jiju," she whispered. "We are around, don't forget…" Aadi smiled and messed his hair… "Blushing jiju… that's a first." Aadi laughed and pulled her cheeks. "Ouch! Don't…"

"Can't help, golu, it is fun to pull your cheeks." They both started fighting and Kavya laughed. She came to rescue Sandhya.

Chapter 12

Shortly after, Rashmi asked Kavya to take a shower if she wanted to as the dressers and beauticians would come soon to get her ready. She nodded and headed upstairs. Aadi was too tempted to follow her, but Kavita was talking to him so he sat back. Beauticians took a long time to get Kavya ready. Aditya got ready in his room. He wore a black tuxedo. He sat in the living room, watching the staircase, almost desperate to see Kavya. He tried having small conversations with the family members. Jatin and Esha were constantly in touch from the venue verifying all preparations.

Kavya came out of her room looking like a doll. She was wearing a bright pink lehenga with golden work and golden dupatta. Her hair tied neatly; she had flawless makeup. To top it all, were her innocence and smile. She could give any ramp model a run for money today. Aditya saw her coming down from the stairs and got stunned for a second. Then, he stepped ahead to take her hand and kissed it. The whole family was in the living room and Kavya turned shy at Aadi's gesture. Sandhya whistled and Kavita saw Sandhya angrily, who made an apologizing gesture to her mother. Rashmi and Kavita came forward to hug Kavya. Kavita again had tears in her eyes looking at her daughter. She hugged Kavya and looked at Aadi saying thank you. Aadi blew a kiss to Kavita, she smiled at him fondly.

Aadi whispered in Kavya's ear, "There is a surprise for you." She looked at Aadi, confused. He took her out. There was a white Audi A6 decorated with orchids and ribbons. Kavya was speechless looking at the car. It was way too over the top gift. She looked at Aadi and was about to argue.

"Aadi…"

Aadi handed over the keys to her and said, "It is your marriage gift, baby… please don't say no." She kept quiet, looking down. She felt very small. Aadi raised her face to see her holding her chin. "Baby, I want to buy everything in this world for you. Please don't get hassled up. Just tell me if you like it or not…"

"It's lovely… Thank you so much."

"The car is lovely or I am lovely?" Aadi said… teasing her.

"It's lovely because I got it from you," she said looking at Aadi.

"Where is my return gift?" he asked.

"What can I gift a man who has everything?"

"There is something only you can give me."

He placed his fingers pointing to his cheeks, asking for a kiss. Kavya looked down feeling shy. "Can't now… families around," Kavya said in a low voice. "I will wait, baby." She nodded…

"Come on, now… give me a ride to our venue in your new car."

"I don't know how to drive," Kavya said and Aadi laughed. "Okay." He took the keys and opened the door for Kavya. Then went and sat in the driver seat. All family members came in other cars to the venue. Aditya purposely did not call for a driver as he wanted to spend time with Kavya before reaching the venue.

As they got into the car, Aadi held her hand and kissed it. "You look like an angel today, Kavya."

"Thank you," Kavya said, trying to pull her hand. "So, we were discussing my return gift," Aadi said mischievously. "Aadi… you are driving right now…"

"And you are not driving right now. I can't kiss you, but you can kiss me, baby."

Kavya tried adjusting in her seat, leaning forward to kiss Aadi. He turned his head and she backed off. "I can't…" Aadi laughed. "Keep trying, baby, you are going to need it tonight."

"Shh… you don't have a brain to mouth filter at all."

"Baby, I don't need any filters around you. "

She looked at him fondly. "So, try again…"

"Please Aadi, not now…"

He held her hand and said, "Okay, baby, I will wait for tonight. Looking at you right now, I feel like stealing you from everyone and taking you back to the room right away and…"

Kavya placed a hand on his mouth, "Please don't…"

"Why?"

"Coz I am feeling the same about you right now."

Aadi smiled and pulled the car aside. Kavya got confused and looked at Aadi. "What happened… all okay?"

"No, I can't hold it anymore." He kissed her hard, crushing her lips under his, softly biting them. She responded back forgetting everything. They both stopped when they were out of breath. Kavya looked away, out of the window and Aadi smiled at her, handing over a box of tissues. "Here, take it… you need to adjust your lipstick"

"Oh!" she took out a small mirror from her purse and started fixing the smudged lipstick. Aadi was smiling while he drove. "Stop laughing." Kavya punched him softly on his shoulder and he laughed harder. "I can't help it, you get so conscious so easily. It's fun to tease you."

"I don't get conscious, okay?"

"Oh really? He pulled her Hand.

"Aa… Aadi…"

And he started laughing again. "See…"

"Oh gosh! What do I do with this man?"

"Learn to deal, baby. You are stuck for life now."

She looked at him now, not able to control her own giggle.

"Straighten up, kitten, we are about to reach the venue.... Are you ready?"

"I am nervous," Kavya said honestly.

"Don't be, baby, it's our day. Just relax and enjoy. I am there with you."

She nodded, leaning her head on his shoulders. "Aadi..."

"Hmmm?"

"I love you."

Aditya smiled, kissing her forehead. "I love you too, baby."

They entered the hall, hand in hand, walking over the specially designed pathway to the stage. The entire pathway was covered with rose petals along with flower decoration on both sides. Kavya felt like a princess and clung to Aditya's hand. Aadi held her by the waist and walked along. They got on the stage and Kavya saw the crowd who clapped for them.

"Oh, shit..."

"What happened, Manu?"

"Aadi... how many people have come?"

"Close to three K, why what happened?

"Isn't it too much?"

Aadi smiled. "Relax baby. We have a big business circle so this was important."

She nodded looking down.

"Hey..." Aadi clasped her hand and said, "Don't get intimidated, baby. You are my wife now." She smiled at the mention of the word wife. "That's my girl. I am feeling like kissing you right now..." Aadi said in a low voice. "Shh... we have people around," Kavya said. "So what, baby? I don't care." She pinched him... "Ouch, Kavya" and she giggled.

Shiv came on stage with Rashmi, Kavita, and Sandhya. He took the mike in hand and greeted all guests, welcoming them. He thanked everyone and popped open the champagne to commence the reception, formally. The reception was filled with a lot of social dignitaries, politicians, celebrities, etc. Many prominent personalities were there, Kavya and Aditya greeted everyone. Unlike her personal self, she met everyone very

confidently exchanging proper handshakes and making small conversations. After a few hours, they both decided to leave the stage and join everyone on the ground so that they could meet everyone properly."

By dinner time, the dance floor was opened. Kavya and Aditya were called for the first dance. Kavya got scared, "Aadi…"

"Hmmm?"

"We can't dance."

"What? Why?"

"Coz I don't know how to dance…"

"Come on, Kavya, I have seen you dancing. You are good."

"That's different… this is different. Everyone is looking at us here."

Aditya laughed.

'Don't laugh, Aadi… I am getting nervous."

"Just go with the flow, baby. I will lead you, follow my footsteps."

"No, please…"

Aadi almost pulled her on the dance floor, took her hand in his, and started moving.

It was their favorite song - Bryan Adams – Everything I do.

Aditya was singing along and Kavya smiled. At that moment, they both forgot there were other people around. They danced as if it was only the two of them. Kavya was looking into his eyes and thought, '*This moment is the world. Everything stops here. This beautiful man… is mine*.'

She leaned forward and placed her head on Aditya's chest who took her in his arms moving slowly. Everyone cheered them and Kavya realized they were in the reception. She got conscious and tried moving. Aadi held her there and said, "Relax…"

"Aadi, everyone is watching."

"I know, let them," he said smiling.

She forcefully came out of his embrace and whispered, "Can we go back now? We have been dancing for long."

Aadi kissed her hand and said, "Okay, princess."

"Shhh… what are you doing?"

"Can do only this much right now, Manu. Wait for a few more hours, then I'll give you more."

"You are impossible," she said looking down.

Aadi laughed, taking her away from the dance floor.

They met a few more people and had a light chat. People started heading for dinner. Slowly, people started going home and Aadi asked if she would like to head for dinner. "Aadi, can we sit and have dinner somewhere please? I just want to sit somewhere and eat. I am tired…"

"What would you like to have, dear," Aadi asked.

"Anything light."

Aditya raised his eyebrows and said, "Eat baby, you are going to need energy tonight."

Kavya turned shy and looked down, unable to think about how to react. Aadi smiled. He called a waiter nearby and gave him some instructions. "Our dinner will be set in ten minutes, baby. Come, let me introduce you to a few more people until then."

Once the waiter informed Aditya that their dinner was ready, he took her hand and led her away. "Where are we going?"

"For dinner," Aadi said smiling.

"Why do I feel there is more to it?"

"Because there is…"

"Tell me, Aadi…"

He grinned further and kissed her hand.

They reached a round table decorated with candles and flowers, covered by white curtains on all sides. Kavya looked at Aadi surprised. "When did you arrange all this?"

"Just when you said, you wanted to sit peacefully and eat. Your wish is my command princess."

"Aadi, this is beautiful," Kavya said grinning.

"You like the surprise?"

"I Love it," she said.

They both sat and Aadi opened wine. "I don't drink," Kavya said reluctantly. "Just a small glass to taste, baby. If you don't

like it, don't have it." She looked at the bottle and said, "It's a bottle of vintage wine." Aadi raised his eyebrows and said, "How do you know if you don't drink?"

"Well, I have done client management for long. I had studied wines for one of my client's dinner meeting as he was very much interested in wines. I thought it will be good to keep the information."

"Impressive," Aadi said pouring wine in two glasses and handing one to Kavya. They clinked the glasses. "To our love…" Aadi said. Kavya turned shy and sipped it.

"How's it?"

"It's very hot…"

Aadi smiled. "Have small sips, baby."

"Hmmm…" she nodded.

Aadi held her hand in which she was holding the glass and sipped wine from her glass. "Umm… this is sweeter."

"Aadi…" she ducked down. He kissed her hand softly and let it go.

"Aadi…"

"Hmmm?"

"Don't you think everyone will be searching for us?"

"No, I told dad before coming."

"Oh, okay."

"In fact, they will join us for the main course."

"Oh, so these are only starters? I am full already."

"You need to eat, Kavya, you eat very less," Aadi said disapproving. She pouted getting annoyed by his scolding and continued eating.

"Kavya…"

"Hmmm?"

"Why are you so cute?"

She giggled and lifted her shoulders "I don't know…"

Soon, their families joined them over dinner and more tables were added along with their table. Aadi got up and sat next to her. All family members had a light-hearted chat. Everyone seemed relaxed as the function was almost over now. Post

dinner, they all joined back the remaining guests. Kavita and Sandhya left for Mumbai shortly after.

They came home very late, exhausted but very happy and satisfied. Everyone enjoyed the function a lot. Rashmi and Shiv headed to their room while Kavya and Aadi sat on the patio for some time, soaking in the moonlight. Kavya looked at Aadi with sleepy eyes and smiled. Aadi looked back at her asking, "Sleepy, baby?"

"No… not really."

"Liar," Aadi said, running his fingers over her cheeks."

"Ummm…" Kavya leaned on his hand. "Kavya…" Aadi looked at her and she looked at him feeling shy. She looked down. "Come, let's go upstairs," he said, holding her hand.

They reached the bedroom and Aadi locked the door. Kavya sat in front of the dressing table and started removing her jewelry. Aditya stood nearby leaning on the wall, watching Kavya. Kavya looked down and said, "What happened? Why are you looking at me like that?"

"I love watching you, Manu."

She smiled and whispered, "Me too."

Aadi smiled and started removing his tux and shirt. Kavya looked down again. Aadi saw her and said, "Remember something, baby? The first time you came to this room?" Kavya smiled fondly at the memory, removing hairpins and setting her hair open. She looked into the mirror. Aditya was standing behind her, shirtless. She covered her face with her hands. "Aadi... go wear your clothes." Aadi smiled, "I thought you like looking at me."

"Of course, I like looking at you."

"Then what's the problem?"

"I feel shy..." she said looking down.

Aadi came forward and planted a soft kiss on her neck whispering in her ear, "I love watching you blush." He removed the dupatta from her shoulder, which fell on the ground, and kissed her shoulder. Kavya let out a soft moan leaning her head behind. Aadi held her head and kissed her on the lips, softly.

His hands traveled down to her waist and Kavya got up from the dressing chair, getting conscious. As soon as she got up, the remaining part of dupatta fell on the floor. Kavya tried bending down to pick it, but Aadi held her hand and pulled her in his arms.

"We don't need it right now, baby." She hugged him... hiding her face in his chest. "I love u, Manu."

"I..." Aditya's hand opened the thread of her top, exploring her back and Kavya lost her words. "Oh God!" She ran away facing the wall. Aadi smiled. He dimmed the lighting of the room and walked towards her. Aadi opened the thread completely.

"Aa... Aadi..." Kavya said in a trembling voice.

"Hmmm?" Aadi said kissing her back.

"What are you doing?"

"I am loving my wife."

"I am feeling shy."

"Don't be so coy, baby. Come on..." his hands reached the hook of her bra. Kavya realized it and before he could open it, she turned facing him. She felt as if her entire body was on fire. Her blouse was too loose as it was open from the back and was about to fall. Aadi tried removing it, but Kavya pulled it back. Aadi smiled holding her face. She looked away. Aadi held her hair and made her turn her face. "Manu..." The fingers of his one hand were running on her navel, making circles, driving her crazy. Kavya let out a soft moan and Aadi started kissing her. He gave her a tight hug and crushed her lips, sucking them... biting in between.

Kavya was feeling Aditya's body, her hands on his back, pulling him close. She slowly slid her tongue in Aadi's mouth and he sucked it hard making her hot between the legs. The moment he realized she was lost deep into feeling him, he removed her blouse in one swift move. Her knees went weak and Aadi gripped her harder against the wall. Aadi broke the kiss almost going breathless and picked up Kavya in his arms.

Kavya tried covering her body, feeling embarrassed. "Don't be shy, honey," Aadi said, kissing her again and placing her

on the bed. Kavya tried to get up, but Aadi pushed her back, leaning beside her. He removed her hair from her face.

"Aadi…"

"Hmmm?"

"Let me pull the cover, please..."

His hand traveled down exploring her body and she moaned again, forgetting everything. His fingers stopped at her lacy red bra and she turned to hug him. Aadi smiled and whispered in her ear, "My girl is very shy." He swiftly pulled her on top and started kissing her. Before she could realize, Aadi opened the hook.

"Aadi…" she whispered. "Ummhmm…" he said, kissing her ear. His hands moved to her breasts and she let out a moan. Aadi started planting soft kisses on her neck, trailing down to her nipples, sucking them softly. Kavya was turning wild with a new found desire. Aadi turned her and made her sleep on her back. Slowly, sucking the other nipple, he trailed further down. Her body and curves looked like milk in the moonlight. Kavya was holding a pillow tightly with both her hands to control herself. Aadi reached her lacy panty, but Kavya held his hand getting nervous. Aadi smiled and softly kissed her hands, moving them away.

"Aadi…" She moaned feeling shy. "You are so wet, baby," Aadi said, running his fingers on her sweet spot. She tried crunching her legs, but Aadi softly shifted them and settled between her legs, kissing her, softly sucking her, and making her go wild with desire. His one hand was playing with the sheets of her skin while the other was pressing her nipple. Her body crunched and Aadi realized she was about to have an orgasm. Getting up, he inserted a finger softly. Kavya felt a soft pain. Aadi quickly kissed her lips, sealing them, helping her cope with the experience.

"Aadi… I can't handle it anymore," she said almost shivering. Aadi removed his sweat and Kavya saw him. She could not take her eyes off from his manhood. She looked at him confused. Aadi understood her confusion and said, "God created us so

we fit baby, don't worry, you will stretch too." He was dying to take her, but he knew he had to give her time to understand and explore her own desires.

She ducked down, feeling embarrassed, thinking… 'How can he read my thoughts?' Aadi took her hands and placed them on his chest. "Touch me, baby." She started kissing him fearlessly, exploring his body. The more time Aadi gave her, the more she was feeling bold. She touched him and Aadi let out a sharp moan.

Kavya got scared. "Sorry, did I hurt you?"

"God… no, baby, it feels like this," he said placing his hands on her sweet spot. "Oh," she said. She remembered what Aadi did and went down on him, hesitantly stroking and kissing. Aadi was hard as a rock, he could not hold further. Aadi reached a side drawer taking out a packet of condoms. Kavya looked at him again. '*We need to discuss this*,' she thought.

"I am not ready to share you yet, baby" He took hold of Kavya and pinned her to the bed. "We won't be able to finish if you continue this way, baby; you are too sweet." He adjusted himself between her legs, coming on top of her and started stroking slowly. Kavya felt the same sharp pain and tears trailed off her eyes as she lost her virginity. Aadi softly kissed away the tears and said, "The pain will subside soon, baby. I can't hold it back more."

"Please don't hold back," Kavya said. Aadi started increasing the strokes and realized Kavya was now moaning with pleasure. He pushed his full length inside and Kavya lost herself in a pleasure-wave. "Come for me, baby," Aadi commanded and her whole body shivered with pleasure. Aadi joined her pleasure and collapsed on top of her.

They remained that way for a long time before Kavya spoke out, "Aadi…"

"Hmmm…" Aadi said softly kissing her cheeks. "Are my brain and toes supposed to feel numb?" Aadi laughed. "You are the cutest thing I have ever come across," he said. Kavya giggled

and hugged him running her hands over his back. "Don't drive me crazy, baby, I can't take you again right now."

"Why?" Kavya said pouting in disappointment. Aadi raised his eyebrows. "You are insatiable, Kavya" And she giggled again. He ran his fingers through her hair. You must be sore, baby, and I want you to be able to walk straight tomorrow," Aadi said with a mischievous grin."

"Oh," she said and Aadi laughed. He kissed her softly on her lips and pulled the cover on them, sleeping beside her.

"Good night, Manu."

"Love you, Aadi."

"Say it again, baby," Aadi requested, leaning on one hand. She looked into his eyes, running her fingers over his cheeks. "What I feel for you almost hurts my chest, Aadi." Aadi took her hand from his cheeks and softly planted kisses. "It's a mutual feeling." She had tears in her eyes. As she saw him she said, "You will never leave me, right?

"Hey, mad girl. I am not going anywhere… never. I can't even dream of staying away from you, Kavya," Aadi said taking her in an embrace. "I love you, Manu. I missed you. Staying away from you all these years was like a curse, but I had to give you time to grow up. I needed time to settle, but I am all yours now." He realized Kavya had slept as he spoke and smiled kissing her on her forehead.

Chapter 13

Kavya got up early the next day. Stretching her arms she realized she was wrapped in Aadi's arms. She was wearing Aadi's grey t-shirt. '*When did I wear this,*' she thought, trying to get herself free from his embrace. Aadi pulled her back. "What's the hurry, baby?"

"Aadi…" she said, turning shy. "Hmmm…" he pulled her, kissing her neck and putting his hand in her t-shirt; Kavya got scared and she got up. He hugged her from behind. "Coffee?" She nodded shyly. She was about to get up when she realized, she wasn't wearing any bottoms. She got back to bed and Aadi realized what had happened. He asked her, "What happened, Manu?" Pretending to be innocent. "Nothing," she said, getting back in the covers and Aadi laughed. "There is not an inch of your body I have not seen, Manu; don't be shy, go ahead…"

"Oh gosh," she said covering her face with her hands. "Can't resist you when you look this cute, baby," and he pulled her in the bed again.

Kavya took a shower and chose to wear a light green colored chiffon sari. Aditya was on a call standing near the window. Kavya was slowly getting used to this. It was his favorite place to stand and talk. He had already ordered breakfast which was kept on the center table in front of the sofa. '*Will I ever get used to this lifestyle?*' Kavya thought. She was used to cooking her own food with mom in her house. Here, since the time she had

come, she had not even entered the kitchen. She gave out a sigh thinking of mom and Sandhya and decided to call them once Aadi went to the office. '*I need to convince Rashmi mom to let me go to the office sooner,*' she thought.

Kavya went and hugged Aadi from behind; he turned and kissed her nose as he continued the call. He wound up call early and gave a good long kiss to Kavya.

Kavya ducked her head in his chest.

"Aadi… what are you doing?"

"What am I doing, baby, you tell me?"

"Oh gosh, please. We just…" she lost the courage to complete the sentence and Aadi laughed. "Come, I am sure you must be hungry." They sat on the sofa and Kavya realized she was famished. When she took the second slice of toasted bread, Aadi gave her a mischievous grin. "What?" She said wiping her mouth. "Looks like I made you work out a lot; you really are hungry."

"Oh!" Kavya said slowly, looking down.

"I love watching you eat, baby; you eat very less usually. Now I know how to make you eat more."

"Aadi…" Kavya gave him a soft push on the shoulder and he laughed.

"What time are you going to the office?"

"Who is going to the office?" Aadi asked.

"You are not going? Why?"

"We got married two days back, baby. You are not the only one on leave right now," Aadi said relaxing.

"What? Why? Aadi, work will get hampered."

"Relax Manu, dad has already gone to the office. He is taking over for a few days. He has given clear instructions to Jatin and Esha not to allow us in the office till we come back from our honeymoon."

"Oh," Kavya said and looked down blushing, trying to pick up the plates.

"Kavya…"

"Hmmm?"

"Keep the plates, we have people to do this."

She nodded and kept the plates.

"So, tell me, where you want to go, baby."

"Anywhere is good. I don't have any specific preferences."

"Okay, where have you not been, tell me that."

"Frankly speaking, I have not stepped out of Mumbai much. Just a few times for client meetings I have traveled out of the state, but never really got time to explore anything. You know how work-travel is…"

"Oh! So you have not seen… I mean…" Aadi lost his words, feeling sad.

"No, not really."

He hugged her hard. "Sorry, Manu… I was not around all these years when you were struggling to make a living. We will travel a lot together... for work, for pleasure… we'll see the world together."

Kavya had tears in her eyes… she just nodded and wiped them before Aadi could notice. She came out of his embrace and said, "I love long drives. Can we go somewhere by car?"

Aadi smiled at her simplicity. "Done… I know just the place for you. Do one thing, unpack your bags, until then, I will make all the arrangements. And yes, your room has your new wardrobe," Aadi said, getting up from there.

Kavya got confused. '*My new wardrobe? Maybe he meant cupboard, to keep my stuff,*' she thought and went to her room. '*Why do we need separate rooms*,' the thought still made her sad, but this is how big people function, maybe, she thought and went ahead.

She opened the cupboard. It was filled with multiple new dresses, ethnic, western, everything. '*What the… Where did all this come from?*' Then she realized, when the dressers came to take her measurements for marriage clothes, they also got a tailor-made wardrobe for her. '*This is too much*,' she thought and went back to Aditya.

"Aadi…"

"Before you argue, which I know you would, remember we work in the fashion industry ourselves, we have our own textile factories. Every time we are launching a new collection, a set of it comes home for us as a first cut. It comes for mom, dad, and me till date, now it will be coming for you as well."

"Oh!" she said, not realizing how to react. Aadi stepped forward and ran his fingers over her cheeks. "I hope you like them, baby."

"It's a lot to take Aadi…"

"It's all yours, Manu, coz I am yours."

She just nodded giving him a hug. Aadi kissed her neck. "Aadi…" she said trying to run away blushing. Aadi laughed, letting her go. He had to make a few more arrangements.

She unpacked her bag and placed everything neatly inside the cupboard. Then, she decided to go down and spend time with Rashmi. Rashmi hugged her and said, "How are you doing, beta? Had breakfast?"

"Yes mummy, just unpacked my bag also."

"Oh! It's done? You could have called me for help."

"No, it wasn't much," she said and Rashmi smiled.

"Mummy, I… actually wanted to…"

"What beta? Go on, please don't hesitate."

"Wanted to cook something for lunch for all of us… Is that okay?"

"It's your kitchen, beta. Cook whatever you feel like cooking. The servants are for our help, not to restrict us from doing anything we want."

Kavya smiled, feeling relaxed. She quickly went into the kitchen happily and Rashmi saw her. '*Such a simple girl*,' Rashmi thought and felt proud of Aditya's choice once again. Rashmi called Shiv to come home for lunch today as their daughter-in-law was cooking something special.

Kavya decided to make kheer as she knew Aadi loved sweets. Everyone in the kitchen was very happy to see her there. Rashmi was not fond of cooking much, though she was an excellent

cook. Shiv and Aadi entered the kitchen on holidays only to cook something light and more to have a fun time together.

Kavya took her own time to make sure the kheer turned out well. Aadi came down quickly as the aroma of kheer spread in the house.

"What's up, mom? Kheer today?"

Rashmi smiled, "Your wife is cooking."

Aadi raised in eyebrows, "Let me taste it and come."

Aadi went to the kitchen and all domestic helpers quietly stepped out seeing him there.

Kavya was fully engrossed in cooking when she realized Aadi was standing there.

"Aadi… What are you doing here?"

"I am here to taste your kheer," he said pulling out a bowl and a spoon from a drawer.

"Umm… amazing!" He said licking his lips and Kavya giggled.

She had learned cooking from her mom. She sent a quick photo to her mother saying, "Cooked this today, missing you."

Soon Shiv came home for lunch and they all had lunch together… Shiv went back to the office shortly after and Kavya felt sad.

"What happened, Kavya? Rashmi asked.

"Mummy, dad is working while we both are at home, it doesn't feel good."

"Kavya, for heaven's sake, you have got married two days back. You deserve a break, Aadi also deserves a break. Shiv rarely goes to the office nowadays. It won't hurt if he works for a few days. In fact, I am happy to see him active again."

Kavya smiled.

"When are you guys going for your honeymoon and where are you going?

Kavya blushed looking down. "I am not sure where we are going. Aadi was making the arrangements."

"Mad girl," Rashmi said. "Go ask him."

She smiled and went upstairs.

"Aadi…"

"Hmmm?" Aadi said packing his bags.

"Where are we going?"

"We will go tomorrow morning, baby."

"No, where are we going?"

"On a long drive," Aadi said teasing her.

"You know what I am asking you… now stop teasing me and tell me."

"Nopes… it's a surprise!"

"Oh, come on, Aadi… I want to know."

Aadi laughed. "When I was asking you the destination, you were feeling shy and now you want to know…"

"Yes, I want to know," Kavya said pouting.

"We are going to another farmhouse, we have."

"Oh, we have another one? Where?"

"We have five, baby. Dad is very fond of weekend getaways."

"And where are those?"

Aadi gave her a mischievous grin. "In India."

She threw a pillow on him. "Tell me now!"

Aadi ducked and laughed harder. "Okay, what will I get in return?"

"What do you want?"

"You know it, Manu," he said pointing at his cheeks.

"Tell me, and you will get it."

"Nope, my earlier one is also pending. First I get a kiss and then you get your destination."

She walked on her knees on the bed and placed her hands around his neck trying to feel as bold as she could. Aadi placed his hands on her waist. "I love saris," Aadi said, running his hand on her bare waist. "Aadi…" she looked down blushing. Aadi pulled her face up and she closed her eyes. "Not so easily, Manu," Aadi said smiling. "You need to kiss me." She opened her eyes and closed his eyes with her hands planting a soft kiss on his cheek. He pointed his hand on the other cheek and she kissed again. Aadi then pointed towards his lips. Kavya just hugged him instead, smiling and blushing.

"God! Lady, I can't keep my hands off you for long," he said pushing her to the bed. He came on top of her, kissing her hard. He whispered in her ear, "How sore are you…"

"I don't know," Kavya replied.

Aadi looked at her. "Baby…"

"I mean… I am, but I don't know how much." He took a long breath again, kissing her softly. "Don't want to hurt you." He just laid down beside her. She hugged him back. "You can never hurt me."

"Don't tempt me, you need time." She made a pout, disappointed that he withdrew. "I don't need time, I need you."

"My girl is insatiable." And Kavya giggled.

"I love this sound," Aadi said, running his fingers over her cheeks. "Soon baby… Keep waiting till then. Go pack your bag."

"First tell me where are we going?"

Aadi smiled back at her. "Goa," he said.

Kavya got up smiling ear to ear. "I love beaches!" She kissed him on the cheeks again and said thank you. She quickly got up from the bed, happy like a kid and went to her room. Aadi looked at her and smiled. If she would have pointed any destination in this world, Aadi would have taken her there in the blink of an eye. Yet, here she was, so simple, getting happy with small things. '*Life is a blessing*,' Aadi thought.

She started packing her bag when Aadi came with a box.

"What is this?" Kavya asked.

"Keep it in the bag. Wear it there."

"Okay," she said, trying to open the box.

"Don't open it now, baby. Just keep it."

"What's inside?"

Aadi gave a mischievous grin. "It's a gift for me."

She blushed. "Why are we not going today?"

"Jatin has kept a house party tonight at his place. All my close friends are coming. I want you to come along with me."

"Oh! I don't know anyone…"

"You know me, baby. I will introduce you to everyone. I will be with you, don't worry."

"Okay," she said, feeling nervous.

"What happened, Manu? You don't like parties?"

"No, it's not like that. It's just that…"

"Hey, tell me so that I can help you."

"I have never really partied, Aadi. Besides, your circle has all big people, I don't know… I mean… I don't feel I fit in there."

"You are my wife, Kavya. Of course, you fit in there. There is nothing like big people, small people. It's a simple house party - Food, drinks, music… Some games and back."

"Hmmm…"

"I will be there with you, baby… don't worry."

"Hmmm…"

"Hey!" He pulled her chin up. "Chin up, gorgeous, I am sure my friends will be your friends after tonight," and she smiled. "I hope so."

"What should I wear?"

"Anything you are comfortable in."

"What usually girls wear… dresses, jeans…?"

"Okay, let me choose for you."

He opened her wardrobe and took out a wine colored simple floral dress with shimmer robe, which would reach her knees.

"Wear this," and she beamed. "It's nice. Okay, I will get ready after packing the bag." Aadi nodded, receiving a call.

"Yes, Esha?" He paused. "No, we can talk right now… tell me... Okay… send the papers home for signing. Anything else? No, hold it… I will be out of town for the next few days, so if you need any additional signatures, send the papers home today by five." Aadi continued the call and Kavya sat next to him, listening to him. He was very different while talking to his employees. Almost curt…" He kept the phone down after some time.

"You are very different when you work."

"So are you, Manu. I have seen you when you made the presentation. I could not recognize you for a minute." She nodded, smiling. "Now go get ready, kitten… we will be leaving in some time for the party."

"Aadi…"

"Hmmm…"

"Do I need to wear makeup? I am not good at that."

"You need to relax, Kavya. Even if you will wear a potato sack, you will still look the most beautiful girl in this world. But if you need any help, I can arrange."

"No, no… I will try." Aadi smiled. "It's not a business meeting to get so conscious. They are my friends."

"Just… I am meeting them for the first time that too, as your wife. I don't want to let you down."

"You are a bright, young woman, Kavya, and you are beautiful. But just so you know, I fell for your nature more than the way you look." She blushed.

Aadi got another call and looked irritated. Kavya patted his hands. "We are on a break, Aadi, but work is important. Go on, take it." He nodded and walked out to the room.

Kavya took a quick shower and came to her dresser. It was well-equipped with everything she could think of. She decided to switch on YouTube, her best friend in makeup and started a tutorial. She watched it for five minutes and realized that it was not meant for her. '*I should have taken Aadi's offer for domestic help*,' she thought and realized Rashmi is very good with it. '*What will she think of me?*' However, she reluctantly thought of asking. She got dressed up and went to Rashmi's room.

She knocked on the door and Rashmi opened it. "Oh! You look lovely, getting ready for the house party?"

"How do you know?"

"Aadi told me that you both won't be around for dinner."

She smiled. "I actually needed your help."

"Please tell me, beta."

"I am not good with makeup or hairdo, can you help me learn that?"

Rashmi smiled fondly. "That would be my pleasure, come inside."

She made her sit on the dressing chair and pulled out some stuff. "It's pretty simple, see… You need to put this on first…"

Rashmi started. "You know what, Kavya? I always missed having a daughter. Today, making you get ready like this, it's such a great pleasure." Kavya got emotional and hugged her. Rashmi hugged her back.

Kavya had naturally wavy hair so Rashmi gave them a bit of bounce and pinned them to one side. She added some color to her cheeks and kept the makeup to minimal.

Kavya loved it. "Mummy, next time I will try and you tell me if I did it correctly."

"You will learn it in no time, beta. Now off you go, else Aadi will come searching."

Kavya blushed. "And do one thing, keep this compact and lipstick with you, in case if you need a touch up in between."

"Mom, you are the best," Kavya said kissing her cheeks. "Enjoy yourself!" Rashmi felt good seeing Kavya settling down in the house and opening up.

Kavya went to their room and knocked on the door before opening. "Baby, it's your own room, you don't need to knock before entering."

"No, last time…" she dropped the words. "Hahaha… before marriage, when you came right? Yeah! That was epic…"

Kavya got lost looking at him. He looked lovely when he laughed, almost irresistible. Aadi saw the way she was looking at him and said, "We can repeat it if you want baby," and unbuttoned his shirt a bit. Kavya felt shy and looked away. "Aadi, we are getting late." Aadi came closer, "Come on, baby. There is nothing you have not seen now," he said, running his fingers on her ear, playing with her earrings. "Aadi… don't tempt me." Aadi raised his eyebrows and smiled. "Oh, is it? Let's see how far can you resist me?"

He trailed his hands down to her neckline, running through her cleavage. Kavya felt the same wave of desire running through her body. She held his hand and pushed him to the wall. Aadi was taken aback. He loved it. Kavya planted a soft kiss on his neck trailing down to his half-open shirt slowly opening the rest of the buttons. Aadi held her head high and kissed her back

hard. Toying her lips in his mouth, he whispered, "I am glad you are wearing a dress." Kavya did not realize what he meant until he lifted her dress up getting access to her completely. His hands went down and she let out a moan. Aadi dropped his jeans and wrapped her legs around him, lifting her up. He barely managed to reach the sofa before taking her fully. Kavya was responding back to him, opening up to him and he was loving it. They both made love and slept on the sofa exhausted when Kavya looked at him and giggled.

"What happened?"

"You look tired already, Aadi."

"You are keeping me worked out a lot, lady."

And she laughed harder.

"Oh God! This sound drives me crazy." He kissed her again. Kavya got up, searching for her panty but could not find it on the floor.

"Aadi…"

"Yes, baby?" Aadi looked at her with mocking innocence. He knew what she was searching for. "Nothing…" she said, too shy to ask him. "Are you searching for this?" He raised her white lacy panty in his hand. "Give it to me."

"No, I won't. Someone was laughing at me some time back." Kavya giggled. "You get tired so easily."

"Ohh… iss itt?" he said dramatically. "We will see on our honeymoon, baby, who gets tired first." She came to him, trying to snatch it back from him. "I will never have enough of you, Aadi," she said looking into his eyes. Her eyes were sparkling with satisfaction. Then she looked down. Aadi held her and raised her chin. "I love you, Manu… and I love the way you are becoming bold and opening up to me." He kissed her cheeks and whispered in her ear, "I have a lot more to teach you on our honeymoon."

"Oh, I am looking forward to it." The moment she realized he was lost talking to her, she snatched her panty from him and walked back giggling.

"Cheater…"

She wore them and got ready. She took out a lipstick from her purse for touch up. "You said you don't know makeup, you have done a fantastic job."

"Mom did it for me. She is teaching me." Aadi smiled at her. "Smart girl."

"Shall we go?" She asked.

"Yeah, do take that lipstick along. You are looking so sexy, I am sure you are going to need to touch up many more times."

"Promises promises…" she said rolling her eyes and Aadi laughed taking her hand. "Come, let's go."

They reached the venue quickly. Jatin stayed in a 3BHK studio apartment with a terrace. It was given to him by the company. Kavya loved the house. Aadi had taken a bottle of wine along and gifted it to Jatin when they entered the house.

"Aadi…"

"Hmmm?"

"Will that girl be around?"

"Which girl, baby?"

"The one who met us at the Club that night."

"No, I know your jealous string… had seen that in you that night. Have ensured she does not come tonight."

Kavya became visibly relaxed and pressed his hand, "Thank you."

"You don't need to get insecure. Kavya… I am only yours."

She raised his hand and kissed it softly, looking into his eyes passionately."

"You don't play fair, Mrs. Joshi."

'*So it's working*,'… Kavya thought and gave a mischievous grin.

"Keep it up and you will remember me every time you walk tomorrow, baby," Aadi whispered in her ear.

Kavya was shocked he could say something like this in public and looked down blushing hard. Aadi grinned. "I can see you got the picture in your head, baby."

"Oh God! Guys, go get a room." One of the guys sitting in the room said looking at them. Since the time they had entered,

they were engrossed in each other. Everyone laughed at his comment and Kavya blushed harder.

"Oh, shut up Jackass," Aditya said and turned to Kavya. "Let me introduce you to everyone. This is Ryan, Amit, PK, Nick, you already know Jatin. This is Jessica, Rupal, and Jane…" Kavya met everyone warmly. "My best friend's name is also Jane. She used to work with me in my previous company," she said looking at Aditya's friend, Jane. "Cool… then we can be best friends too!" Jane said beaming and hugging her. Kavya felt good instantly and relaxed.

Kavya got into conversations and fun discussions almost immediately as if she knew them all since ages; joining them in cracking jokes and serving food. Jatin slowed down the music and announced they will be playing daredevil shortly. Jane explained Kavya that it was an improved version of truth and dare and when the bottle turns, it's a compulsory dare. Kavya found it a fun idea.

The game started. The 'dares' given were very funny, everyone fell off their chairs, laughing. Kavya's turn came and she was worried thinking about what they will ask her to do.

"Well, Kavya, we have been observing you still have the same glass of wine in your hand, which I handed over to you when you came. You are not drinking at all."

'*Shit*,' Kavya thought, realizing she had got caught. "So, your dare is going to be simple - drink your glass bottoms up."

"Oh! I can't, I am not used to it." She got scared and looked at Aadi who was laughing with the others. He looked at her and said, "Relax, Manu, do it… I will take care of you." She reluctantly took the glass up but kept it down again saying no. Nonetheless, everyone around started pushing her so she finally clipped her nose and polished off her drink. Her expression was as if someone had forced a kid to take medicines. Everyone rolled laughing, looking at her.

Kavya felt light-headed and she held Aadi's shirt. Aadi instantly wrapped his hand around her. "Manu, are you okay?"

"Yeah, I am fine," she said. He asked Jane to get a glass of ice-cold water and gave it to Kavya. "Here, drink it… you will feel better."

"Hmmm…"

"No, I will hold, you drink."

"God… she is like a kid," Jessica commented sarcastically, getting jealous looking at the way Aadi was protective about her. "Easy Jessica…" Aadi shot her an angry look and she immediately backed off. "Kavya is not used to drinking and parties. Of course, she is light-headed."

Kavya had water and told Aadi she was fine. She was trying her best to keep thinking straight. The game continued for a few more rounds. Aadi was surprised and happy the way she was handling herself. She was slightly off balance but she was well composed not to let anyone get the feel. By the time the game finished, many of the guests had on the rocks drinks and half of them had dozed off there itself. House parties were usually this crazy.

After finishing off the game, Jatin dimmed the lights and played soft music. A few of them started dancing while a few left saying goodbyes, wishing and congratulating Aditya and Kavya. Kavya looked at Aadi and whispered, "Aadi…"

"Hmmm?"

"I want to dance."

Aadi smiled, "You are still light-headed, baby."

She nodded shyly and said, "I am sorry."

"Don't be a baby, it's alright, nothing wrong. I love the way you pull yourself off. Come," he said, almost lifting her, but she stood properly. He took her in his arms and started moving slowly on the tune. She hugged him back.

"Aadi…"

"Hmmm…"

"I love you," she whispered. Aadi looked back at her with a grin. "I love you too, baby." He kissed her nose. "Come, let's go home."

"No, I want to dance more," she said pouting.

"We will dance once we reach back home, baby. Come."

He waved at Jatin who nodded and Aditya left from there with Kavya. Kavya was feeling light on air as Aadi drove back. He parked the car at the main entrance and lifted Kavya in his arms who happily hugged him smiling ear to ear. "Someone is very happy today," Aadi said looking at her smile. "I am happy because I have you," she said hugging him, kissing on the cheeks. Aadi grinned. He knew her new found boldness to confess was thanks to the wine.

Aadi kept her on the bed and she pulled him on the bed along. "Manu…" Aadi said, but before he could say much, she came on top of him, looking at him with eyes full of desire. Before he could react, she pulled off her dress and Aadi whistled while she giggled at his reaction. She kissed him hard, almost tearing his shirt. "God, Kavya! Slow down…" She giggled again. "No," she was resolute and started kissing his neck and almost fumbling to open his shirt. She went down on him removing his jeans.

"You are killing me, Kavya." Aadi pulled her up kissing her hard, opening her hook. She was on fire and watching her like this, Aadi lost his control. He started sucking her boobs wildly, pinching her nipples. Aadi made her sit in his lap and worked slowly on her breasts, driving her crazy with desire. Kavya was pushing her hand through his hair, pressing him harder. She pushed him back to the bed, taking his manhood in hand. Aadi moaned hard, Kavya loved it. She went down, licking him up and down. Aadi hissed breathlessly with desire. "Slow baby…" She took him in mouth and started sucking. "Yeah… like this!" He started guiding her head. "Oh God, Kavya…" He inserted a finger inside her as she sucked him hard and she moaned along… He pulled Kavya up and pinned her to the bed, kissing her wildly. In one swift move, he pushed himself inside her and Kavya let out a soft moan arching her back. He kept moving softly, driving her wild. Her nails pressed in his back and Aadi realized she was close and increased his speed. Kavya kept moaning taking his name as she had the orgasm. Aadi collapsed on her breathlessly as he came inside her.

"You drive me insane, girl," Aadi said, softly kissing her and she smiled. "Sleep, love."

She turned and hugged him. Her naked body fitted perfectly against his. He took her into an embrace and pulled a duvet on them.

Kavya got up in the morning, trying to remember everything that had happened the night before and felt embarrassed. '*Drinking; Oh no! The drinks… dance… we reached here… shit… what Aadi must be thinking about me*,' she thought and covered her face.

Then she realized she was naked. '*Oh shit*!' She tried pulling the duvet and Aadi got up. Watching her from behind, she looked perfect. He grinned watching her embarrassed and decided to tease her a bit. He got up and hugged her from behind.

"Aa.. Aadi… What are you doing?"

"Oh! What AM I doing? Feeling shy, baby?"

"Please Aadi," she said clinging to the duvet.

He whispered in her ear, "Well, someone did not feel shy yesterday night while tearing my shirt apart."

"Oh shit! Did I?"

Aadi laughed. "Yes you did, and I loved it!"

"Oh gosh! I am never going to drink again," Kavya said covering her face again.

Aadi laughed harder. "Do you want to know everything else you did?"

She turned to face him covering his mouth. "Please don't embarrass me more…" and the duvet fell off. Aadi removed her hand and kissed it softly, taking her in his arms.

"There is nothing to get embarrassed about it, baby. You were just bold enough to explore your desires openly, and that's lovely. However, I would love it even more if you become bold enough to do it without the influence of alcohol. By the way, I am proud of you the way you handled yourself yesterday at the party after the bottoms up. It was a thirty-two-year-old wine, not an easy one to handle."

"Thank you," she said, pressing her nose against his chest. "Ms. Insatiable…" Aadi said and Kavya giggled. He whispered in her ear, "You should try to walk before you seduce me more, baby." And Kavya looked up at him. Aadi gave her a mischievous grin going back to bed. Kavya pulled the duvet and got up giving out a soft moan in pain. Seeing her struggle, Aadi laughed. She looked back at him feeling more embarrassed now.

"I always keep my promises, Manu. I told you, you will remember me every time you walk the next day," Aadi said blowing a kiss at her. "Oh gosh! Aadi, you are too much," she said, running into the washroom. "Get ready, kitten, we will leave in an hour's time," Aadi said.

Chapter 14

She came out of the washroom wearing sleek, blue jeans and a mauve colored top. She tied her hair in a high ponytail and applied some matching lipstick and kajal. She searched for Aadi, but he was not around. She decided to go back to her room to pick up her bag. As she entered her room, she saw a rose on the bed with a small box and paper.

There were Diamond earrings with a rose and a small, pink paper saying 'Love you!' She kissed the paper and kept both the rose and the paper neatly in a drawer. She changed her earrings and wore the new ones. She was not used to taking gifts, but Aadi did not leave any opportunity to surprise her. He was spoiling her all the time and she was loving it.

She quickly collected her bag and went to Aadi's room. He was sitting on the sofa signing a few papers. He looked so serious that for a minute, she reconsidered disturbing him. She stood near the door.

"Why are you waiting there, Manu?" Aadi said without looking up.

"How do you know I am here?"

He looked up and smiled.

She reached near him and hugged from behind whispering in his ear, "Thank you."

He looked back and saw the earrings. They look lovely on you. She blushed.

"Where is my return gift?" Aadi said and she leaned forward to kiss him.

"Naah! After knowing your wild side yesterday, I want more."

"Oh Aadi!" She blushed and came around sitting next to him. Aadi pulled her in an embrace and she happily went in his arms.

"Aadi…"

"Hmmm…"

"Will I ever get used to this? Every time I touch you…" She lost her words.

Aadi laughed. "The feeling is mutual, Manu."

They both went down with their bags. Rashmi and Shiv were waiting for them on the Patio. Kavya touched their feet. Rashmi hugged her while Shiv hugged Aadi. "Enjoy yourselves. Don't worry about work here, I will take care."

"Thanks, dad," Aadi said and they walked towards the car. Aadi gave her a hand to get into the car and went on the other side sitting in the driver seat.

"By when we will reach, Aadi?"

"By night time, princess. It's gonna be looooooong drive…" Aadi said and Kavya giggled. Aadi wore sunglasses chuckling at her sound. You tempt me too much," and started driving.

Kavya played songs, light-hearted party numbers and started singing along, dancing in her seat. Aadi saw her and smiled in satisfaction. She was opening up slowly, being herself around him. Aadi decided to call Kavita and Sandhya.

"Manu…"

"Umm…" she said while singing a song.

"Let's make a video call to Sandhya." She smiled back at him. He was so thoughtful. She reduced the volume and called Sandhya.

"Hi, Diiii!"

"Hi, Sandhya… How are you?"

"I am cool. Was about to go to college. You guys are going to Goa, right? Are you in the car?"

This was a surprise to Kavya as she had not told her. "How do you know?"

"You forgot us sister, but Jiju calls us daily. He told me yesterday."

"I was just occupied a bit, Sandhya. I can never forget you," she said with almost tears in her eyes.

"Just kidding, di. I am sure Jiju keeps you occupied enough," Sandhya said winking.

"Sandhya…" She tried scolding her and blushing scarlet. Aadi laughed.

"Don't laugh, Aadi."

"Well, she is right, isn't she?"

Kavya pushed him softly and Sandhya started laughing.

"Sandhya! Don't laugh… Oh gosh! You two are too much," Kavya said covering her face. Kavita came out of the kitchen. "Hi, beta!"

"Hi, mom, how are you?"

"I am fantastic," Kavita said wiping her tears as she saw Kavya. "How are you?"

"I am also good, mom… I miss you."

"We miss you too, beta. When are you coming back from your honeymoon?"

She looked at Aadi as even she had not discussed it with him. "When are we coming back?" Aadi smiled and took the phone from her. He parked the car aside.

"Hi, Mom…"

"Hi, Aadi…"

"We will come back in a few days."

"Okay. I think you guys are on the way. We should not disturb you for long. Enjoy both of you and take care of each other."

"Yes, mom."

He handed over the phone to Kavya.

"Bye, mom."

"Bye…"

Kavya kept the phone down and wiped her tears, looking down.

"Hey," Aadi took her face in his hand and kissed her, taking her in his arms. In a moment, she forgot everything and kissed him back. In some time, Aadi pulled back and said, "If we continue like this, we won't be able to reach Goa."

Kavya softly wiped her lips looking out of the window, blushing. Aadi pulled the car back to the road and started driving. "You are blushing now with a simple kiss. But if I remember correctly, you were not blushing yesterday night when you…"

"Oh gosh, Aadi! Please stop reminding me of yesterday."

Aadi laughed. "You are so much fun after wine, Kavya. I have full intentions to make you become that bold without wine."

Kavya laughed along, "Keep hoping…"

"Yeah, I will."

On their way, they caught up with all the years they had missed. Kavya was talking her heart out, of all the events that happened after she lost her dad. Aadi was listening patiently. Aadi filled her with his life events as well, and somewhere in between, Kavya dozed off. Aadi saw her and smiled, he reduced the volume of the music and drove ahead.

Kavya woke up the next day in Aadi's arms in a room. "Oh! When did we reach? How did I come here?" Aadi was sleeping wrapped around her. She looked at him and smiled. He looked so peaceful. Kavya ran her fingers through his hair and kissed his cheeks softly. Aadi smiled as she kissed. She went into his arms.

She got up after some time. This house was bigger than the earlier one. It was all white. White walls with white curtains and the room in which they were sleeping had all glass walls. She opened the curtain and saw seashore ahead.

'*Wow,*' she thought and sat on a long sofa in front of the window. '*How life can turn a full 360 degrees in less than a month. A few days back, I was unsure of the very next day. And today, I am here with the love of my life, living a life of dreams.*' She thanked God and also thanked her father in her heart for

this happiness. She was so happy that she was getting scared of the feeling. This was holding her back from showing her love for Aadi. What she was not aware of was, Aadi knew this.

Aadi got up and joined her on the sofa. He kept his head in her lap and closed his eyes again. Kavya was softly patting him, running her fingers through his hair. "Aadi…"

"Hmmm…"

"You must be tired of driving, right?

"A little bit."

"How stupid of me, I should have realized; I am sorry."

"Don't be sorry, Manu. I enjoyed it more than you."

She smiled back. "What is the plan for today?"

"Whatever my princess wants to do."

"Right now, I want to take a shower."

"Let's take a bath together instead."

"Aadi…" she said blushing. "I am not asking you, I am telling you. We are having a bath together. Join me in ten minutes."

Aadi got up. He arranged a few scented candles and added aroma oils to the water in the bathtub. It was a huge oval-shaped tub. Aadi added a few rose petals in it and called Kavya. "Manu, come…"

Kavya entered the bathroom and was surprised. "When did you arrange all this?"

"Just now," he said raising his hand. "Come, baby…"

"Aadi…"

"Don't be shy, baby, come."

She went out, removed her clothes, wore a bathrobe, and entered again. Aadi smiled. "Are you going to get into the bathtub with the robe?" He asked mischievously. "Aadi…" She said with mocking anger. "Close your eyes for a minute." He complied, relaxing in the tub. She quickly removed the robe and entered the tub, trying to hide herself with foam. "Come here, baby." Aadi gave her a hand and hugged her. A fire evoked as their skin touched and she kissed him.

"Hmm… I was hoping for this," Aadi whispered, sucking her neck softly. She gave out a soft moan digging her fingers in

his back. They came out almost after an hour's passionate love-making. Kavya decided to go for a bright yellow sundress. She tied her hair high. Aadi chose black shorts and a blue t-shirt. Kavya looked at him, he was setting up his hair. She walked towards him and stood leaning on the wall.

"Like what you see, angel?" Aadi said smiling. "Love it…" she said. "Keep watching me like this, and we won't step out of this room the whole day." Kavya giggled. "Well, I won't complain."

"Really?" Aadi said pulling her close, and she giggled harder. Aadi tickled her and she ran away laughing hard. "Stop it, Aadi."

"Come, let's go."

"Are you going to drive again? I am sure you must be tired," Kavya said getting worried. "No baby, we will have a driver." She smiled satisfied with it. "But it means, I will have to keep my hands to myself while we are out," Aadi said disappointed, softly pouting. '*So cute*,' Kavya thought and went to him and kissed him. Aadi kissed her back softly.

The more time they were spending together, the more Aadi found his childhood friend, old Kavya coming out. She was talking her heart and mind out to him. Aadi also had no filter in the conversations with her, about his college days, his plans for the company expansion, his interests… Kavya was very supportive and was able to add value to the conversations by giving her opinions and suggestions. Aadi thought he had got the perfect life partner and it was time to head back to Mumbai.

"Manu…" Aadi said, sitting on the sofa with Kavya in his arms.

"Hmmm…"

"I was thinking we should head back tomorrow."

"Oh!" Kavya said pouting, feeling sad with thought.

"Baby, we will still be together, just not in Goa. It's been a week we are here. There's a lot of work pending."

"Yes, I understand. Let's go back tomorrow. Even I need to start my work."

"Yes," he said smiling, running his fingers through her hair.

"Manu…"

"Hmmm?"

"I love you."

She hugged him harder. "I love you too, Aadi."

They reached home. Shiv and Rashmi came down to greet them. Rashmi teased Kavya and Aadi a bit and both of them blushed like teenagers. Watching them blush, Shiv joined Rashmi. "You look tired, Aadi."

"It was a long journey, dad."

"Oh, is it? Well, I have not seen you this tired even after the US trips."

Kavya blushed and tried excusing herself to the kitchen to bring pickle, but Rashmi held her hand and made her sit. "You look equally tired. Sit, let me bring it."

"Mom, please," she said looking down. Rashmi and Shiv laughed hard looking at them. They finally finished dinner and almost ran upstairs.

Kavya came out of the washroom with a sad face.

"What happened, Manu?

"Nothing…" she said looking down.

"Hey…" Aadi said, lifting her face up with his hands.

"We need to stay away for four days," she said, looking away.

"Thank God," he said visibly relaxing as he understood what she meant. I was going to ask you what the dates are, coz I was worried… we were not entirely careful.

"Oh!" Kavya said surprised.

"So you are sad because you got your periods?"

"Aadi…" she felt embarrassed as Aadi said it. Aadi laughed.

"Can I ask you something?" Kavya said, looking at her knotted hands.

"Hey, you don't need my permission to ask me anything, Manu. Go on…"

"Will it be that bad if I get pregnant?"

Aadi raised her face in his hands. "It will be lovely if you get pregnant, Manu. Thinking of having a small Kavya in my arms,

makes my heart swell. But this life with you is like a dream to me. I have thought of it, dreamed of it for years. Now that I have you, I am not ready to share you yet. I need time."

"Oh Aadi!" Kavya hugged him and tears started flowing from her eyes. Aadi patted her head softly.

"Now you tell me one thing, honestly…"

"Hmmm…" she said.

"Do you want a kid sooner?" Kavya blushed and came out of his embrace. "Come on, tell me. There is nothing more important to me than your happiness, Kavya."

"We will wait, Aadi. Even I want time with you." Aadi smiled. "I am sure about it, Ms. Insatiable," and Kavya giggled.

"Do you need anything, baby? Are you okay… you have any pain?"

"No, I am just tired," she said, stretching her arms. Aadi had a mischievous grin on his face. "What?" She asked. "You have a mark on your neck."

"I know, I saw it in the morning," she said giving a mischievous grin back. "Why are you smiling?" She came forward and whispered in his ear. "You have two."

"Oh…" he said running to see himself in the mirror," and Kavya giggled.

"Shit! I have a meeting tomorrow."

"Great! Now everyone will know you are taken," Kavya said laughing harder.

"It's a matter of four days, Manu. Keep waiting, trust me, I will ensure you have more visible marks." She just laughed and went in his arms.

Next day morning Kavya opted for clothes from her new wardrobe. She went for a simple navy trouser with a white shirt. It had nice fluffed sleeves and a unique one-side cut. She loved it. She applied minimal makeup, the way Rashmi had shown her and went for a nude lipstick. Aadi was already up and was studying contract papers. She went and sat next to him.

"Aadi…"

"Hmmm…" he said without looking up.

"How do I look?" He looked up and raised eyebrows. "Wow," he said. She blushed and looked down.

Aadi kept the papers down and pulled her close, kissing her. She kissed him back with equal passion. "Umm… you have missed me," Aadi said grinning. She turned shy and got up. Aadi pulled her back and whispered in her ear, "Soon baby…" She nodded.

"So… today is your first day at work. How are you feeling?"

"Very nervous." Aadi smiled. "Don't be, baby. I am there." She hugged him back.

"Come, let's go down for breakfast."

Rashmi saw her in formals and got annoyed. "You are joining the office today?"

"Mom, you had asked me not to go until we come back from our holiday. Please let me join now." Rashmi gave out a sigh and agreed. "But let her come home on time okay? She is not going to have late sitting. I am warning both of you right now." Shiv smiled, "Yes, she will be all yours after six."

"Shall we go?" Aadi asked, and the three of them stepped out of the house. "Kavya, you will be working with the production team this week. Understand the complete line and report back to Aadi every day, end of the day. After fifteen days, you will give us a presentation."

"Okay, dad," she said.

"You will be working with…"

"Mr. Rajesh," she said promptly, cutting Shiv in between. "He heads the production, right?"

"Correct," Shiv said smiling.

Once they reached office, Shiv sent Jatin along with Kavya to introduce her with the team and he headed to his cabin. Aadi directly went to the conference room for his meeting.

Kavya took her time to understand every minute detail Mr. Rajesh was explaining; taking notes of every aspect and asking many questions. Rajesh answered her every query, impressed with the study she had done before coming. The day went in a jiffy and Kavya skipped her lunch. She was

studying machines when Aadi came for a round of the shop floor. Aadi used to come once in a while to have a surprise check on everything. Rajesh promptly went out to attend Aditya. He asked if he should call Kavya, but he said no. She was completely engrossed in her work not even noticing he was around. He smiled satisfied with her efforts and went ahead.

At 6 pm, Rajesh came back to Kavya and reminded her that she needed to go home.

"Has Aditya left for the day?"

"Sir has gone out for a meeting some time back. Your car is ready outside."

"I wanted to finish this part before going, actually."

"We have got instructions from Rashmi mam to send you home on time."

Kavya felt embarrassed. "Okay," she said.

She called Shiv. "Dad, where are you?"

"I am home, beta. I came back at lunchtime. Have you left?"

"No, I was about to leave," she said winding up papers.

"Okay, beta. Come soon."

She looked at Rajesh and asked him, "if you don't mind, can I take these papers home?"

"Sure, mam."

"Please don't call me mam. I am way too younger than you."

He smiled and nodded.

She waved bye to the team and headed back home. '*Shit… my tiffin is still full*,' she thought. Mom is going to be mad at me. Kavya reached home and Rashmi hugged her warmly. "Come… you will have some tea? Anything to eat?"

"I would love to have something to eat, actually," Kavya said. "I will just quickly change and come down."

"Give me your tiffin and then go."

"Don't worry, I will keep them in the kitchen on the way," Kavya said swiftly and went to the kitchen. Rashmi realized she was trying to hide something as she avoided eye contact, so she went to the kitchen after she went upstairs. Her tiffin was full; uneaten, untouched.

Rashmi came out and started talking to Shiv. "Shiv, I had told you… don't make her work too hard. Today was her first day and she has skipped her lunch already. This is not done."

"Oh! Did she?" Shiv asked getting worried.

"She is not your son for heaven's sake. She is your daughter, let her have some life."

"She is no less talented than my son, dear. But I agree, let's talk to her once she comes down."

Kavya came down shortly after and saw her tiffin on the dining table.

"Kavya, what is this? Rashmi asked.

"Sorry, mom," Kavya apologized.

"This is not done, Kavya. How can you skip your meals? If these guys are giving you too much work, you will have to tell me."

"Please mom, it's not like that. No one forced me to do anything. It's just that I was so excited. This is all so interesting that I could not stop myself from working and missed having lunch."

Rashmi was still not looking convinced. Kavya went and hugged her from behind making a small face. "Please, mom… I promise I will eat from tomorrow."

"Of course, you will. Coz I will come to the office with the tiffin and will personally ensure you three eat."

"Oh! Aadi also did not eat?" She asked and Rashmi smiled.

"He ate today. He had a lunch meeting."

"Good," Kavya said, feeling better.

"Someone gets worried so fast," Rashmi said teasing Kavya…

"Oh, mom, please!" Kavya sat at the table and started eating. "This is fabulous," she said. "I made it," Rashmi said.

Aadi joined them soon. "Early dinner?" he said looking at Kavya. "No. It's her lunch," Rashmi said. "Madam skipped it."

"Kavya…" Aadi said angrily.

"Aadi please," mom has scolded me already.

Shiv laughed and joined Aadi. "No, but my son has a right to scold. Go on, beta."

"Dad, please! Not you too…"

The whole evening went in fun, teasing, and talks. Aditya excused himself post-dinner and went to the study room to finish his work. Kavya joined him there and hugged him from behind. Aadi left all his papers and turned to hug her tight, kissing her hard. "I missed you," Aadi said.

"I missed you too," she said.

"I have some urgent work to finish, baby, then I will join you."

"You work so much Aadi."

"So do you, princess. I saw you today on the shop floor."

"Oh! You came?"

"Yeah, I met Rajesh and his team. You were studying some machinery."

"Why you did not come and meet me then?" Kavya said pouting.

"Coz if I would have come there, we would have gotten started then and there."

"Aadi…" Kavya blushed and he kissed her again.

"Will see you in some time, baby."

"Hmmm," she said and left.

She went back to their room and remembered she had carried a few papers along. She took them out and sat on the sofa making her notes. She got so engrossed that she did not realize when Aadi came to the room. He came and hugged her from behind the way she always did.

"It's just the first day, baby. Don't work so hard."

"I love working, Aadi," she said smiling.

"And I love you!"

The complete week went in a jiffy. Kavya was catching up with work fast and Rajesh was highly impressed with her grasping. She was very down to earth with his team and she never showed any attitude of being from the owners' family or MD's wife, even once. She quickly became friends with everyone and had lunch with them instead of going upstairs to eat with Aadi. Next day was her presentation to Shiv and Aditya. The entire team helped her with data and inputs wishing her the best.

It was well past 8 when Kavya got up from her chair only to stretch and get back to work. She checked her phone. '*Shit… five missed calls, twelve messages*.' She checked… all were from Aadi.

"Where are you, Manu?"

"What are you doing? Missing you."

"My work will be over early today, can we go out for dinner?"

"Reply back girl…"

'*Shit, shit! Me and my habits. Aadi is going to be mad*,' Kavya thought.

She quickly dialed his number and heard it ringing nearby. '*Is he here?*' She thought.

"Aadi… I am sorry, I got so engrossed in work and did not check the messages. It's just that I have the presentation tomorrow and I…"

"Aadi came to her desk and stood there smiling.

"I am not angry with you, baby. I am proud of you," he said, taking her face in his hand and kissed her forehead. "Aadi, what are you doing? There are people around here," Kavya said blushing. Aadi whispered in her ear, "Since the time we came from Goa, I have not made enough efforts to make you blush, baby. Come, let's go home." Kavya just nodded turning red and started packing papers along.

"You are not going to get time to work tonight baby."

"Aadi, we have a presentation tomorrow."

"It's in the evening. Come early and work."

"Hmmm…" she said picking up her purse and joined him. She said goodbye to Rajesh. Rajesh saw Aditya and informed, "I am glad you are here, it's the third time since the morning she is rehearsing the presentation." Kavya blushed, feeling embarrassed. But to her surprise, Aadi smiled at Rajesh and said, "I am glad to hear that Mr. Rajesh. Keep yourself free at five-thirty for the presentation."

"Sure, sir."

Chapter 15

Aadi asked the driver to take Kavya's car and he drove Kavya back in his car. He held her hand and kissed it. "I missed you, Manu." She went in his arms and whispered, "I missed you too, Aadi."

When he missed the usual turn, she looked at him. "Where are we going?"

"For a dinner date…"

"Oh, I am not wearing the right clothes for a date," she said looking at herself.

"You always look perfect to me, baby."

She went into his arms slowly, rubbing her nose and cheeks on his shoulder.

"Manu, I have not had you for almost a week. Keep doing this, and we will skip dinner." She smiled at the thought and hugged him harder. Aadi chuckled.

They reached a fancy building and Kavya looked at him confused. "Where are we going, baby?" She asked. "Baby?" Aadi smiled raising eyebrows, "that's my word," he said pulling her nose. "Ouch!" Kavya said, "Tell me."

"There is a restaurant on top, you get awesome veg tandoor."

"Wow," she said beaming.

They reached the venue. They had white sofas and blue lights. The restaurant was almost full. "I think we are late, it's

full; we will have to wait." Aadi smiled at her, "I have booked a private dinner section, baby… come."

"Oh!" She was not used to this. "A private dinner? Why?"

"Because I wanted you all by myself," he said pressing her hand softly and she blushed.

They had a separate section emptied with a single round table at the center. The walls were completely transparent glass, giving a view of the city. "It's lovely," Kavya said admiring the view. "It is lovely coz you are here, princess," Aadi said, hugging her. "Aadi…" she said looking down. He kissed her neck and smiled. "Come, I am famished."

He pulled a chair for her, helping her settle before he sat next to her. Aadi had pre-ordered the menu. He discussed her work progress. She explained to him everything she was doing with enthusiasm. Her zeal towards work was contagious. Aadi was once again amazed by the length in which she had studied everything. If there would have been any other girl, she would have had thrown an attitude on the others as she was senior to them. But Kavya did not take anything for granted and was very cordial with everyone. '*It's rare*,' he thought and pulled her hand to kiss it.

Kavya's link in talking broke as he kissed. "Aa… Aadi... What are you doing?" Kavya said blushing. "Enough of work-talks, princess, I am here with my wife."

She nodded. "Sorry, I got into the flow. Did not realize I spoke for so long."

"Hey, you don't need to apologize for being you, baby. I love listening to you.

Would you like a glass of wine?" Aadi said looking into her eyes romantically.

She remembered what happened the last time when she had it. She blushed scarlet and looked down nodding no. Aadi took her hand and sucked her little finger. She let out a soft moan taking his name. Aadi gave her a mischievous grin. "Good you are not having wine, you need to learn to turn wild without it."

"Aadi, please…" she looked away and Aadi laughed. She lost her appetite and kept her fork down. Aadi looked at it and raised his eyebrow. "Are you done?"

"Yes," she said simply, wiping her mouth with a tissue. "But you hardly ate anything, Kavya." She whispered in his ear, "Right now I am not hungry for food…" and Aadi chuckled. "Come, let's go home."

They reached home and saw Shiv and Rashmi sitting in the living room watching TV.

Kavya and Aadi looked at each other and tried having a small-talk with them before Aadi wished them good night and headed upstairs. Rashmi realized and nodded Kavya with her eyes to join him. After they went upstairs, she looked at Shiv and said, "Shiv, it looks like we will be grandparents very soon." Shiv laughed. Aadi almost pulled her into the room and switched off the lights. Kavya giggled.

Next day morning, Kavya got up very early. She looked at Aadi and her heart swelled again. She was too tempted to get back to sleep, but she had work to do. Very softly, she came out of the bed and got ready. Everyone at home was sleeping. She called her driver and asked him to pull out the car in five minutes. She sent a message to all three of them saying, "Leaving early to work… Good day."

She sent another message to Aadi. "Aadi, I love you…" with multiple kiss smileys.

She reached the office and got back to work. Rajesh thought she was going to present only the presentation part, but she had planned a few more things. She had prepared the process improvement plan for the department. She had been working on that alongside.

Aadi got up and saw Kavya was not around. He checked his phone and saw her message. '*Mad girl*,' he thought.

He joined Shiv and Rashmi for breakfast. "You guys are making Kavya work very hard," Rashmi complained again. "We are not," Shiv said. "She is a workaholic, Rashmi."

"Yeah," Aadi joined in. "We are just letting her be herself and she is extremely bright. You know what, dad? Yesterday she discussed a few aspects of production with me in terms of improvement plan; fantastic suggestions. Some things I have not got from Rajesh, ever. She is planning to add them in her presentation today."

"Oh, is it?" Shiv said. "It will be interesting to see."

"If she is a workaholic, then isn't it your responsibility to teach her a work-life balance? Have you guys noticed? It's less than a month she got married and she looks like she has lost a lot of weight. She keeps skipping her meals and both of you don't say anything to her. This is not done."

"I agree with you," Shiv said. Aadi nodded in agreement. "I will look into it, mom. Perhaps I think we all can have lunch together in the office."

"That's a great idea!" Rashmi said. "It's done then. I will come every day and we will all have lunch together." She handed over the tiffin to Aadi. "This is Kavya's breakfast and ensure she eats it." Aadi smiled at Rashmi, kissing her on cheeks. "Bye, mom."

"Bye, beta."

Aadi reached office and asked Esha to call Kavya to his cabin. Kavya got confused and thought it must be related to work. She took her diary and went to Aditya's cabin.

"Sit," he said and she sat on a chair in front of his desk. The office assistant came with a plate of breakfast and Kavya smiled. He called Esha and instructed not to disturb him until further notice.

"Looks like I need to force-feed my girl."

"Aadi… I am not hungry. I was in the middle of…" Aadi placed a finger on her lips. "Don't argue, baby. Dad and I have got a good scolding from mom today and she is right. You really have lost weight," Aadi said feeling sad.

"Aadi, I haven't; really… please…" she held his face in her hand. "See, I am eating." She started eating and Aadi visibly relaxed. "Kavya, you need to learn to have a work-life

balance. Work is not going anywhere. We have the whole life to accomplish… But promise me, you won't compromise your health for work."

She got up and hugged him. "I promise, Aadi. I love you…"

He hugged her back and whispered, "I love you too." He looked into her eyes and kissed her hard; she kissed him back. They backed off when they both were breathless and Aadi gave her a mischievous grin.

"What happened?"

"I hope you have a scarf with you, else today's presentation will show off your neck."

"Is there a love bite? Shit…" and Aadi laughed.

"Aadi, don't laugh. What should I do now?"

"Relax, I will arrange one for you," he said kissing her nose. "Last night was lovely," he said. "Don't tempt me, Aadi," she said. "Really?" He said, running his hand over her waist and she leaned her head back with desire. Aadi kissed her neck. There was a knock on the door and Kavya got straightened up getting scared. Aadi smiled and said, "Later, baby," and went to the other side.

"It was Esha. Sorry to disturb you, sir, but your next meeting is in ten minutes."

Kavya got up. Aadi looked at her, "Sit," he said. "Finish the breakfast and then leave."

"Aadi, I am full."

He gave her an angry glance once again and she sat back. She finished her plate and looked at Aadi. "Finished, sir. Now can I get back to work?" His eyes became warm. "Yes, you can," he said with a smile. She started walking and Aadi said, "Kavya, you will get your scarf on your table in some time." She blushed and nodded walking away. Aadi smiled. '*I will never get used to seeing her blush*.'

She went back to her desk and finished her work. The presentation was in twenty minutes so she decided to head to the conference room to ensure all arrangements were proper. She connected her laptop to the screen and kept all the notes ready.

She went through them one last time before the presentation, sipping her coffee."

Aadi entered the room with Shiv, Rajesh, Esha, Jatin, and a few other people. He saw her scarf and gave her a mischievous grin. She blushed scarlet. Everyone settled and Kavya started the presentation at sharp 5.30. She was given 30 minutes for it so she had prepared the data for 20 minutes, keeping 10 minutes for queries.

It was mesmerizing to see her present. In less than 10 minutes, she briefed about the whole department's work and structure. She had made charts in such a way that it was easy to understand even for a new joinee, yet they had an absolute depth of information. Her presentation skills were so good that it could give any b-school pass-out student a run for their money.

She came to her last section of the presentation on the process improvement plan. She was a bit nervous about this as it was too early. She looked at Aadi who gave her an encouraging nod. She started ahead. The points she raised were game-changer for them. She suggested a vital change in the production line and presented a complete cost and time-saving matrix on the implementation of the same. Rajesh and his team felt like putting their foot in their mouths watching her presentation. He was working with this company for years, but he never realized these obvious flaws in the process. Aditya's heart swelled with pride watching her present it.

When she finished, everyone stood up clapping for her. Kavya smiled back satisfied. Shiv got up and went and hugged Kavya. "I am proud of you," he said.

Aadi wished he could do the same. He just said, "Excellent work, Kavya. We will spend the next week in the implementation of the areas you have presented us. Post that, you will work with the accounts team."

"Esha, how am I placed tomorrow? We need an hour's slot."

"Eleven AM appointment can be shifted."

"Perfect. Rajesh - join me tomorrow at eleven with Kavya on the implementation plan. Kavya will lead it."

"Jatin - a few of her presentation slides… I want us to adapt to them for our client presentations and a few will form part of the company induction program. Collect a soft copy from her and discuss with me in some time."

"Esha - connect with the HR department. Kavya will give a presentation and power point skills training to our core team next week."

"I think we can close for the day, everyone. Thank you for joining us."

'*Oh my! He is so fast in decision-making*,' Kavya thought. '*It really is tough to match his thinking speed.*' She was lost in her thoughts when Aadi joined her. Everyone else was walking out of the room.

"Congratulations, Kavya!" Aadi said. "You impressed me once again. It's rare someone manages that in so less time." She smiled and said, "I am glad I could impress you. The more I see you at work, Aadi… it's my privilege to work with you. I have not seen anyone like you before. Such strong decision-making… this kind of vision… It's a rare mix."

Aadi smiled at her. "Together, we will do wonders." She smiled again. "Aadi, I am too small today to even reach to be your partner at the work-front. I can be a support system." This clicked an Idea in Aadi's mind and he smiled broadly.

"What happened?"

"Nothing, there is something I have been thinking for long now. You just gave me the answer to that."

"What?"

"Nothing, angel… just keep up the good work. I have some work on hand. You are heading home, right?"

"I was thinking of spending time with Rajesh for tomorrow's meeting."

"Nothing doing. You are going home and taking rest. I will be home in half an hour with dad."

"Okay," she said, calling the driver to take out the car.

Aadi straightaway headed to Shiv's cabin. "Dad, I have an idea."

"Come, son. I am so proud of Kavya. She is extremely talented, indeed."

"Yeah… dad, I was thinking… she can be the internal process auditor instead of the support function head for us and work on continuous improvement for the next six months. We must admit, what she came up with today, none of us had thought of it. After six months, she can lead all support functions."

"That's fantastic. Let's do this."

They discussed it in detail and headed back home together. "Dad, I wanted to halt in between."

"Meeting friends?" Shiv asked.

"No, actually wanted to buy something for Kavya. It was her first formal presentation at our company." Shiv smiled and nodded.

Aadi took a big bunch of Lemon lilies for her and got back in the car. "They are lovely," Shiv said and asked him to wait. "What happened, dad?"

"Even I have a wife, son. Let me pamper her a bit," and Aadi smiled as Shiv got down to buy flowers for Rashmi.

Both father and son entered home with flowers in their hands. Rashmi and Kavya were sitting on the Patio having coffee. Kavya reached home early and had changed into a simple, home, Punjabi dress and came down to spend time with Rashmi. She was very excited and was telling Rashmi all that happened in the office. She beamed as she saw Aditya and Shiv walk in.

Aadi went to Kavya and gifted her flowers. "For your today's achievement," Aadi said handing over the flowers. Kavya blushed as Shiv and Rashmi were around. Aadi took her hand and kissed it sitting next to her. Kavya pulled it back now, blushing scarlet. "Aadi…" she pleaded with her eyes to let go of her hand and Aadi gave her a mischievous grin, looking at her neck. She realized and pulled her dupatta near her neck before Shiv or Rashmi could see it.

Rashmi cleared throat and said, "Aadi, we are here," and Aadi gave a blushful smile and looked down.

Shiv handed over the flowers to Rashmi and said, "Thank you for giving me such a wonderful son and daughter-in-law," he kissed her on her cheeks and Rashmi blushed. Now Aadi cleared his throat saying, "Mom, we are here." They all laughed hard. Shiv announced, "We will be going out for dinner tonight to celebrate Kavya's first success. Kavya's heart swelled with happiness. They all loved her. She was thanking God in her heart for such a lovely family. Unknowingly, tears dropped from her eyes and she quickly tried to look away and wiped them, but all of them noticed them.

Shiv came and kept his hand on her shoulders, "What happened, beta?"

"Nothing, dad," she said.

"Come on, say it…"

"You all love me so much. I never expected my life to be so beautiful. It's very overwhelming, I don't know how to thank you all."

"I know a way," Rashmi said.

"What?" Kavya asked her looking at her innocently.

"Give us grandchildren soon. No one else can give that to us!"

"Oh gosh!" Kavya said and ran inside the house blushing. Everyone laughed looking at her. Aadi excused himself along with her as even he felt shy and joined Kavya upstairs.

Kavya had turned red out of blushing and was standing near the window. Aadi joined her and stood in front of her. She was too shy to look at him. "Looks like you are not the only one wanting us to have kids sooner."

"Aadi…" she said looking down. "I agree with your thoughts. We should wait, we have the whole life for kids. Right now, I don't think even I am ready to share you." Before she could finish her sentence, Aadi pulled her in arms.

They came down after an hour. Kavya still had a flushed face. Rashmi and Shiv were already ready and sitting in the living room. All four drove in the same car. Rashmi teased them more and Kavya felt like hiding into a hole to avoid facing

them all. As they got down from the car, Aadi and Shiv walked ahead while Rashmi and Kavya followed them.

"Beta, I am teasing you just for fun. Plan kids whenever you two are ready, not because we are saying, okay?" Kavya nodded looking down and smiled. Rashmi laughed as she turned shy again and patted her head. "Come, let's have dinner."

After dinner, Kavya dozed off on Rashmi's shoulder in the car as she had got up very early. She nudged her softly as they reached home. "Beta, we are home," she said.

"Hmmm," Kavya said clinging to her hand in sleep. "Five minutes, mom."

All three of them smiled. Rashmi ran her hand through her hair. "Kavya, get up beta, we are in the car. Let's go inside."

Kavya realized and got up quickly. "Oh! Sorry, I did not realize I slept. I was just…"

"Relax, Kavya," Rashmi said, patting her softly. "Good night, beta, and don't get up very early tomorrow."

She nodded softly and went upstairs with Aditya.

Kavya led the meeting the next day in the office very confidently. Aditya realized she was a born leader. Rajesh was a decade more experienced than her, but he was following her instructions. She knew what she brought on the table and was not afraid when she spoke her mind. They drafted a base strategy on implementation and Kavya quickly got back to work. Days were flying by and Kavya's work was picking up pace. They had got the rhythm in working together. She was taking over department by department, leaving everyone amazed with her knowledge and sharp mind. However, she had now reached a hard point. Aditya shifted her in the quality department and Mr. Gokhle was a tough nut. He was an extremely insecure man and could not digest if anyone surpassed his powers. Kavya was finding it difficult to find a way around but was not ready to give up.

She was sitting in her cubical when Aditya passed the area. He saw her disturbed but did not go there. He called her and asked her to join him in his cabin.

"What happened, Manu?"

"Nothing, Aadi."

"We have been working together for almost a month, Kavya. I have never seen a single wrinkle on your head when you worked for any of the departments. I know something is wrong, tell me."

"Aadi, promise me you won't misunderstand."

"I will never misunderstand you, Kavya, what's wrong?"

"I can sense something is off in our quality department. I have dug from all dimensions, everything has come out clean, but my sixth sense is telling me - there is something obvious that I am missing."

"Kavya, you are getting hassled up because Mr. Gokhle is very secretive, but please don't worry; that does not mean something has to be wrong. He is just getting insecure of you."

"Aadi, I have handled insecurities of seniors before. This is something else. Trust me."

There was a long pause as they both were thinking. "What do you want to do, Kavya?"

"I want unrestricted and uninterrupted access to the department's data for the next ten days without the knowledge of Mr. Gokhle."

"Are you sure about this, Manu?"

"I don't know, Aadi… I always follow my heart. What I see here… it's all too good to be true. Rejection is always in the exact range as defined, customer complaints… less than three percent, vendor rejections less than four percent. I mean… Come on, is it practical? We are in manufacturing, I checked all our competitors' records. Their ratios are more than double, Aadi. This is impossible."

"How did you get access to competitors' data?"

Kavya smiled. "I have my ways these around things, Aadi."

Aadi nodded. "Done. You will shift to your cabin tomorrow onwards. I will declare in the company that you are working on a special project with me and no one will disturb you for

the next ten days. We'll set up all access on your system. Jatin can do that."

"Wait, Aadi…"

"What?"

"Can you ask someone other than Jatin?"

"Are you doubting him?"

"I am just being cautious," she said, choosing her words carefully.

There was a long pause. "Manu…" Before Aditya could say anything, Kavya grabbed his hand. "I am sorry for doing this, Aditya. I know it's not easy for you."

"Are you sure?"

"Of course I am not sure, Aadi. Rather, I hope and wish I am wrong. But all the pieces of evidence I have in hand so far, it's clear, someone is wiping out data from the backend. There are only three people in the entire company who have whole-data access. IT Head Mr. Malhotra, Jatin, and you. I can't take a risk, Aadi."

Aadi was thinking hard and was trying to hide his hurt. "It's a phase and it will pass," Kavya said. Aadi nodded. He called Esha but kept it down without instructing anything. "Let me do it myself." He took Kavya's laptop and set up data access.

"Thank you," Kavya said and Aadi just nodded in response.

Kavya walked towards the door and came back. "What happened?" he asked. She kept her laptop down on the table and hugged him. "Hey…" Aadi said, running his fingers through her hair. "I don't like hurting you or seeing you like this, Aadi. I am sorry."

"Don't say sorry when you are not wrong, Manu. You are just doing your work."

"I don't like doing this."

"I can understand." He pulled her out of his embrace and kissed her forehead. "I love you, Manu, and I have full trust in you." Her eyes started watering. "I love you too, Aadi and I hope I am wrong this time."

"Let time decide that. But not even once I want you to hesitate while carrying out this investigation." She nodded, wiping her tears. "Stop crying, baby, else I will have to kiss you."

"Aadi…" She looked down giving a shy smile and tried stepping back. Aadi smiled. "That's my girl. Go back to work now." As soon as she left, Aadi made a few calls and stepped out of the office for a meeting.

Kavya worked until late in the night and had instructed everyone not to disturb her. Aditya had left long back. She decided to save the data and left for the day. She texted Aditya that she has left from office, but he did not reply back. Kavya assumed he must have slept.

When she reached home, it was all dark. She thought everyone had slept. Kavya was actually hungry, she had skipped all meals today but was too tired to eat anything, so she decided to directly head to the room.

When she entered, she saw Aditya sitting on the sofa, peacefully, waiting for her with food. The entire room was decorated with soft lights of scented candles. She stood at the door and saw him. Aditya smiled back at her. "I am sure you have not eaten anything. Come," he said opening his arms.

She kept her bag on the side table and ran into his arms. He gave her a tight hug. More than physically, she was mentally exhausted. She needed him right now. He let her calm down and then pulled her face kissing her softly. She kissed him back, but he pulled himself back. You need to eat first, Manu."

"I am not hungry," she said pouting. Aadi smiled. "Ms. Insatiable, please eat first." Kavya looked down feeling shy.

Aadi fed her the food by his hand. Kavya was still in his arms and started talking about work. Aditya placed a finger on her mouth and said, "Shhh… No more work talks, baby. Relax." She nodded.

Kavya got up late the next day and looked at her watch. '*Shit! It's ten am already*.' She panicked and got out of the bed hurriedly. Aditya was lying beside her, still sleeping peacefully.

She saw marks of her lipstick on his neck and smiled. She was too tempted to go back in his arms and sleep, but there was a lot of work pending. She slowly ran her hands through Aadi's hair, waking him up."

Chapter 16

"Aadi…"

"Hmmm…"

"Wake up baby, look at the time."

He smiled opening his eyes lazily and looked at her. "What's the time?"

"It's ten already. What mom and dad must be thinking, we are very late for work. Come on, get up." He pulled her hand and she crashed on him. "Aadi, what are you doing? We are very late."

"Happy first month anniversary, baby," Aditya said, kissing her forehead.

"Oh! Oh, shit! I forgot," she said covering her face, feeling embarrassed and Aadi laughed, pulling her in an embrace. "It's okay, baby, you have been occupied with a lot of work."

"I have not even bought a gift for you," she said pouting. "Well, you can make up for it," Aadi said with a mischievous grin. She realized what he was pointing at and hid her face in his arms. She kissed him softly and wished him back, "Thank you for everything, Aadi."

"Welcome Mrs. Joshi," Aadi said, kissing her nose. So what do you want to do today, princess?

We have a lot of work pending in the office. You know I was working on this data yesterday, and…" Before she could continue, Aadi pulled her. "Oh please give me a break," and kissed her.

They both came down for breakfast after a shower. Kavya was wearing a bright pink dress while Aadi chose a casual black t-shirt with a cargo 3/4th. As they came down, Shiv and Rashmi hugged them both wishing them for the anniversary. Rashmi handed over a Gift box to Kavya.

"What is this, mom?"

"Open it and see," Rashmi said with a smile. The box had a diamond set of earrings, a small pendant, and a bracelet. Kavya loved it. She beamed and hugged Rashmi. "Thank you so much, it's perfect." Rashmi smiled at her enthusiasm. "I was hoping you will like it, beta."

"I loved it."

"Where is my gift?" Aadi said looking at Rashmi. "We want a gift from you guys soon," Rashmi said pulling Aadi's ear and laughing. Kavya got embarrassed and looked down.

"What is the plan for today, beta?" Shiv asked. "I hope you guys are not coming to the office today."

"No papa, we have to come," Kavya said. "There is a lot of work pending."

"Work will never end, enjoy your day," Rashmi said.

"Let me at least go and collect my laptop. It has a lot of sensitive data."

"Then I will get someone to bring your laptop home. You guys are taking a break from work and that's it," Shiv declared. "Give me your official phones, both of you."

"But dad…"

"Don't argue, Aadi. Give it to me."

They both reluctantly handed their phones to Shiv. Shiv smiled and said, "You will get them back tomorrow morning on breakfast. Go ahead now, enjoy your day."

Kavya looked at Aadi. "What have you thought?"

"I have planned something," Aadi said with a mischievous grin. Kavya turned shy and looked away. "Let me bring my purse. Can you please get my laptop delivered home until then?"

"Why are you so worried about your laptop, Kavya?" Shiv asked.

"It's a long story, dad," Aadi said. "We will have a meeting tomorrow first thing in the morning, preferably before office hours," Aadi said in a serious tone. Shiv raised his eyebrows. "Let me ask Jatin to set up the meeting."

"No!" Both Aadi and Kavya said together. "Let only three of us meet first, dad. Don't inform anything to anyone."

"This sounds serious."

"It is serious," Aadi said sadly.

"Enough of work talks, three of you… Let the kids enjoy, Shiv. It's their day."

Shiv nodded, "You are right, this can wait."

"Come Kavya, let's go," Aadi said holding Kavya's hand. Kavya turned shy and tried freeing hand as Shiv and Rashmi were in front of them. She looked at Aadi with pleading eyes who just laughed. She gave up and waved bye to them while going with Aadi.

They got into the car and Kavya asked, "Where are we going Aadi?"

"Surprise," he said.

"Tell me."

"Come on, baby, it's a journey of a few hours." Kavya pouted and Aadi laughed.

On their way, they discussed Kavya's analysis at length and her suspected issues in the system and people. They both decided to hire a fraud detection team as a completely independent function, which will straightaway report to Kavya and Aadi.

Kavya was so engrossed in talking that she did not realize they reached the farmhouse where Aadi had proposed her.

"Oh! We are here," Kavya said surprised.

"Yes," Aadi said mocking her and she punched him laughing at his reaction.

"Come, kitten. Let's go inside."

They spent the whole the day there like love birds. Aadi cooked for her and pampered her to the fullest. After dinner, Aadi said, "We need to leave now."

"I don't want to go," Kavya said pouting.

"Then let's stay, and leave early morning tomorrow."

"I don't want to get up early," Kavya said pouting again and Aadi laughed.

"Yeah, we are going to have a looooooonnnnnggg night tonight!"

Kavya felt shy and looked down.

"If you look this cute, I think we will directly go tomorrow morning. Come with me." Aadi held her hand and took her to the bedroom.

"What happened, Aadi?"

He opened the cupboard and took out a gift-wrapped box. "What is this?"

"Well, it's a gift for me," Aadi said with a mischievous grin. "As in? I don't understand."

"Wear it, baby… I want to see you in this."

She opened the box and saw designer lingerie with net covers.

"Oh," she said. "Aadi… this is…"

Aadi leaned at the cupboard seeing her reaction. "Hmmm?" he said raising his eyebrows.

"There is hardly any fabric in this."

Aadi laughed hard. "Oh really? I did not notice…"

"Don't laugh," she said looking down. "I feel shy…"

Aadi raised her face up, "There is nothing I have not seen before baby." And her cheeks turned red.

She looked down again and slowly whispered, "Okay…"

"Cool… I am waiting outside."

"No, wait here only, I will change in the washroom."

Aadi smiled. "Okay, baby."

Kavya went to the washroom and opened the box properly. She removed her dress and wore the lingerie. It was bright violate in color and had exquisite designer cuts. Part of it was lacy and it hugged her curves perfectly. Then she took out the cover. It was ivory net cover with strings at shoulders and had big front slit below her bra.... it showed off her navel and barely reached her hips. Kavya looked in the mirror and almost felt naked.

'*Shit, how can I go out like this?*' She opened her hair, but it barely covered anything.

Aadi knocked on the door, "Kavya... Come out, baby... or should I come inside?" "No, don't!" '*Shit, I need to think something real quick*,' she thought.

"Aadi, its size is smaller. I am not fitting into it," she said.

Aadi laughed. "Liar... its stretchable fabric, come out now!"

Kavya took a deep breath and decided to step out. She opened the door lock, Aadi was standing some distance away. Kavya looked down and started folding her legs in her knees and pulling the dress down to cover herself. Aadi saw her and started laughing.

Kavya thought she wore something wrong and got confused. "Why are you laughing?" she asked.

"I thought you will look sexy, baby, but you look cute."

"Aadi..." she said with mocking anger and ran towards him to hit him, but Aadi held her hand laughing. Kavya tried freeing herself, but Aadi laughed harder. She suddenly realized what she was wearing and turned shy. Her aggression went off and now she was trying to free herself so she could cover her body. Aadi realized it and pushed her to the wall, holding her hands above her head.

"Aadi…" she said turning her head to one side, feeling shy.

"We are going to go real slow tonight, baby... Are you ready?"

She just managed a nod.

"I have something more, but we will use it only if you are comfortable."

She looked at Aadi with questioning eyes. He gave her a grin and said, "Later! Let me see you first. Keep your hands up, okay?" He held her both hands with his left hand and slowly ran his right hand through the slit of the front.

Kavya moaned taking Aadi's name and tried leaning forward to hug him, but he pushed her back. "Not so soon, baby. I want you to be hungry for me." His fingers lingered around her navel button and slowly went down, teasing the lace of her panty.

Kavya struggled to free her hands and started pulling Aadi close with her legs. Aadi leaned forward a bit and sucked her neck wildly. His grip on her hands loosened and she dug her nails in his back hugging him with her legs. Aadi kissed her hard and lifted her.

He went back to the cupboard taking out furry red handcuffs. He placed her on the bed and came on top. He slowly stepped aside breaking the kiss and showed the cuffs to Kavya. She saw them and got confused.

"Will you be okay, baby?" She nodded shyly.

Aadi tied both her hands to the bed, and laid down with her, kissing her hard. He was purposely touching her less to make her hungry for him. He then got back up and slowly and seductively started removing his t-shirt. His toned abs made Kavya's lips turn dry. She forgot for a minute that she was staring at him and ran her tongue along her lips. He removed his jeans and came on top of her. Kavya lifted her head to kiss him, but Aadi pulled back. He kissed her whole face softly, teasing her lips. He held her face in both hands and took his time to suck her lips softly.

Kavya was turning wild with desire and Aadi could sense it. He tore her dress freeing her bosom as he slowly started licking her down, sucking her body. His hands pinched her nipples making her moan loudly.

Aadi went down and sucked her breasts while his hand traveled down exploring her clit and massaging it softly. Kavya was moaning loudly taking his name and he realized she was about to have an orgasm. He inserted two fingers inside and kissed her fiercely. Kavya was completely wet, almost sobbing with pleasure.

Aadi removed her remaining clothes and went down on her, sucking the sweet spot while placing his fingers in and out. Kavya was crushing his head between her thighs as another wave of pleasure went through her body.

"Please free my hands," she finally managed to say, and Aadi opened the locks.

She immediately pushed Aadi on his back and came on top of him. Before he could realize, she was kissing him hard. Her nails dug in his shoulders and Aadi moaned. "Slow, baby..." he said and she went down licking, biting, and taking her time now to feel his body.

She took his manhood in her hand and licked, sucking the tip. Aadi moaned hoarsely, "Slow, baby..." she started sucking him hard while crunching his thighs. Aadi held her hair and pulled her up. They kissed hard and Aadi pushed her to the bed, pushing himself inside her in one swift move. Kavya crunched the pillow with both pleasure and pain. Aadi moved inside her, slowly, making her turn wild with desire. Only when he saw her moving her hips to push his harder, he pinned her down and pushed harder. Kavya cried taking his name as she could not bear the wave of pleasure. Aadi collapsed on top of her.

They both came to senses after some time. Aadi looked at the watch, it was 4:30 am. They had to leave in 2 hours. He pulled himself out of her and Kavya moaned again arching her back. "You are gonna turn me into an animal, girl," Aadi said, kissing her once again.

They both left early in the morning. Kavya slept in the car hugging Aadi's arm while he drove back to work.

He kissed Kavya's forehead and asked, "Tired baby?"

She just nodded sleepily and she smiled.

"Me too," he said and Kavya laughed.

"I can't help it, you looked so irresistible in that…"

Kavya covered his mouth with her hands before he could talk more. Aadi laughed and kissed her hands, but she pulled back quickly.

They directly went to office and Kavya came in work mode. They headed to the conference room where Shiv was already waiting for them, sipping a cup of coffee.

"Good morning, Dad."

"Morning son. You both look like zombies, do you want to postpone the meeting? Go home, grab some rest and come back."

Kavya and Aadi both turned shy on Shiv's comment and looked down.

"Come on, dad, nothing like that; we are good."

Kavya took the lead in the conversation and explained the entire situation to Shiv. The more he was listening, the more he was getting serious.

"I am surprised, Aadi, we missed this part out." Aadi nodded.

"What have you thought?"

Aadi told him about a separate department.

"No, it won't help. People will get alert if you hire a team in-house. Hire an external agency and keep the entire thing under cover. We will not make any official paperwork with them on email and payment will go directly from my personal accounts."

Aadi nodded. The more he was thinking, the more he was realizing the seriousness of the matter.

"Can you give us a movement, beta?" Shiv said looking at Kavya. "You can wait outside. Join us in ten minutes." She nodded and left the room.

"Aadi, we need to look at Kavya's security," Shiv said looking at his son.

Aadi nodded. "I have already hired undercover guards the day she discussed this with me. We went to the farmhouse on purpose. I wanted to check their efficiency and ensure no one is following her."

Shiv nodded. "This entire thing does not sound like good news to me."

"I know, dad. It's a matter of another ten-fifteen days before she digs out the entire thing."

Shiv had a different opinion but decided to keep quiet. He could sense that this is going to take longer. "What have you thought, what are you going to tell everyone, what Kavya is working on? We need to create a cover for her."

"I was thinking a new business venture… something apart from textile so that everyone will relax automatically."

"Okay, then, also tell people, I will be working with her. She will now sit in her cabin and work. Call her in."

Aadi called her on the mobile and she quickly came inside. They explained the plan to her.

Kavya got back to her cabin and started the laptop. She downloaded the latest stock data dump from the system and started comparing the numbers. In less than an hour, she saw numbers had been changed. Yesterday's inward was 6 tons. It was now changed to 4.2 tons. The rejection was kept constant. Rates were changed in the system. Original challan rates were 110/- per kg, they went up 250/- per kg. It was a straight difference of 1.8 Tons fabric + 3.9 Lakhs. This was big. She tried to search for the IP address from which the changes were done, but suddenly her laptop went off. She thought the battery was drained and checked, but it was running.

She called Aditya and told him. Both Aadi and Shiv came to her cabin with the IT head. Soon they all realized her hard disk had crashed. Kavya was almost in tears. She had worked a lot on the data. Aadi saw it and took her along with him in his cabin.

"How can my laptop crash? It was brand new."

"Relax, baby; we will recover the data."

"I am telling you, Aadi, someone has done it on purpose," Kavya said sobbing.

Aadi pulled her in his arms. "Hey, don't cry. Relax. We will find out who it is. Don't worry."

She wiped her face and nodded. "Sorry," she said.

"Don't say sorry, Kavya, it's not your fault."

Aditya was feeling very angry but decided to control his anger.

The IT head joined them in some time and told that the data cannot be recovered. It's all wiped out. Someone added some bug in the laptop.

Aditya called for records of cameras where Kavya's laptop was kept yesterday to see if anyone accessed it. But soon he

realized that footage of some 10 minutes had gone missing. '*This is going to be serious*,' Aadi thought.

Kavya told him her latest noting of the stock issue she had observed before the system collapsed.

Aditya looked at Shiv. Shiv realized what action he was planning to take and nodded. Aadi called Esha and told her today is a surprise stock take. He used to do this rarely but had done it a few times to keep control over inventory. This time he additionally informed that the production unit would also be closed and they will count the stock in the processing area as well. This was new, Esha wanted to argue, but stopped herself and followed the instruction.

The production manager came running to Aditya's cabin.

"Sir, we have an urgent order which needs to be dispatched today. We cannot afford to stop production right now."

"I will handle the client personally, but stock take has to happen now."

They left and everyone got back to work. Jatin usually led the stock take. Aditya went along and said, "I will be involved personally this time."

Jatin felt hurt. "Don't you trust me?"

Aadi smiled at him warmly and said, "Of course, I trust you. But I can't lose my habit of working, isn't it? Let's do it together today like the old days."

Jatin could not say 'no' to this and smiled back.

They did a routine stock take and matched it with the system stocks, everything matched. Aditya texted Kavya.

"Manu, all clear here…"

"Did we check WIP?" Kavya replied.

"Yep, all clear."

"Wait, let me come down."

She came to the shop floor. She looked into the records personally and thought of something.

"Aadi, please come along."

"Where?"

"Just come…"

She took him to the main gate and instructed the security, "Show me all vehicles' in and out challans."

The security guard got confused but handed over the book.

There were 3 vehicles that had gone out. She checked the records of the weight. There was a vendor vehicle which went back post-delivery but the weight was not done at the time of exit.

She took out all vehicle records and weighing records. There were 2 out of 26 vendors for which outward weights were "missed" multiple times. Kavya and Aadi dug all data and marked the vendor entries.

Aditya was getting constant calls from Esha as his next visitors were waiting in the conference room. Kavya looked at his phone and said, "Aadi, you please carry on. I will take it ahead from here."

Aadi left her there reluctantly and nodded. Kavya asked the security guys to deliver the files to her office, which she had marked and walked with Aditya inside the office.

She reached her cabin and got back to studying the details. It was almost evening when she saw Aadi sitting in front of her, with food.

"When did you come inside?"

"When my girl was busy in her work," Aadi said with a smile. "Keep it aside. Let's eat."

"Aadi…"

"Shhh… I am not asking, I am telling you."

She just gave out a sigh and nodded.

"So, where have you reached?"

"Two Vendors which we saw downstairs and three people from our company whom I am suspecting in this."

"Who are the three people?"

"I am sure of one name, not sure of the other two."

"Tell me more…"

"First is Mr. Gokhle… I got his bank statements and financials checked. In sixteen years, if he has earned X from us, Aadi, his current total wealth is nothing less than 10X. I got his

family background checked and could not find any reason for the sudden uplift of his standard of living in the last five years. Besides, I have pieces of evidence of frequent calls between him and vendors every time post-delivery. For a minute, let us assume it's about quality issues or something, but isn't it a huge coincidence that maximum calls are with these two vendors only, especially when the weights of the outward vehicles are 'missed'?"

"Hmmm…" Aadi nodded.

"Which are the other two names?"

"Jatin seems a clean chit, I am ruling out that possibility."

"Why?"

"Only reason to suspect him was IT access. I had installed change-log tracker in our software. His system's IP does not match to the one from where the changes have been done. Unless, of course, he is jumping the IP while doing changes. But again, I cannot find anything else which can push the doubt ahead."

"When did you do that and how?"

Kavya smiled, "Aadi, it's basic software, I guess you forgot, I worked in an IT company in the past."

Aadi smiled back. "Smart girl. So who do you think is doing all this?"

"Someone undercover, Aadi. Who has access to all this data and passwords but never came on our radar."

"And the third person?"

"Our raw material store supervisor – Mr. Das."

"All the marked vehicles have come only in his shift."

"Very well," Aadi said. We should take action against all of them and close the chapter now. I don't think we should invest further time on this.

"No Aadi, wait… we need to find out the third person before we officially declare anything to anyone."

"Kavya, if the base culprits are gone, what will the IT expert do? He won't have anything left to do."

"That's not the point, Aadi. You need to understand that our company's IT security is in wrong hands."

There was a long pause. "Are you sure about Jatin?"

"Positive," Kavya said.

"Alright, let's involve him in this."

Kavya nodded.

Aditya called Jatin and explained to him the entire thing. He was in a shock and was in pain to know his department was not doing well. Aditya asked him to change all system and software passwords without letting anyone know.

"But I will need time, Aditya, and I can't do it alone."

"We three can do it?" Kavya said promptly.

"Do you understand software's?" Jatin asked her.

"Not much, but I have preliminary knowledge. I can do what Aditya is asking us to do."

"That's great to know, but it still won't suffice. Our team is very big, we need at least six people."

"Let us call people from an external agent and put them to the task. But this has to be done in one go," Kavya said.

"I guess that should work. Let me ask Esha to set up a meeting right away with the vendor."

'Esha…' The name lingered in Kavya's head a bit longer.

Aadi nudged her, "What happened? Where are you lost?"

"What is Esha's educational background?"

"I can't remember, why?"

"Can I get her employee file?"

Aditya realized where she was going with this and looked at Jatin.

Jatin nodded and fetched her the employment data from the system. She was BSC IT and was the topper of her college. Also won an award for her project. This was followed by Masters in Administration.

"Jatin, is there any chance Esha has access to IT passwords?" Kavya asked.

Jatin's face turned red and he was extremely low already.

"What happened?" Kavya asked. Jatin looked at Aditya and Aadi understood.

"Will you both tell me?"

"I will explain that to you later, Kavya," Aditya said. "For now, understand that Esha had access to information."

"Then let's do one thing." Kavya laid out a plan in front of Jatin and Aditya. They both agreed and got back to work.

By around 10 pm, Kavya finished all her work and went to Aditya's cabin. He was on a call when she entered the room. He was standing at the window and looking out. It seemed like a serious discussion as his jawline was tensed as he spoke calculatedly. Kavya stood in front of him, relaxed to the core as they had sorted out the majority of the things. Aditya saw her and smiled. He walked towards her and kissed her forehead while continuing the call. Kavya hugged him in return. Aditya wound up the call and kept the phone in his pocket hugging her back. They stayed in arms for long. They heard the door knock and Kavya came out of Aadi's arms. Composing herself, Aadi smiled at her mischievously and stepped back.

"It was Esha, she had come to confirm Aditya's next day's meetings."

She looked a bit flustered. Both Aditya and Kavya knew why.

"Sir, I just wanted to confirm your appointment tomorrow with ACP Singh at eleven am and also with our IT partner vendor."

"That's right, Esha."

"All okay, sir? Why is Mr. Singh meeting our IT vendor?"

"That's none of your business, Esha." Aditya snapped back. Kavya held his hand and pressed it softly, signaling him to stay composed.

"We are planning to run a routine IT system investigation tomorrow, Esha, to ensure our IT infrastructure is safe. We observed a few unauthorized IP logins on sensitive data. So, it's better to be safe, isn't it?" Kavya said sweetly

"Of course, mam…" Esha said, composing herself back. "Excuse me, I have some urgent work to do." She almost ran out of the cabin, confirming the doubt of Kavya and Aditya.

Kavya looked at Aadi with a smile and he kissed her nose. "Love you…"

She went back in his arms.

"Come on, Mrs. Joshi, there is a small surprise waiting for you at home."

Kavya quickly looked up. "What?"

Aadi smiled. "Come, let's go."

Chapter 17

They reached home and Kavya saw her mom and sister in the living room to welcome her. She almost ran in her mother's arms. The moment she hugged her, she realized how much she missed them. Tears started flowing out of her eyes. Kavita started crying along, and watching them two cry, Sandhya also had watery eyes. Aditya went and pinched Sandhya with a grin and whispered in her ear, "Are you in a queue to hug her and cry?" Sandhya punched him back. "Don't laugh at me, I missed her."

Aadi moved swiftly missing her punch and teased her more. Sandhya ran behind him to hit him and everyone started laughing.

"Where are you lost Kavya? No call, no message…"

"Sorry mom, I was a bit occupied with work. You know, in the company…"

"Wait… don't get started yet. We have the full night to talk. You must be hungry, we all are waiting for dinner."

Kavya nodded. "Let me change and come back."

Kavya went upstairs with Aditya. She was almost jumping with excitement seeing her mom and sister. Aditya saw her and laughed.

"Manu, now I regret bringing not them here earlier. You look so happy and I love to see you like this."

Kavya just grinned. As soon as they entered the bedroom, Kavya closed the door and pushed Aadi to the wall. Aditya was taken aback. "Manu, what are you…"

Before he could say anything further, Kavya held his head with both her hands and kissed him hard. They got off when Kavya was almost breathless.

She looked into his eyes and hugged him, smiling ear to ear. "I love you…" She whispered.

"I love you too, Manu."

"Thank you for this surprise. In the work, I did not realize I was ignoring them so much."

"I was in touch almost every day, Manu."

"Oh!" This was news to Kavya. "Why you never reminded me or told me about it?"

Aditya smiled. "Do I ever remind you to greet my parents before leaving the house… or spending time with them? You do it naturally, baby. Similarly, now Mom and Sandhya are my family. I will take care of them naturally."

Kavya had tears in her eyes. She just hugged him back.

"Hey, don't cry baby."

She wiped her eyes and nodded.

"By the way, I must remind you something."

"What?" she asked.

"Tomorrow is your mom's birthday."

"Oh! Oh shit! I forgot… I am so bad with dates," Kavya said and Aadi laughed.

"Don't worry, I have already arranged a surprise for her."

"What?"

"Well, we will finish our meeting with the ACP tomorrow morning and then go to Mumbai with mom."

"For?" Kavya asked, getting confused.

"While you have been occupied with work here, I was working on setting up Mom's catering business. She just needed a proper marketing team. So, I had set up a backend team for it. Now that there is enough business on the platter, we will open her office tomorrow."

"Aadi, but she is not geared up for this."

"Relax Baby, I have put my whole team there. They will run the business. Mom just needs to look at the recipes and ensure quality. Rest everything is taken care of."

Kavya was stunned. "When did you do all these things?"

Aadi smiled. "Magic…" he said winking.

Kavya again had tears in her eyes. "I can't thank you enough for this, Aadi."

"Well, another night like yesterday will be more than thank you for me," Aadi said in a low voice and Kavya covered her face in her hands, hiding herself in his chest.

Aadi laughed. "Come on, let's go down, everyone must be wondering where are we lost?"

They went down for dinner and Sandhya cleared her throat, "Hmmm… finally, love birds are here. Di, you never took so long to change before marriage."

Kavya went shy and looked down. Rashmi and Shiv Laughed. Kavita pushed Sandhya with legs hinting her to keep quiet.

Kavya sat next to her mom and Aditya sat in front of her. They all started discussing the closed office issue and explained everything in length to the family members.

Your daughter is a real gem, Kavita." Shiv said.

Kavita was overwhelmed seeing her daughter so happy in her life. She just nodded and got back to eating.

Aditya was mischievously grinning while they all had dinner. Kavya asked him with her eyes, "What happened?"

He kept the spoon down and pointed a finger below his right ear, hinting her that there is a visible love-bite "

Kavya got scared and started pulling her dupatta up, looking at Aadi… but it was not covering the mark which made him grin more. Kavya got irritated at him and hit his leg below the table.

"Ouch!" Aadi said loudly.

"What happened?" everyone asked him.

'Nothing, the food is very hot," he said.

Everyone understood but just smiled and let go of the topic.

Post dinner, everyone went back to sleep. Kavya went to her room with Mom and Sandhya. Aditya made a puppy face asking her to come to sleep with him.

"I want to spend some time with them."

"Then I will also come," and Kavya laughed. "Okay, come…"

"Let us talk to them for some time and then you come with me."

They both did not realize, Sandhya was just behind the door. She quickly came out and hugged Kavya from behind.

"Jiju, Come on, you guys are married for more than a month now. Let me have my sister all by myself tonight."

Kavya turned shy as she teased them. Aadi pulled her ear and said, "Okay, but just one night."

"Yeah, yeah," she said and they all laughed.

Kavya rested her head in Kavita's lap and spoke almost half the night. She did not realize when she fell asleep while talking. Kavita smiled looking at her daughter and slept beside her.

Aditya came to their room early morning the next day. Kavita and Sandhya had gotten up long back. Kavya was sleeping peacefully. He was too tempted to wake up Kavya, but she needed rest. Aditya decided to go down and joined everyone for breakfast.

"Mom, we all are coming to Mumbai with you today," Aditya said.

Kavita got confused. We can manage, it's not a problem."

"No, no," Rashmi said, "we have not been to our Mumbai house since marriage, so we thought of going there; nothing else."

Kavita got convinced with that and nodded. Sandhya already knew the plan. She was part of the whole planning, so she smiled knowingly at Aditya who smiled back at her. "Aditya, I really want to thank you for all your support in my business. I would never be able to bring it to this scale without…"

"Please mom, you are embarrassing me. I have done nothing. Your hands have the magic. I travel the world and have had food in the finest restaurants, but very few can match your

culinary skills. You just needed administrative handholding, which I did."

Kavita nodded, getting chocked with emotions. Aditya realized it and got up from the chair hugging her from behind just the way Kavya used to do. "Relaxxxxx…" he said and Kavita laughed. "I wish Kavya's father was alive today, he would have been so happy to meet Aditya."

Both Shiv and Rashmi got nostalgic remembering Kavya's father.

"He is here with us and he is seeing you cry right now," Aditya said.

Kavita smiled wiping her tears and nodded. "Where is Kavya?"

"She is sleeping."

"Oh!" Kavita felt embarrassed that her daughter gets up so late and made a mental note to lecture her on the way to Mumbai about getting up early.

Rashmi realized it and said, "I am glad to see her relaxed. She is so engrossed in the work, she barely gives time to herself. Let her sleep. No one will wake her up today. We will leave once she is ready."

"Yes, mam," Aditya said and everyone laughed.

Kavya got up at around 8 am and realized there was no one around. '*I am late again*.' Kavya thought and almost jumped out of the bed as she saw her watch.

She directly took a shower and wore a peach-colored sari with a matching, sleeveless blouse. She let her hair down today and applied light makeup.

Kavya came down almost running. Everyone had finished their breakfast and were sitting in the living room. They saw her and started laughing.

Kavya touched everyone's feet and hugged mom wishing her for her birthday.

"Sorry, I am late. I overslept," Kavya said feeling embarrassed.

"It's no problem, beta, it's not that late. Just eight-thirty am. What would you like to eat?" Shiv asked.

"I am not hungry actually…"

"Nonsense!" Shiv called one of the servants and instructed to bring breakfast for Kavya. Kavya sat between Sandhya and Aditya. Sandhya whispered in Kavya's ear, "I can understand you got up late. I heard… the day before you guys were at the farmhouse; must've been a hectic trip."

Kavya turned red at the mention of the farmhouse trip and looked the other way. Sandhya laughed.

"What happened Sandhya?" Rashmi asked.

Kavya got scared that she might tease her openly and pushed her leg hinting her to keep quiet. Sandhya ignored it and said, "I was just asking di if she is this tired regularly or these are the after-effects of the farmhouse celebrations."

Everyone laughed and Aadi gave a mischievous grin to Kavya. Kavya turned shy but tried her best to hide it. "It's nothing like that… work has been a bit hectic, but it's fine now."

Aadi raised his eyebrow and whispered in her ear, "Smart save…"

"I will have breakfast and come back," Kavya said getting up.

Kavya and Aadi quickly got ready and went for the meeting with the ACP, meanwhile everyone got ready and packed up for Mumbai.

After the meeting, they all headed to Mumbai and Kavya opened her laptop again. Aditya swiftly picked it up and kept it in the bag.

"But Aadi…"

"Nothing doing, Kavya, you have finished your project just now and you need a break. I am not allowing you to work today."

"Hmmm," she nodded with a pout. Aditya smiled looking at her and played songs.

When the cars missed the regular turn, Kavita called Kavya.

"Kavya, we are going in the wrong direction, our house is to the left."

"There is a surprise for you, mom. We are going somewhere else," Kavya said.

"What now? Aditya is already doing so much for us. I hope it's nothing expensive…"

"Relax, Mom… we will reach in a minute."

The cars stopped outside a commercial complex. There was a board at one of the offices with the name Kavita's Kitchen. It was her corporate office. The kitchen was on the backside.

They all got down. Aditya told her the whole plan and Kavita landed in tears. She was too overwhelmed to say anything. All she managed was thank you.

Rashmi came and hugged her. Everyone was silent but knew it was a very big moment for them. Rashmi helped Kavita calm down and they had an opening ceremony shortly after. Kavya was missing her dad a lot. Aadi realized it and was by her side throughout the day.

In the evening, Kavya said her goodbyes to Mom and Sandhya and came back with Aditya and his family.

Kavya came in Aditya's car while Rashmi and Shiv came by the other car. While walking towards the cars, Kavya whispered in Aadi's ear, "Can we go without the driver today?" Aadi looked at her and raised her eyebrows. She gave him a mischievous grin as if she had a plan. Aadi grinned back at her, "Okay."

He went and spoke to the driver and the driver got down on the way and Aadi took over driving.

"So, Mrs. Joshi. Why this special request?"

"Just…" she said, raising her shoulders giving him a grin. "Last time you had teased me by restraining my hands. Now, you will be occupied driving, maybe I can try and tease you a bit," she said, running her fingers through his ear.

"Don't mess, baby, it's a short drive of two hours. Then will be the payback time."

"Two hours is a very long time," she said, running her nails around his shirt's collar.

Aadi took a deep breath. "Kavya…" he said.

"Umhmm…" she said.

Aadi parked the car at side and pulled her in a kiss. "God, girl! You will turn me into an animal soon," and Kavya laughed.

They had dinner on the way and reached home late. Kavya sat with Shiv and Rashmi in the living room chatting with them about the day's event. Aadi was getting desperate to take her upstairs, but she purposely chose to sit back a bit longer. Aditya was realizing it and decided to sit with her.

Kavya got confused and said goodbye and went upstairs while Aadi still stayed back a bit longer in the living room. He came upstairs and saw Kavya sitting in front of the dressing table…

"You took time," she said raising eyebrows.

"Why… you missed me?"

She just smiled. "I thought you missed me."

"Is it?" Aadi said, slowly opening his shirt and walked towards her. Kavya stepped back slowly.

"Don't tease me more, baby, come here…"

She nodded 'no' with a naughty smile.

"Let's see how far you can go." Aditya switched off the lights.

"Aadi…"

"Shh…" He said holding her, "I am here, baby."

He tickled her waist and she started giggling. "What are you doing?"

"Teasing you back, baby," Aadi said.

"Don't!"

Right then they heard a knock on the door.

"Aadi, let me…"

Aadi stepped back giving her space to let her go and open the door. She quickly went to the door and opened it, adjusting her dress. It was Rashmi. She felt shy as she was adjusting her dress.

"Yes, mummy," she said looking down.

"You forgot your phone downstairs, beta…"

"Oh, thank you!"

"My pleasure. Please carry on," she said with a wink.

"Mom…" Kavya said and Rashmi laughed.

Kavya got up early the next morning and got ready for work. Shiv and Aditya were already at the dining table.

"So, what is the strategy today?" Shiv asked Kavya.

"I still feel dad, they should get one chance to put forward their point. I have done the investigation, we will show them the results. Let there be a neutral panelist in this discussion as an observer who will directly report back to you."

"True…" Aditya said. "What do you think dad?"

"I have a different opinion here," Shiv said. "Kavya, I want you to understand a few things here. How much ever right you are, these are very old employees and have worked with me for long. I would not want them to go hanging their head low. Let them go with dignity. I will talk to them one-on-one and ask them to resign."

"Dad, that's not fair… we need to expose them. Let their exit be an example to all other employees. No one else would dare to do this next time."

"Aadi, I think I will agree with dad here. We want to get rid of them for sure, but what's the fun of spoiling their career. Let them learn their lesson and get a fair chance to correct their mistakes."

"Kavya but…"

"Aadi…" Shiv stopped him. "Let us not argue. I think my decision is final here. I am not discussing it any further. Let us finish breakfast and go to the office. Kavya, hand over the file to me, I will take it ahead from here."

"Okay, dad," Kavya said.

"Sorry, dad. I didn't mean to argue," Aditya said.

"I know, son," Shiv said patting his hand softly. Aditya smiled.

"Dad, you will have to take Esha's system log from Jatin. That's the last proof pending in the file."

Shiv smiled, "Aditya told me what you guys did. Great job, beta."

"Thank you, dad," Kavya said.

As they got into the car to go to the office, Kavya asked Aditya, "Aadi… what am I going to do now? My project is over."

Aadi smiled. "You know what, you are like that monster who constantly needs work."

Kavya giggled. "I can't help it. I cannot sit empty."

"Hmmm…" Aadi said with a grin.

"You know what, when we first met, you were shy, used to talk very less. Now you are bold and carefree. I love this transition of yours."

"It's all thanks to you, Aadi," she said blowing a kiss to him.

Aadi raised his eyebrows and chuckled. "Miss insatiable…" and Kavya giggled again.

"Don't change the topic, Aadi. Tell me what I am going to do ahead?"

"Do you remember that brand you mentioned for the masses?"

"Yes, yellow. That's still one of my favorite brands. What about that?"

"Well, we bought that company. You will now run that line of business independently."

"What?" Kavya said feeling shocked. "When did you do that, Aadi?"

Aadi just smiled.

"Aadi, you can't be serious! I am not ready to run the company yet."

"Of course you are. Dad and I were suspecting you will take at least three months to learn the business. Yet, here you are… it's just been one month and you are all geared up to take the charge."

"Aadi, executing your vision is different; having my own vision is very different. I can execute… I know I am good at that, but I am still not ready to be a visionary."

Aadi kept quiet. She had a point. No matter how fantastic she was at work, she was yet to develop the vision.

"We will see how to go about it. Don't worry. Do you trust me, Manu?"

"Of course I trust you, Aadi, more than I trust myself."

"Then leave it to me."

"Hmmm…" she nodded.

Aditya had called the new company's management team and introduced Kavya to them. There was a formal presentation on the company's current statistics, information about the core team, future business and expansion plans, current business strategies, SWOT analysis and much more. The entire first half of the day went in the presentation until Aditya called for a lunch break.

During lunch, Aadi asked her, "How do you find it, baby?"

"It's fantastic. How do you want to go about it?"

"It's your company baby."

"We discussed this, Aadi. I am not ready yet. I need guidance. In fact, I have something in my mind about my role."

"What?"

"Can I be your Executive Assistant? That way I will be involved in both the companies and will execute your vision. Esha must have left by now, you anyways need another EA. In fact, we can keep a separate PA for you for scheduling your meetings and other routine work. I will focus more on the execution side. What you think?"

Aadi smiled. He liked the idea. "Done," he said and Kavya gave him hi-five.

By 4 pm, they wound up the remaining discussion. Aadi chalked out a basic launch plan and asked Kavya to work on it ahead. Shiv joined them for the closure discussion. He looked very tired and Kavya got worried.

"What happened, dad? You don't look well," Kavya said.

"I am fine… it's just that all these exits' stressed me out."

"Oh, it's done?"

"Yeah, Esha is preparing her handover."

"Aadi…" Should I go and take the handover?" Kavya asked.

Aadi nodded. "I will brief you about closing later. You can go ahead and take the charge from her."

"Okay," she said.

"Dad, please don't worry, everything is going to be fine."

Shiv nodded and Kavya looked at Aadi. Aadi gave her a reassuring nod and she walked out to take the handover.

She called Esha to her cabin. "Yes Esha, how do we go about it?"

"These are the keys, these are the papers and appointment diary. That's it. I don't have anything else to handover,' Esha said fuming with anger.

"Don't make things difficult for me and for yourself, Esha. It won't be good," Kavya said trying to keep herself composed. "We both know what has happened. You should be thankful to dad that he still decided to give you a clean exit."

"Yes, everything was going fine… And then you came… in Aadi's life…"

"Mind your tongue, Esha; you are talking about the MD of the company and his name is Mr. Aditya Joshi."

"He was mine…" Esha hissed. "I always loved him… And you stole him from me."

Kavya was taken aback. '*Calm down, Kavya… keep calm,*' she kept telling herself.

"All the more you should not have damaged his company, Esha. Records clearly show you are doing this since way before I came in Aditya's life. Your statements do not justify anything."

"That's because he never loved me." Esha landed in tears. "It was my way to take revenge on him." Esha collapsed as she spoke and Kavya went to hold her. She made Esha sit in the chair. "We cannot help whom we fall for, Esha. God will have some other plans for you. I am sure about it."

"I don't live life on compromises. I want what I like," Esha said taking a knife out of her bag. Kavya saw it and backed off quickly before she could hurt her. "These things do not scare me, Esha, I have lived a very different and tough life." In one swift move, she held Esha's hand and twisted it. The knife fell on the floor and Kavya gave her one tight slap.

"Get up," Kavya said with a raised voice. Esha got scared and got up. Kavya rang the bell and the office boy entered the room.

"Call the security team and escort this lady out of the office right now," Kavya instructed the office boy without losing eye contact with Esha.

"Yes, mam."

"Wait… pick up this knife from the floor," Kavya said.

He realized what had happened and quickly picked up the knife and walked out.

In about a minute, guards came to pick up Esha.

"I will make you pay for this, Kavya…" Esha said before leaving the cabin.

Kavya chose not to react to it. She needed Aditya right now.

By now Aditya had got the news of what happened. He left the meeting and almost started running towards Kavya's cabin. He saw Kavya walking towards him. Kavya went in his arms running.

"Shh… baby, calm down… I am here. Nothing is going to happen to you."

To her own surprise, the moment she hugged Aadi, she landed in tears.

Aadi held her tightly. She was shivering. He tried his best to calm her down.

Kavya kept sobbing in his arms when someone brought a glass of water. Aadi pulled her out of his arms to offer her water. That's when she realized they were in the middle of the office like this. She felt embarrassed and tried stepping back. Aadi held her close, "It's okay, baby. Here… have some water."

Kavya had water and wiped her face. From within, she was still shaken a bit. Aadi held her hand and directly marched in his cabin.

They reached inside the cabin and Aadi pulled her back in his arms. He let the tears flow from his eyes. "Sorry baby, I should have been more careful. I should have anticipated this." He kept kissing Kavya's face while apologizing.

"Don't say sorry, Aadi. It was not your fault, I was just scared. I am fine now. Everything is fine."

They both calmed down in some time and sat across table silently digesting everything that happened.

"Aadi…"

"Hmmm…" he said

"Esha told me she loved you."

Aadi ran his hand through his hair. "I know that."

This came as a shock to her. "You knew?"

"She had proposed a few years back, Kavya, but I always loved you. I could never date any girl. I told her a flat 'no'. In fact, I was on the verge of sacking her at that time. But she begged me to keep her job and promised me to stay professional. So I never told anything to anyone."

"That explains…" Kavya said, thinking. "She said she did all this to take revenge on you."

"Now I feel stupid for trusting her, Kavya," Aadi said feeling sad.

"It takes a lot of courage to have a soft heart in this cruel world, Aadi. I am proud of you that you still managed to keep it that way."

Aadi did not say anything.

"Don't blame yourself Aadi."

Aadi looked at her. She realized he was feeling guilty so she got up and went to his side of the table. She sat on his lap and hugged him.

"You are a good man, Aadi and you did not do anything wrong."

"Today she tried to…"

"Shh… It's past. I am a strong girl. It was in the heat of the moment and it's gone."

Aadi hugged her back. Tears started falling from his eyes once again.

"Shh… Calm down, Aadi. Please don't cry." Watching him cry, Kavya landed in tears. "I love you," she said.

"I love you too, Kavya"

They both sat in each other's arms for long.

"I still don't understand one thing, Aadi," Kavya asked

"What?"

"How come she got the passwords from Jatin?"

"She dated Jatin," Aditya said simply.

"What?" Kavya looked at Aadi shocked.

"Jatin is smart, good looking, and extremely well to do for his age, Kavya. Of course he has had his share of women, but he never ever dated anyone from office in the past. We had a bad fight yesterday after you left my cabin, on this."

"Hmmm… This explains again. This was clearly to take revenge. She could not do anything to you coz she loved you. So she took a dig on your company and corrupted your right-hand man. Two things which will hurt you the most."

"And she tried to hurt you. I am going to give her a taste of her own blood," Aadi said, feeling furious from within.

"Don't waste your time on negativity, Aadi. We have so many productive things to do in life. Let us focus on the positive side of life."

Aadi nodded and kissed her softly. She held his head and kissed him back, almost as if she was hungry for him. She needed him. The feeling that he is hers… They broke the kiss when they heard the door knock. Kavya hurriedly got up from his lap and stood beside him. It was Shiv.

Kavya saw him and ran in his arms.

"I got to know everything that happened, beta. You are a brave girl."

Kavya nodded wiping her tears while coming out of Shiv's arms. Shiv looked at Aditya and Aadi nodded.

"We are heading home now, dad."

"Good thought," Shiv said. "Go on. I need to finish a few things before I come home."

Kavya and Aadi drove back home in silence. "I don't like to see you sad, baby," Aadi said, kissing her fingers.

"I am not sad, Aadi, I am thinking. Esha, by all means, was an extremely talented girl. How she must be feeling today? I was fortunate that the guy whom I loved, loved me back. But it must be so devastating to see whom you love does not love you back. I feel for her. If I was her… I would have probably ended my life. I can't even think of you with someone else."

Aadi pulled the car aside on the road. "Don't ever… ever… talk to me on the lines of ending your life," Aadi said feeling furious.

"Relax, Aadi, I was just…"

"No Kavya… what I feel for you scares me sometimes. I am still struggling to cope up with what happened in the office today. Don't you dare talk anything like this again…"

"I am sorry, Aadi," Kavya said quietly. "I am not going anywhere."

Aadi ran his hands through his hair and pulled the car back on the road. They reached home and Aditya directly went upstairs to his room. Rashmi saw that and realized there was something wrong. She looked at Kavya.

"What happened?"

"Come here, mom, sit with me. It's a long story."

She explained everything to Rashmi and tears started dripping from Rashmi's eyes.

"I am fine mom, please don't cry." She hugged her and calmed her down.

"I need to go and see Aadi, mom. He is very upset."

Rashmi nodded. "Go freshen up. Let us have early dinner tonight."

Kavya went upstairs and opened the room. Aditya was smoking in the room. She knew he smoked, but it was very rare.

She went straight in his arms and he hugged her back.

"Manu…"

"Hmmm…"

"I love you."

"I love you too, Aadi, and I am here… with you… in front of you. Nothing will happen to me till you are by my side."

Tears started dripping his eyes.

"Aadi, I have never seen you so vulnerable. What's wrong? Is there anything more you want to tell me?"

"I am feeling guilty, Kavya."

"Guilty for what?"

"She came behind you because of me."

"Aadi come on. You can't be serious. Why will you feel guilty about this? I know you, dear, not even in your dreams

you would have encouraged her. You are so lovable; of course, she fell for you. I don't blame her either for falling for you. What happened was sad, but it's over now. Get over with it."

Aadi nodded.

"What can I do to cheer my man up?" Kavya said pouting and Aadi smiled.

"Just never leave my side, baby."

"Never," she said, getting into his arms.

They both came down for dinner. Everyone was hassled up with what happened and had a quiet dinner. Finally, Shiv broke the silence.

"Aadi… when are you planning your USA campaign? We had parked it for your marriage, but I guess it's time we reopen it."

"Yes, dad. I was planning to travel by the end of this month."

"Good. Take Kavya along," Shiv said.

"Yes dad, her visa documents are already in process."

Kavya pushed Aadi a bit and whispered slowly. "When did all this happen?"

"It's a work-tour, Kavya," Aadi said.

She just nodded and got back to eating.

Post dinner, Rashmi said "Aditya, Shiv… see me in the study room. Beta, Aadi will join you upstairs in ten minutes."

Kavya got confused and looked at Aadi who just nodded and asked her to go upstairs.

Rashmi was furious. "How can you both be so irresponsible? You should have anticipated something like this would happen. What if Kavya was hurt today?"

"Sorry Mom, I was occupied in a meeting with dad. She just went to take the handover. It just skipped my mind that something can turn this nasty."

"Not done, both of you. I am really not happy with this. This is the last time this has happened. I will not tolerate any such things in the future."

Aadi nodded. Rashmi went out of the room.

Aadi looked at his father.

"Relax, son. She will come around. I know how to calm her down. Have made a few arrangements. We will be going out for a few days tomorrow."

"Okay, dad. What time are you leaving?"

"We will be going early morning tomorrow. Tomorrow is Sunday, so you both also take rest and start working with a fresh mind on Monday."

"Okay, dad, happy journey and all the best." Shiv laughed. "Yeah, looking at her mood right now… I need best wishes."

Chapter 18

Aadi went upstairs. Kavya was already asleep; she was tired. Aadi went directly in her arms and slept by her side.

Kavya got up next day morning feeling warm as Aadi was wrapped around her and she smiled. '*Will I ever get used to seeing him*,' she thought and hugged him back, running fingers through his hair. Aadi smiled. He ran a finger on her back and she moaned.

"Your body responds so easily to my touch," Aadi said looking at her and she felt shy again.

Aadi slowly slipped his hand in her shirt feeling her warmth and Kavya tried getting out of bed.

"Aadi… its morning time!" Kavya said pushing him away. "Mom dad must be waiting for us for breakfast."

"They went early morning today on a holiday, baby. It's only us in the house."

"Oh!" Kavya said pouting. "I was not aware. I would have gotten up to say goodbye."

"Haha… lazybones, you… and getting up early?"

"Oh please… I can get up if I want to, okay?"

"Yeah right," Aadi said. "But right now, you don't need to," Aadi said pulling her back to the bed.

"Aadi… its bright daylight right now, what are you doing?"

"Oh! My girl turning shy… that's a feast!" Aadi said, pulling her in his arms.

"Aadi, please… Someone will come now."

"No one will come, baby," Aadi said kissing her neck.

"You are driving me crazy," Kavya said closing her eyes.

"I fully intend to, Manu." He slowly started opening her shirt, kissing her as he opened each button. She moaned and pulled his face to kiss him. Aadi sat and took her in his lap. She sat wrapping her legs around his waist; he opened her shirt and removed it. Kavya felt shy and tried pulling the cover. Aadi pushed it back. "No, baby, let me see you," Aadi said and removed his t-shirt.

Aadi pulled her back in arms and kissed her hard. As she got engrossed in him, he opened her hook freeing her bosom. She tried breaking the kiss to cover herself but could not get through his hold. He pushed her to the bed and laid down by her side lazily feeling her body. Kavya tried pulling the duvet, but Aadi threw it on the floor. I want to see you, baby. He pushed his hand in her pajamas and she arched back as he touched her.

"I love the way you respond to my touch, baby," Aadi said, pulling her nipple with his teeth. "Aadi…" she said, pulling his face towards her. He slowly slid a finger inside her and started kissing her neck. He removed her clothes and went down on her. After sucking her hard when he realized she was close, he removed his clothes and took her fully. Kavya was moaning loudly along with Aadi when they finally came together. Aadi collapsed on her, breathless.

She kept kissing his shoulders and running her hand on his back. "I love you, Aadi," she said.

"I love you too, princess."

He finally moved and slept beside her. Kavya suddenly felt exposed as he moved and went back to his arms. Aadi laughed. "I love it when you turn shy, baby. Your cheeks turn pink."

"Don't tease me," she said.

"You look beautiful, Manu. I love watching you," he said running his hand through her body.

"Don't tempt me again."

"God, lady! Are you ready again? Give me a break." And Kavya giggled. "I can't help it, you are too sexy."

"Really?" Aadi said raising his eyebrows. She quickly moved up and kissed him on his lips. "Really…" she said.

They came out of the bed almost by brunch time and decided to have it in the bedroom today. The maid served all the food and went. They discussed business plans ahead about the new company and the current status of many projects as Kavya now had to take charge of the work.

Next day in office, Kavya took charge of all the work and made a charter of all the projects along with the timelines. She created internal project teams with clear responsibilities for each project. The team was very happy the way she was handling the work and was all geared up to work under her guidance. For the whole week, she prioritized the projects judging the potentials on various parameters and created a brief report on strategy for execution. Shiv was going to come back the next day so she had kept a meeting at eleven AM with Aadi, Shiv, and the key stakeholders of the project.

Kavya came home with Aadi. Rashmi and Shiv were already home. She directly went to Rashmi's arms and hugged her hard.

"Oh! Seems like you missed me, beta."

"Of course, I missed you, mom! How was your trip?"

"It was fantastic. Rashmi sat with everyone and told them all the stories from their holiday. They all decided to step out for dinner so Kavya and Aadi went upstairs to get ready.

Kavya chose a little black dress for the evening. She was about to change when Aadi came out of the bathroom. "Aadi… go inside, I am changing."

Aadi laughed. "What's the big deal? You can change in front of me."

"I feel shy… Go in."

"No baby," he said. "It's too tempting a sight to miss." She went and started pushing him inside and he laughed "Okay, okay. I am going."

As she changed, she felt a small cramp in her stomach. She winced and sat down on the sofa.

"What happened?" Aadi asked.

"Nothing, Aadi, just got a cramp."

"Are you sure? Did you eat anything wrong today?"

"Maybe, I don't know…" she quickly changed the topic. "Leave it, how do I look?" She asked.

"You look delicious," Aadi said, walking towards her.

Kavya giggled… "Really? Delicious desert or delicious spicy dish?"

"Mrs. Joshi… you look spicy hot to me today in this black dress."

Kavya was walking backward in the room and started running as she saw Aadi pacing up the speed. Aadi ran behind her. She climbed the bed and jumped on it. Aadi started laughing and joined her. Kavya pushed him down and started hitting him with a pillow. Aadi started hitting her back. They both were standing on the bed, fighting when Shiv and Rashmi entered the room to call them for dinner.

Kavya saw them and immediately threw the pillow. She straightened her dress and got down from the bed. "Sorry mummy," she said, "but he started hitting me first," Kavya said as if complaining about Aadi.

"Mom, she is such a liar… she hit me first!" Aadi said.

Shiv and Rashmi burst out laughing. Well, you both seem to have plans for the evening. "Are you sure you want to come along with us?"

By now Kavya had turned bright red. She looked down and said, "Of course, let me just grab my purse." She quickly moved away and joined them with her purse. Aadi was looking at her amused but she avoided looking at him the whole evening.

As they settled at the dinner table, Aadi placed his hand on her lap. She swiftly moved it away and Aadi smiled more. He slowly pulled her dress up and ran his fingers on her thighs and she gasped. He whispered in her ear, "I love this dress. There are so many advantages." Kavya's face was fully flushed.

She whispered back in a low voice, "Aadi, please. I can't think straight when you do such things. We are with mom dad."

"Alright, what do I get in return for stopping?"

"What you want?" she asked.

"Nothing much, just have some wine tonight. I remember some awesome time in the past when you had wine."

Kavya blushed hard on his comment.

Rashmi finally cleared her throat and teased them playfully. "You both have been looking at the menu and discussing it since long. I hope you have been discussing your order. Have you decided your order yet?"

"Yes mom," Aadi said and placed an order for 4 glasses of Rose wine.

"How is work going on? Did you hear the news afterward about Esha or any of them?"

"Not really, dad," Aadi said, "and honestly I don't care if they don't do well in their careers ahead. I don't know about you, but if I get their background check calls, it's not going to go positive for sure."

"It's not about caring, beta. It's about protection. They have left the company with hurt. Corrupt people have a tendency to bite back. We must keep a tab on their whereabouts and ensure our companies safety."

Aditya nodded. "You are right, dad. I will get the information tomorrow."

"Esha had threatened me while leaving that she will make me pay for this," Kavya said casually while eating. This got the attention of both Aditya and Shiv.

"What?" Aadi said. "You did not tell me about this before."

"She was angry Aadi, she just said it out of anger. She didn't really mean it."

"Still, I would have been more careful. You should have told me this earlier, Manu."

"I am sorry," Kavya said ducking her head down.

Seeing Kavya feeling guilty, Rashmi entered the conversation. "Don't intimidate her, Aadi. You are used to handling such

things, she is not. She was scared at that time. It must have skipped her mind."

"You are right, mom."

"Enough of work talks," Shiv said. "Let me show you some photos of our holiday." Shiv started showing photos on the Tab and shared their experiences.

They reached home late. Kavya felt a slight pain again a couple of times but did not mention it to Aadi. She came back to the room and while checking her phone, she realized her periods were delayed.

Kavya lost the color of her face completely with the thought and sat at the corner of the bed.

"What happened, Manu… are you okay?"

"Yaa, I am fine," she said. "Just light-headed by the drinks maybe."

"Oh really?" Aadi said with a mischievous grin.

"Aadi, if you don't mind… can I sleep early? I am not feeling very well."

"Hey…" Aadi sat next to her and took her face in his hand. "What happened, baby… are you okay?"

"I am fine, Aadi, just feeling a bit sleepy and tired."

"Okay… but you sure there is nothing else right?"

She just nodded looking down.

"Baby… look at me. What's wrong? You were so happy the entire evening. Now, suddenly, you seem off."

She hugged Aadi tightly and started crying.

"Hey, what happened? Tell me, please. What's bugging you so much? Are mom and Sandhya okay?"

"They are fine…"

"Then what happened? Did I do something wrong?"

She just nodded 'no' in his chest.

Aadi almost forcefully pulled her out of his embrace and held her face in his hand.

"Kavya, you are killing me, tell me what happened."

"I don't know how to tell you," she said sobbing.

"You don't need to think while talking to me."

"You will be angry at me, I know…"

"I can never be angry at you, Kavya. Now stop this and tell me what happened…"

She went in his arms again and said, "My periods are delayed and I don't know why. They are never late."

Aadi pulled her out of his embrace and held her with both hands.

"Kavya, look at me."

She nodded 'no'.

He held her chin and raised her face to make her look at him. "I will be the happiest man on this earth if you are pregnant right now, baby. Just the thought of having a small Kavya in my arms, makes my heart swell."

She landed in tears again. "But we decided on giving time to each other before planning a kid."

"Kavya, we will grow together with the kid. There cannot be better timing than God's chosen timing. And why do you think I will be mad at you? It's my child! Stupid girl… it's probably time for celebration."

Kavya turned shy at the thought and looked down. "It might be nothing," she said.

"I agree," he said. "So, let's not jump to conclusions right now. If you are pregnant, great. If no, chill; we have the whole life ahead… Unless… you want me to get you pregnant right now. I don't mind actually." He winked.

"Aadi…" she said looking down. She felt better after talking to him. "We will go to the doctor tomorrow morning, baby. Then we will go to the office. Let us not tell anything to mom dad right now. Don't want them to worry."

Kavya just nodded.

"Are you okay now, baby?" Aadi asked.

"You are really not disappointed with the news?"

"Are you mad? I am just holding back my emotions on the chances of being a father. There cannot be anything more beautiful than having a family with you, Kavya. Tell me, how are you feeling?"

"I don't know, I am very nervous. I don't know if I am ready yet."

"I guess no one is hundred percent ready for these things, Kavya. We will learn when we walk the path. As far as we are walking it together, it's the best journey of life for me."

"You make things sound so easy, Aadi," Kavya said, holding his hands. "Thank you for being there for me." She slowly kissed his hand and Aadi's eyes turned dark.

"Come here… let me make love to my wife. God knows, she might be bearing my child and the doc will stop me from doing this in a few months," Aadi said with a mischievous grin.

Kavya turned shy and tried walking away from the bed at the thought when Aadi pulled her in his embrace.

They both got up early the next day. Kavya was getting ready while Aadi went for a shower. She saw herself in the mirror and ran her hands on her stomach, thinking if she was pregnant. '*How will it be to have a small Aditya in her arms*,' she thought. When she was fully engrossed in her thoughts, Aadi came out of the bathroom and saw her. He stood at the door and whistled. "Wow…"

Kavya turned shy and went back to pick her purse. "I am waiting for you downstairs. Come soon," she said. Aadi quickly walked towards her and held her back.

"Not so quickly, baby," and he kissed her neck.

"Aadi, what are you doing?"

"You smell so good, baby," he sucked her earlobe slowly.

"We will be late. We have doctor's appointment in some time," she said looking down.

"Hey…. Are you nervous, baby?"

She nodded 'yes'.

"Don't be… I am there for you. What can I do to make you feel better right now?"

She just smiled and quickly kissed him on lips. "You don't need to do anything, Aadi. You being around is enough for me."

"Now you are tempting me too much," he said kissing her hard until she almost pushed him away. "Come down soon, Aadi, I am waiting."

Aadi blew her a flying kiss and she turned shy again.

Kavya went down for breakfast. Shiv had gone to the office early as he was going after a break. Rashmi joined her. "You are ready very early today." Kavya just nodded. "Have some work, mom."

"You always have work, do you realize, you have not a taken single day's leave since you joined?"

"I know mom, I will take a day off soon. I promise."

Rashmi smiled fondly. Aditya joined them shortly after and quickly finished breakfast.

"Why are you both in so much hurry today? Some critical meeting?"

"Yes mom, I will brief you later. Shall we go, Kavya?" Kavya nodded. She touched Rashmi's feet and left with Aadi.

Aadi had pre-booked an appointment with a gynecologist so they directly went to the doctor's cabin. Kavya explained about the cramps and told the doctor that she was late this month. Doctor asked Aadi to wait there and took Kavya inside for a check-up.

He performed a routine urine test and then went for a scan. After about 15 minutes, the doctor came out with Kavya and made them both sit.

"Well, as of now these tests show that she is not pregnant. Periods delay can be simply because of high stress levels or hormonal imbalance, changed lifestyle… There can be many reasons and there is nothing to worry in that case."

"Oh," they both said, almost disappointed.

"These tests are not hundred percent accurate though. There are a few occasions when the cases turn positive later. However, it's very rare…"

They both were quiet and nodded.

The doctor laughed. "Look at your faces. Cheer up, guys!"

Aadi smiled, "Yes doctor. Does she need any medication?"

"I don't feel the need. Let us wait for another week, then we will see."

They left from the clinic and got into the car. Both of them were extremely silent.

"Kavya…" Aadi broke the silence.

"Hmmm…"

"Do you think we should plan a child now?"

"I don't know, Aadi. Till yesterday I was scared with the very thought of having a child, but today, when the doctor said I…" tears started rolling her eyes. Aadi pulled the car off the road.

"Hey… please don't cry, baby. We were being cautious most of the time. That's why. If you want a child, we can plan one."

"Do you want a child?

"It's exactly the same wave of emotions I am going through right now. Let us not jump to conclusions. Let us both think about it today and discuss it at night, okay?"

Kavya nodded in agreement.

"It will be convenient too, we can immediately take action if we both want to plan a child," Aadi said winking and Kavya blushed.

"That's my girl. Don't take the stress of such small things, baby. We have the whole life ahead to have kids."

Aditya called Jatin in his cabin and asked him to tap the status of all 3 of them. They both got engrossed in work and completely forgot the morning episode of the doctor. Kavya skipped her meal and worked till late evening. Aditya had a few outstation meetings the next day, so she got into preparations of the same. Aadi got flights booked for both of them. They both needed a break so he decided to extend the stay by 2-3 days post meetings.

They left from the office late evening when Kavya asked him.

"Why did you book it for me? I don't know this client."

"Then you will get to know them now," Aadi said simply. "Also, I thought it's time for our second honeymoon. I am hoping you will say 'yes' for a child, so we can make great use of this second honeymoon."

Kavya blushed hard with the thought of honeymoon and looked down. She just nodded saying 'yes'.

"Is that 'yes' for the honeymoon or the baby?"

"Both," she said, looking out of the window.

"Look at me and say it, baby."

"Aadi, are you sure about this?"

"As sure as I wanted to marry you."

She hugged his hand and he took her in his embrace kissing her forehead.

They both went back and packed the bags.

"Kavya…"

"Hmmm?"

"You remember that black dress you had tried before our marriage?"

Kavya smiled at the memory. "Yes."

"Did you buy that? You never wore it."

"Yes, I bought it."

"Then pack that along."

Kavya blushed and nodded. Aadi kept the bag aside and sat on the sofa in front of Kavya. "Maybe I can teach you a couple of more things on this honeymoon," Aadi said winking. Kavya was so shy, she simply gave up packing and tried running away. Aadi laughed and pulled her next to him. He kissed her nose. "Do you know, you are very cute?"

She pouted. "Just cute?"

"Oh God!" And he kissed her.

Both Aditya and Kavya wound up the meetings in the first 2 days and had a whole week by themselves. They explored many places together and forgot all the worries. Towards the end of the trip, Kavya got her periods. She was sad again.

"The doctor had told us these tests are not hundred percent accurate. I had some hopes," she said looking at her hands.

"Baby, you need to chill a bit. Now that we both are sure about it, it's gonna happen soon. We, anyway, barely manage to keep hands off each other, isn't it?"

Kavya blushed at his comment and looked down.

"So, another four days, and be ready for a lot of action, baby."

"Aadi…" she pushed him a bit and Aadi exaggerated it and fell down on the floor.

"Ouch! Kavya, you hit so hard," and she started giggling.

"Mr. overacting, come up…" she gave him a hand and he pulled her down on top of him instead.

"Aadi…" she said feeling shy.

"I have observed, Manu, you always feel shy when you are on top. We will try it for sure."

"Aadi…" she smacked him on the shoulder. "You don't have any filters when you talk." She quickly got up and Aadi started laughing.

"Of course, why should I have filters while talking to my wife? By the way, what's your favorite position?"

She literally ran out of the room and went to the balcony out of embarrassment. Aadi chuckled looking at her.

After coming back, Jatin gave a full download to Aditya about the whereabouts of Esha, Gokhle, and Das. There was nothing suspicious. However, Esha and Gokhle were in constant touch and Esha was in Mumbai.

"She must be trying for a job there."

"Maybe…" Aadi said. "Does she have any connect there?"

"Not that I know of."

"Check if she has applied anywhere. I need info of her in detail."

Kavya was picking up work very fast. She got a hang on Esha's routine quickly. Aditya hired a PA to Kavya for help on the routine day-to-day coordination to ensure she can focus on more important tasks. Kavya started a new department in the company as Business Intelligence. She hired experts from various domains and even a few different industries. These people were responsible to keep Aditya updated about the latest trends, practices, and technology of their respective industries. They all were young but toppers from B-schools and were chosen very carefully.

Today was the first formal presentation of the new team members as they had completed the first month in the system. Their first task was the same which was assigned to Kavya. Study the company's current system and suggest improvement areas. Kavya and Aditya finished meeting with Yellow brand team and joined BI team in the conference room.

Presentations started and the complete core team started taking notes and discussing points they raised. Kavya's phone buzzed, "*I am back honey… It is payback time!*" Kavya was extremely scared seeing that message. Aditya saw her and asked her with eyes, "What happened?" She showed him the phone. "Who could this be?" she asked him with a trembling voice. Aditya realized something and immediately got up. Watching him, everyone in the room got up.

"Excuse me, ladies and gentlemen. Apologies for an end-moment change, but we will have to postpone this meeting. I have some business exigency."

Kavya got up with him and started walking behind him. He turned and asked Jatin to join him in his cabin.

Kavya, Jatin, and Aadi reached his cabin. As soon as they entered, Aditya asked, "What is the status of Prakash's case?"

"Oh!" Kavya realized who was texting and landed in tears.

"Don't cry, baby… I am there. He cannot harm you," Aadi said, holding her hand tightly.

Jatin raised his eyebrows and asked, "What happened?" Aadi showed him the phone.

"Give me ten minutes. Let me check with our legal team."

Jatin went out of the cabin almost running.

Kavya's phone buzzed again, this time it was from a different number. "You look so good in today's peach outfit." Kavya saw that and started crying.

"Aadi, he is in town…"

Aadi tried consoling her, but before he could say anything, Kavya fainted.

When she got up, she was in the doctor's clinic with Aditya sitting next to her.

"What happened? How come I am here?"

Aditya smiled and hugged her, overwhelmed with emotions.

"I love you," he whispered.

"What happened, Aadi?"

"Baby, we are going to be parents!" Kavya hugged him back with tears in her eyes. "Are you sure? I mean… are we sure?"

Aditya laughed. "Yes, I am sure. Just got the confirmation from the doctor."

She blushed and looked down. "Mom and dad know?"

"No, but they will be here any moment. We will tell them together."

"No, please… you tell them. I feel shy."

Aadi pulled her face up and kissed her forehead. "As you say, my princess."

Shiv and Rashmi came running to the hospital on the news that Kavya had fainted.

As soon as they entered, Aadi went and hugged his father. Rashmi got confused and walked towards Kavya.

'What happened, beta?"

Kavya was too shy to say anything. She just hugged Rashmi.

Aditya told Shiv and they both almost started dancing on the news. Rashmi realized and pulled Kavya out of her embrace.

She looked at Kavya. "Good news?" Kavya looked down blushing. She just nodded. "Oh, Kavya! I can't explain to you how happy I am today," Rashmi said kissing her forehead.

"Let me call Kavita and Sandhya."

Kavya's phone buzzed again, Aditya had kept her phone with himself. He checked the message. "Congratulations, my love. Now let's see how far you manage to keep the child."

Aadi cursed under his breath looking at that message.

"What happened, Aadi? Where is Prakash?" Kavya said, remembering what had happened before she fainted.

"You don't need to think or worry about anything, Kavya. I am there, I will handle everything. Do you trust me?"

She nodded.

"Then just forget all this, okay?"

"What happened, Aadi?" Shiv asked. "Dad…" Before he could say anything ahead, Jatin came there.

"Boss, there is one bad news…"

"What happened?"

"Prakash got bail."

"Who sponsored it?"

"Esha…"

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